

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 24 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

STATE CEO WRITES TO ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

Maharashtra top poll officer wants ECINet discretion for local staff — a demand the two ECs had flagged

For SIR notice process, seeks 4 changes in EC portal software, more options for EROs

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, September 28

THE CHIEF Electoral Officer of Maharashtra, the largest state now in the notice phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), wrote to the Election Commission of India (ECI) in New Delhi last week, seeking four changes to the ECINet soft-

ware, each, in effect, a request that the software let Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) exercise a discretion the law already gives them, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Maharashtra CEO S Chockalingam's requests that EROs be allowed to decide which "logical discrepancy" cases need a hearing, what docu-



Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer S Chockalingam

ments to accept and which discrepancies they can dispose of themselves, echo concerns already recorded by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh

THE EDITORIAL PAGE
CEC MUST CORRECT COURSE, NOT JUST DO DAMAGE CONTROL **P14**

Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

The CEO's communication, addressed to Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, Director General of IT Seema Khanna and two secretariat officers, went out on September 24, a day after an investigation by *The Indian Express* revealed that the two

Election Commissioners had flagged, on record, that the software was curtailing the powers of the EROs.

CEO Chockalingam could not be reached for comment Monday. *The Indian Express* sent a questionnaire to the ECI spokesperson who acknowledged receipt. A response is awaited.

The Maharashtra draft roll, published August 31, left out 21.1 per cent of the state's electors. Its final roll is due on

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

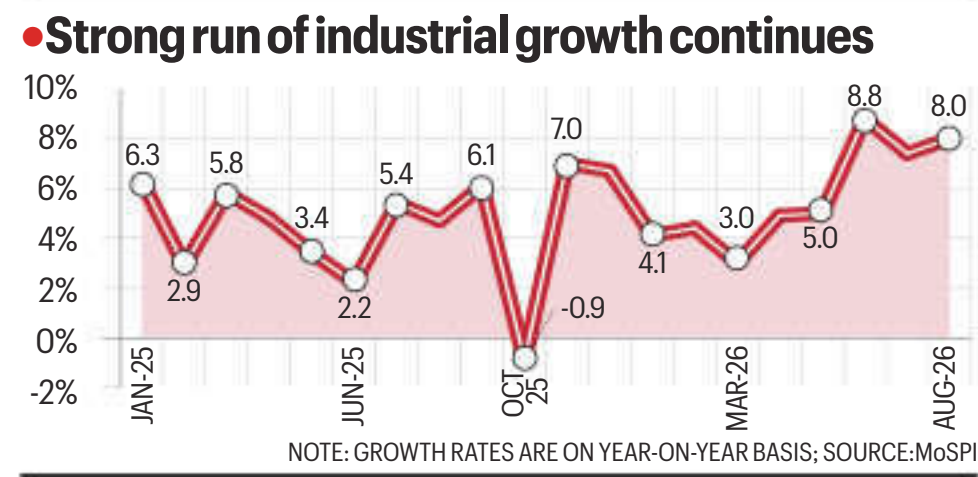
ALL EYES ON FESTIVAL SEASON DEMAND

Industrial output up 8% in August, FMCG a slow spot

Manufacturing, favourable base effect behind strong IIP growth

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 28

THE INDIAN economy continued its impressive run with data released Monday by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation showing industrial production in August was 8% higher compared to the same month last year. The overall growth was driven by a favourable base effect and the manufacturing



sector whose output rose 9%.

Policymakers, however, will keep an eye on the consumer goods segment.

While production of durable goods rose 11.1% in August, following up a 12% increase in July, non-durable goods, which are primarily fast-moving con-

sumer products or FMCG, saw a growth of only 2.1%.

Rajani Sinha, Chief Economist at CareEdge Ratings, said the overall strong industrial performance was in line with other data such as GDP growth, lending and exports, indicating

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

• **THE NAVY** Commanders' Conference begins in New Delhi. The Naval leadership will review operational preparedness and contribution to safeguarding India's maritime interests, including energy security, amid the West Asia conflict.

• **THE JOINT PARLIAMENTARY** Committee on the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 will hold its second meeting.

TRACK THESE AND MORE ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Bengal SIR case: No early hearing, 'only by-elections' ahead, says SC

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

THE SUPREME Court Monday declined to advance the hearing of a plea regarding appeals against the exclusion of names from the West Bengal electoral rolls, pending before the tribunals constituted by it.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge bench, told the petitioner's counsel who cited urgency in view of the upcoming bypolls in Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly constituencies on October 6 that "these are only by-elections".

The counsel told the bench, also comprising Justice Joymya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, that though the case was listed for hearing on September 29, the causelist was now showing it as listed for hearing on October 5.

He contended that the excluded voters in these constituencies had already lost their chance to vote in one election and that they would not be able to vote in the October 6 polls as well if their appeals were not decided urgently.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FORMER TOP COP HAS BEEN AWARDED FOUR YEARS' RIGOROUS IMPRISONMENT

Behind former Kerala DGP's sentencing in graft case, two brothers and a 36-year fight

PAGE 1
anchor

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram,
September 28

AS FORMER Kerala DGP Tomin Thachankary was awarded four years of rigorous imprisonment, and ordered to pay a fine of Rs 30 lakh in a disproportionate-assets (DA) case around 10 days ago, two brothers, in their late 50s and early 60s, closely watched the



Vithya breaks PT Usha's record

Vithya Ramraj celebrates after she clocked 54.75s in the final of the women's 400m hurdles to claim the bronze medal at the Asian Games in Nagoya, Japan, on Monday. She broke PT Usha's national record of 55.42s after 42 years. PTI **REPORT, PAGE 23**

EXPRESS special

In this drought-hit taluka of Maharashtra, monsoon came, but a long dry spell followed

Kharif crops destroyed, fields too dry for rabi crops, say farmers

Sadaf Modak
Sakri (Dhule), September 28

FOR FARMERS in Sakri taluka of Dhule district, this year's drought is not a story of the monsoon failing to arrive. It is about the rains arriving, raising hopes, and then disappearing when the crops needed them the most.

Sakri is among the 265 talukas declared drought-affected by the Maharashtra government last week; the state has a total of



A farmer assesses his damaged crops in Sakri. NARENDRA VASKAR

358 talukas. While the drought-hit areas cover 32 of the total 36 districts, all the four talukas in Dhule district are among the affected areas. The state recorded a rainfall deficit of 18% this year,

with 798.2 mm of rainfall between June 1 and September 26, against a normal of 970.9 mm.

But in Sakri, where the seasonal rainfall was around the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Alexander and Bobby Kuruvi; Keralam ex-DGP Tomin Thachankary

proceedings at the Vigilance court in Kottayam.

Their stoic expressions did not betray their association with the case, and the decades

they spent in pursuing it, but there was still satisfaction of a hard-won battle.

The DA case dates to 2002 but its roots go back 12 years be-

fore that, when Bobby and Alexander Kuruvi were in their 20s. They belonged to Alappuzha's prominent landlord family, Karivelithara, with their ancestors part of the erstwhile Travancore government.

In 1990, Thachankary was posted in their town as an Assistant Superintendent of Police (ASP). He allegedly misused his position to implicate them in a case arising from a minor scuffle involving his distant relative.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



TRUMP ASKED XI IF HE WANTED TO BUY OUR WEAPONS: U.S. ENVOY **PAGE 16**

Sabse Pehle
Life Insurance

New Labour Codes have redefined Employer obligations on Gratuity and Leave Encashment.
Our expertise will ensure the compliance becomes Simple, Reliable, and Future-ready.

Presenting
LIC's GROUP SCHEMES

- New Group Gratuity Cash Accumulation Plan** - UIN: 512N281V04
- New Group Leave Encashment Plan** - UIN: 512N282V04
- New Group Superannuation Cash Accumulation Plan** - UIN: 512N274V03
- Group Post Retirement Medical Benefit Scheme** - UIN: 512N352V01
- Group Benefits Secure Plan** - UIN: 512N367V01

Salient Features:

- Scientific funding
- Attractive Returns
- Benefit of insurance protection
- Income Tax Benefits as per Rules
- Multiple options for annuity payments

For more details, email to groupbusiness@licindia.com or contact your Agent/nearest LIC P&GS unit

Call Centre Services (022) 6827 6827 Visit: www.licindia.in

Follow us : [f](#) [t](#) [v](#) [i](#) [o](#) [i](#) LIC India Forever | IRDAI Regn No.: 512

BEWARE OF SPURIOUS PHONE CALLS AND FICTITIOUS / FRAUDULENT OFFERS. IRDAI or its officials do not involve in any activities of insurance business like selling insurance policies, announcing bonus or investment of premiums, refund of amounts. Policyholders or the prospects receiving such phone calls are requested to lodge a police complaint. For more details on risk factors, terms and conditions, please read sales brochure carefully before concluding a sale.

LIC
भारतीय जीवन बीमा निगम
LIC
Har Pal Aapke Saath

LIC/P/2025-26/36/Eng

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Maharashtra CEO

November 16. A “logical discrepancy” is not a finding that someone is not a voter. It is a mismatch the Commission’s ECINET software throws up when it tries to link an

elector to a parent or grand-parent on the roll from the last SIR, such as a parent’s name that doesn’t match, an age gap between parent and child of under 15 or over 50 years, an age that



भारतीय कंटेनर निगम लिमिटेड
CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
(भारत सरकार का नगरन उपकरण) (A Navaratna Undertaking of Govt. of India)
NSIC New MIDP Building, 3rd Floor, Okhla Ind. Estate (Opp. NSIC Okhla Metro Station), New Delhi-110020

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
CONCOR invites E-Tender in Single Packet System of tendering for the following work:-
Tender No. : CON/EPIA-III/EE-99204/Track works/ICD-TNPM/2026/
Name of Work : CTR for MRL-6 & Allied works on Line NL-1, 2, 3 at ICD-TNPM (Chennai) TN
Estimated Cost : ₹ 287.39 Lakhs (Inclusive all taxes) Completion Period : 10 Months
Earnest Money Deposit : ₹ 5.74,800/- (Rupees Five lakhs Seventy four thousand Eight hundred only) (through e-payment)
Cost of Tender Document : Nil
Tender Processing Fee (Non-refundable) : Rs. 3,540/- (Inclusive all taxes & duties through e-payment)
Date of Sale of Tender (online) : 29.09.2026 (15:00 hrs.) to 19.10.2026 (upto 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of Submission of Tender (online) : 22.10.2026 upto 17:00 hrs.
Date & Time of Opening of Tender (online) : 23.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs.
For financial eligibility criteria, experience with similar nature of work, etc., please refer to detailed tender notice available on website www.concorindia.co.in, but the complete tender document can be downloaded from website www.tenderwizard.com/CCLIL only. Further, Corrigendum/Addendum to this tender, if any, will be published on website www.concorindia.co.in and www.tenderwizard.com/CCLIL and Central Procurement Portal (CPP) only. Newspaper press advertisement shall not be issued for the same.
Group General Manager (P&S)/Area-III
Phone No.: 011-41222500



Petronet LNG Limited

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT) FOR SELECTION OF CONTRACTOR FOR ARC FOR CIVIL MAINTENANCE WORKS FOR A PERIOD OF TWO YEARS AT PETRONET LNG LIMITED, DAHEJ
Interested parties are requested to visit our website www.petronetlng.in for detailed eligibility criteria along with other necessary details for issuance of Tender document.
Note: PLL reserves the right not to issue the tender document and / or accept or reject any or all the bids at any stage of the process and/or modify the process without assigning any reasons on its sole discretion. No separate notification shall be issued in press. Bidders are requested to visit the website regularly to keep themselves updated.
Sr. Manager (C&P)
PETRONET LNG LIMITED
GIDC Industrial Estate, Plot No. 7/A, Dahej, Taluka Vagra, Distt. Bharuch 392130, Dahej, Gujarat, Tel No: 02641-670232/233/235/231
E-mail id:- c&p_dahej@petronetlng.in, sumitkumar@petronetlng.in



JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

No.: JDA/EE(Garden-1)/2026/D-497 Date : 28.09.2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB NO: JDA/EE (Garden-1)/07/2026-27
Online Bids are invited up-to 06:00 PM of 26.10.2026 for
"Development of Royal Happiness Park in Ram Niwas Bagh Area under Garden-1, JDA, Jaipur". The last date for Applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up-to 06:00 PM of 26.10.2026. The estimated cost of NIB is Rs.1228.92 Lakh. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in/jda
UBN No. : JDA2627WLOB00335
To participate in the bid, bidder must:
A. Participate in Tender & Deposit Payment on 'Online Tender Participation' Portal of JDA at <https://jda.rajasthan.gov.in/jda> or by Single-Sign-On at <http://service.jaipurjda.org>.
B. Submit e-Bid on 'e-Procurement Portal' of GOR at www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10868 Executive Engineer (Garden-I)



JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

No.: JDA/EE(Garden-I)/2026/D-496 Date : 28.09.2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB NO: JDA/EE (Garden-I)/06/2026-27
Online Bids are invited up-to 06:00 PM of 26.10.2026 for
"Development of Rajasthan Utsav Park (Waste-to-Wonder) in Ram Niwas Bagh Area under Garden-1, JDA, Jaipur". The last date for Applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up-to 06:00 PM of 26.10.2026. The estimated cost of NIB is Rs.2287.26 Lakh. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in
UBN No. : JDA2627WLOB00333
To participate in the bid, bidder must:
A. Participate in Tender & Deposit Payment on 'Online Tender Participation' Portal of JDA at <https://jda.rajasthan.gov.in/jda> or by Single-Sign-On at <http://service.jaipurjda.org>.
B. Submit e-Bid on 'e-Procurement Portal' of GOR at www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10867 Executive Engineer (Garden-I)



JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

JDA/IT/15654594/ITMS/2026-445587-9701198-Part File(3)-9851156/D-839 तिथि :- 28.09.2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No.: JDA-IT-10-2026-27
Online Bids are invited up-to 3:00 PM of 06.11.2026 for
"Request for Proposal for Selection of Master System Integrator (MSI) to Design, Implement, Integrate, Operate and Maintain Intelligent Traffic Management System (ITMS) and Adaptive Traffic Control System (ATCS) for a duration of 10 years". The last date for Applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up-to 5:00 PM of 05.11.2026. The estimated cost of NIB is Rs. 350.00 Crore. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and <https://jda.rajasthan.gov.in> **UBN No:- JDA2627SLOB00337**
To participate in the bid, bidder must:
A. Participate in Tender & Deposit Payment on 'Online Tender Participation' Portal of JDA at <https://jda.rajasthan.gov.in/jda> or through Single-Sign-on Rajasthan
B. Submit e-Bid on 'e-Procurement Portal' of GOR at www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10871 System Analyst (Procuring Entity)

doesn't progress correctly between the old roll and the new, or a case where the elector submitted no document, or only Aadhaar.

As reported by *The Indian Express*, Sandhu wrote on August 14 that CEOs, DEOs and EROs, the statutory authorities for the voters' list, were reporting they could not perform their duties, their powers “curtailed by centralised control of ERONet at DG(IT) level.” “It is strange,” he said, “that all the responsibilities regarding Electoral Roll lie on EROs, DEOs and CEOs as per law, but the access control has been centralised by DG(IT).”

The Maharashtra CEO's communication of September 24, in effect, asked for the same freedom the two commissioners said ECINET had curtailed: four places where the law gives the ERO a decision to make and the software gives him no way to make it.

Hearings: The rules give the ERO “the discretion to require” a person “to appear personally before him,” the CEO wrote. ECINET's “Take Action” menu has two options, and neither lets the ERO waive a hearing. He asked for a third, “Exempted from Hearing,” for electors who submit “valid and satisfactory documents,” so that senior citizens, the disabled and “other vulnerable groups” are spared “unnecessary inconvenience and apprehension.”

Documents: The 13 documents listed on the back of the notice are “indicative and not exhaustive,” the CEO wrote, and asked for a 14th option, “Other/Other Equivalent Document,” because electors from tribal, homeless and sex-worker

communities “may not able to provide any document from the indicative list”. He said relevant provisions for such groups in the Election Commission's Electoral Roll Manual could be taken into consideration.

Who decides: At present, BLO statements or panchnamas are considered sufficient for EROs to decide certain name-related logical discrepancies. For other discrepancies, supporting documents are required and are subsequently verified at the DEO level. The CEO proposed allowing EROs to dispose of all categories of logical discrepancies at their level wherever they are satisfied that a BLO statement or panchnama provides sufficient grounds. If the discrepancy cannot be satisfactorily resolved on that basis alone, the elector may be asked to submit supporting documents for verification at the DEO level, the email states. The CEO also said documents required to resolve a discrepancy should not necessarily be restricted to the 13 documents in the indicative list.

A mandatory upload: The ECINET currently requires an “Extract of Last SIR” to be uploaded in every discrepancy case.

The CEO proposed making this optional, requiring it only where the last SIR details in the system differ from the correct mapping being claimed or established by the elector.

Written instructions: The EROs “have number of queries” about the process, the CEO said, and “oral instructions from ECI or CEO are insufficient”. He asked for FAQs explaining the notice, document submission, hearing and disposal process to

provide clarity to electors and officials.

Four of the five are the same request in different clothes: the law gives the ERO a judgement to make, and the software does not give the ERO the button to make it.

The Representation of the People Act, 1950 and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 assign responsibility for the electoral roll to the Electoral Registration Officer, one for each Assembly seat.

An ERO is usually the sub-divisional magistrate or an officer of equivalent rank in the district administration. The ERO prepares the voters' list, hears claims and objections and decides which names will stay and which get deleted. This is a deliberately decentralised system. For decades, the ECI has leaned on that design to answer political allegations of mass manipulation of electoral rolls. No single person is supposed to control the voters' list.

On paper, the ERO still decides every name on the list. In practice, the ERO has been able to do only what the software allows: add a name, delete one, reverse a decision or process an appeal. What the software allows is controlled centrally by Khanna's division in New Delhi.

On September 23, in its first response to *The Indian Express* investigation, the Commission had said its digital platforms “operate under strict data security protocols to prevent unauthorised tampering,” and that EROs and DEOs “function as per statutory powers for registration and deletion under law”. The Maharashtra CEO's communication went out a day later.

On September 26, after a meeting of the full Commission, the Commission issued a state-

ment that partially addressed the Maharashtra requests, giving EROs the discretion to exempt people flagged for logical discrepancies from personal hearings. It also said “various upgradations of the portal have already been made based on the inputs from State CEOs in the past few months,” and that “in case any further flexibility is required by the field officers, that will be made operational”.

The four-page note announced eight other decisions that addressed, point by point, several of the concerns recorded by the two Commissioners. Agendas will now be circulated before every Commission meeting and minutes issued afterwards. Officers' foreign trips will need Commission approval. New IT modules and portals will go through a committee of officers before being placed before the Commission. The ECINET will be reviewed by a committee headed by a senior Deputy Election Commissioner and will include an independent expert from an IIT or IIIT. If field officers need more flexibility in the system, it will be provided. And directions issued by Commissioners to officers will be “meticulously complied with”.

These decisions map, almost item for item, onto the concerns the two Commissioners had put on file over 10 months: that agendas were not circulated and minutes not issued, that officers went abroad without the Commission's approval, that new IT modules were built without its knowledge, that the electoral-roll database needed an audit by an independent expert, that field officers lacked “proper and complete access” to ERONet, and that an administrative order had altered the allocation of work around the IT division without them.

five-year extension for Executive Chairman N Chandrasekaran, alongside a pivotal decision to pursue a public listing to comply with RBI mandates, despite opposition from Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata.

As recently as 2004, the group's tech firm, Tata Consultancy Services, was a business division of TSPIL before it was demerged into a separate subsidiary. This was also the case with other operating businesses of TSPL. “Accordingly, the proposed reorganisation will result in TSPL reverting to its previous operating model, with its own operations and revenues, in addition to being a holding company for the Tata Group,” officials said.

This will also be in line with

the previous classification (after 2004) by RBI of TSPL as a “non-banking, non-financial company”. The amalgamated entity, arising out of the merger of TESS and TCE with TSPL, would have an operating revenue of Rs 105,043 crore, far in excess of its income from financial assets (Rs 40,072 crore), constituting 64.3% of the total income of the amalgamated entity.

This will not meet the “principal business criteria” of an NBFC, and will also not meet the conditions applicable to a CIC (assets aggregating Rs 200,158 crore, of which investment in group companies will be Rs 177,120 crore, representing less than 90% of the aggregate net assets of the resultant entity), Tata Trusts said.

Tatas

its 100-year existence, always had operating businesses and operating revenues, which enabled it to fund its other, newer business ventures,” they said.

Tata Trusts have asked the Tata Sons board to consider and approve the proposal and take all necessary steps, including approaching the RBI for the required no-objection certificate (NOC), for the proposed merger and reorganisation. The proposal comes at a critical juncture for Tata Sons. The RBI had rejected the company's request to be de-registered as an upper-layer NBFC, effectively keeping alive the regulatory requirement for its listing.

Tata Trusts, which collectively hold 66 per cent stake in Tata Sons, the holding company of the \$180 billion Tata conglomerate, are now seeking to change the underlying structure of the company rather than proceed with a listing in its existing form. The proposed merger would bring two operating businesses directly under Tata Sons, strengthening its operating-business character and potentially changing the regulatory classification of the reorganised entity. The proposal now rests with the Tata Sons board and, ultimately, the RBI, whose approval will be required for the proposed restructuring.

On September 17, in a dramatic shift of trajectory, the Tata Sons board approved a fresh

Keralam

Pursuing action against the officer, who went on to have a storied career, they learnt about his allegedly ill-gotten wealth, finally getting the Vigilance department to register a case. Though the officer allegedly tried to drag the case for years, the brother continued pursuing it, making sure he was eventually brought to justice.

A minor scuffle, its consequences

“I was 22. There was a minor scuffle with a neighbour...” said Bobby as he recounted the events of September 13, 1990.

The neighbour was a distant relative of Thachankary and his family took the matter up with the officer. “He asked his relative to file a complaint not only against me but also my father Kuruvila and elder brother Alexander,” Bobby said.

The FIR alleged that they stormed into the house of the complainant and manhandled him. “The scuffle had taken place at our house, not his,” Bobby told *The Indian Express*.

Bobby, Alexander and Kuruvila secured bail from a local court but police added another charge: That they had threatened the complainant at gunpoint. Sections of the Arms Act were invoked and the court cancelled their bail.

The trio went into hiding. “Police threatened our mother. They did not spare the premises of our sister, who was pregnant,” said 63-year-old Alexander.

Weeks later, the father and the two sons obtained pre-arrest bail.

But for Bobby and Alexander, this was not the time to rest.

They moved the police department to complain against Thachankary. When it yielded nothing, the family filed a private complaint with a local court, accusing Thachankary of

fabricating a case against them. The magistrate court ordered a probe against the officer. But, Thachankary moved the high court; proceedings at the magistrate court were quashed.

As Thachankary climbed up the career ladder, the brothers realised they would have to change tactics. “We began meeting people who may have faced his high-handedness,” said Bobby. This is when they stumbled upon Thachankary's huge wealth.

In 2002, Bobby approached the Vigilance, alleging that Thachankary had amassed wealth disproportionate to his known source of income.

When no FIR was registered, Bobby approached the HC in 2005; the next year, the Vigilance informed the court the probe would be completed within six months.

As Vigilance continued dragging its feet, Bobby approached then Chief Minister V S Achuthanandan, which finally led to

registration of an FIR in 2007.

The Vigilance probe covered the alleged wealth amassment by Thachankary between 2003 and 2007. With the probe not making much progress, Bobby approached the HC in 2010, filing a contempt of court petition against the department. The petition was closed with the Vigilance telling the court the probe was on.

In 2013, the Vigilance filed the final report in the special court in Thrissur, stating that Thachankary was found in possession of pecuniary resources and properties to the extent of Rs 64 lakh, disproportionate to his known sources of income.

Meanwhile, the case was transferred from Thrissur to Muvattupuzha in Ernakulam district in 2016.

When the trial did not commence, Bobby petitioned the HC Chief Justice in 2017. In 2018, he petitioned another HC judge with jurisdictional supervisory charge over the special court in

IIP growth

Explained

Encouraging data

that the economy had “held up well” despite persistent global uncertainties and elevated energy prices. While the performance of consumer durables, Sinha said, continued to be a positive for consumption, “the feeble performance of consumer non-durables remains concerning”.

Consumer durables and non-durables are key indicators of household demand. And while production of durables is strong, analysts have been sounding caution ahead of the festival season, which sees Indians splurging on new purchases. But with prices of consumer electronics rising for a variety of reasons — significantly more expensive memory chips and other key inputs such as copper and aluminium as well as increasing freight costs — demand may face headwinds.

However, Indians are seen relying on loans to make purchases, with UBS analysts predicting last week that India is entering a “strong unsecured credit growth cycle, led by personal loans”. Latest data from the Reserve Bank of India shows that while personal loans given by banks were up 16.2% as of the end of July, those given by non-banks were up 21.4%.

Industrial growth as per the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) was 7.4% in July and 4.7% in August 2026. The IIP comprises four key sectors, with manufacturing accounting for three-fourths of the entire index.

The August industrial growth print of 8% is the latest in a series of robust economic numbers, with June having posted an expansion of 8.8%, the highest since 19% in March 2024. So far in the first five months of 2026-27, or April-August 2026, industrial growth has averaged 6.7%, well above 4.2% in the same period of 2025-26.

Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda, said, “If this is maintained, India can register growth of 7-8% for the year on the back of higher growth during the festival season with demand building up. This makes the third quarter very critical for industry.”

A favourable base effect usually occurs when output either stagnated or fell in the year-ago month which is used to calculate the growth rate for the latest month. As such, this favourable base meant the year-

Encouraging data

After a faster-than-expected GDP growth of 7.8% in April-June, despite headwinds from the West Asia conflict, the monthly data continues to be encouraging. The festive season will be a key gauge of demand, with the weak monsoon and rising prices seen as drags on consumption.

on-year growth rates in August 2026 for industrial output as a whole and the manufacturing sector were impressive even though production was down compared to July 2026: manufacturing output was down 1.4%, while overall industrial production was 1.8% lower.

According to Rahul Agrawal, Principal Economist at ratings agency ICRA, the favourable base effect in August 2026 was because of ‘inventory recalibration’ in August 2025 ahead of the widely-expected cuts in the GST rates, that were announced by the GST Council in early September 2025 and came into effect later that month.

Within the manufacturing sector, 18 of the 23 categories posted higher year-on-year growth in their output in August. According to Devendra Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings & Research, this underlined “generalised improvement”.

“Like previous months, electrical equipment and motor vehicles continued to record strong growth of 30.9% and 25.2%, respectively,” Pant said, adding that the former's performance was indicative of “growing domestic and external demand for Indian manufactured electrical goods.”

The sharpest sectoral month-on-month fall in August was for mining and quarrying, whose output slumped 9.2% from July. Mining and quarrying, which accounts for over a tenth of the IIP, usually suffers during the monsoon as rain hinders mining activity. On a year-on-year basis, mining and quarrying output was down 5.6% in August.

A favourable base also helped push up the output of the ‘electricity and gas supply’ sector to 12.3% in August, although it was the only sector to post a sequential improvement in production. However, this month-on-month output increase was a mere 0.3%.

six months.

Meanwhile, in 2023, Thachankary retired from service.

Thachankary is presently lodged in central prison in Thiruvananthapuram and has appealed the trial court verdict in HC. The HC has reserved its verdict on his plea.

Alexander is still unsure if Bobby's fight with Thachankary's relative was the only reason why the officer went after his family. “He must have heard about the Karivelithara family. After getting khaki (uniform), he might have thought about taking on our prominent family by implicating us in a false case to gain attention,” said Alexander.

Bobby and Alexander's granduncle Karivelithara Mathew Korah, a Congress leader, had been a minister in the Travancore government. He had served as a member of Travancore Legislative Council as well as the Travancore-Cochin Assembly before the formation of Kerala.

abruptly stopped. I remember the last shower was a weak drizzle, not enough to seep into the soil. Now, we have to see the crops burning in the sun,” said Nimbabai Brahmane, 65, a farmer from Khorli village.

Brahmane's two-acre farm had groundnut, cotton and bajra. The groundnut crop had reached the pod development stage when the rains stopped. Pulling out a plant from the soil, she showed the underdeveloped seeds inside. The crop, she said, is neither fit for consumption nor sale. If left to dry further, it may not even be useful as cattle fodder.

Farmers in Khorli and neighbouring Jamade, Lagadwal, Petale and Panhalipada villages are facing similar losses. The region is largely hilly, with limited irrigation facilities. The main crops grown here are maize, soybean, groundnut, bajra, onion, cotton, pulses and nagli. Most farmers sowed in the first and second weeks of June, after the onset of monsoon raised hopes of a normal season.

Most of the farmers belong to tribal communities, includ-

ing Bhil, Kokna, Gamit, Naikda and Pardhi. Many have cultivated forest land for generations. They were part of the 2018 march to Mumbai and the 2023 march to Nashik, seeking recognition of their forest rights and compensation during droughts, under the Satyashodhak Shetkari Sabha.

Now, they are not only worried about crop losses, but also about whether they will be able to access the relief announced by the government, in view of their pending claims for individual forest rights.

“In 2019, a Government Resolution had announced that relief will also be granted to those with pending claims for individual titles. But our taluka did not get any compensation. We hope that we are included this year and the relief is given,” said Mansaram Pawar of Khorli.

Besides affecting their kharif crops, farmers pointed out that the prolonged dry spell has left their fields without enough moisture for the rabi season.

“This would mean getting out of two cycles of debt. Most of us with small land holdings put

everything we had from the previous season in the kharif crops, and have nothing left,” said Ramlal Gawli, 60, of Lagadwal. He said it brought back memories of the 1972 drought, recalling how his father recounted that families had to depend on wild plants for food.

Bansi Pawar, 75, another farmer, said this year's drought appeared harsher because farmers had invested their savings after the early rains raised hopes of a good crop.

The distress extends into neighbouring Jalgaon district, where 15 talukas have been declared drought-hit. In Erandol, 72-year-old Shaligram Gaikwad, too, recalled the 1972 drought, saying families had to depend on red jowar and American wheat.

This year, the maize crop on his 12 acres has been destroyed. Gaikwad has now sowed onions, using water from a well where the level is steadily falling. Farmers in the region are trying to use available irrigation and drip systems to salvage something from the season, but the investment carries the risk of another crop failure.

SLAPPING ROW

Minister faces non-cognizable report, FIR against AAP MLA

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

A DAY after Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh allegedly slapped an AAP worker during an inspection of a newly constructed road in West Delhi's Tilak Nagar, police have registered a non-cognizable report (NCR) for voluntarily causing hurt against the Minister. They have also filed an FIR against AAP MLA Jarnail Singh for allegedly obstructing government work, based on a complaint filed by a PWD assistant engineer.

An NCR is filed for minor offences and police require permission from the court to conduct an investigation. It is different from an FIR, registered for offences where the police can directly conduct a probe.

According to police sources, two local BJP workers Monday filed separate complaints against Jarnail and his supporters for allegedly misbehaving with the Minister during the inspection.

On Sunday, two complaints were filed against the AAP MLA by the PWD and the contractor entrusted with constructing the road. In both complaints, Jarnail was accused of allegedly obstructing officials from discharging their duties and allegedly threatening, coercing and demanding money from contractors at the work site.

Sahib Singh, the 22-year-old man who was allegedly slapped by the Minister, also filed a complaint against the latter, alleging that he was slapped, threatened and abused. All five complaints were filed at Vikaspuri police station.

The incident took place on Sunday afternoon when the Minister visited the Outer Ring Road in Vikaspuri to inspect the construction of a stretch of road.

Rs 15-cr road repair project at centre of political controversy

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 28

EVEN FROM some distance from the Outer Ring Road, commuters can smell the pungent scent of tar and asphalt. Walk a little closer and it is evident that a road has been newly laid. The black tar is still sticky in some places. The long-due repair of the stretch — after nearly 12 years, according to some residents — should have caused cheer among commuters and locals. The road, however, is now at the centre of a political slugfest due to what has been claimed as “poor quality reconstruction”.

AAP leader and Tilak Nagar MLA Jarnail Singh had been raising the issue of “faulty and substandard work” over the past week by posting videos of him lifting portions of the newly-laid stretch.

On Sunday afternoon, during a review visit, Delhi Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh allegedly slapped 22-year-old AAP worker Sahib Singh, accompanied by the MLA, who was streaming a live video during the inspection. The incident drew condemnation from national leaders. Criticising the ruling BJP, Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, said in a post on X that “this is the face of a power that no longer fears the voters”.

The Rs 15.76-crore project at the centre of the controversy is the carpeting and strengthening of a 5.4-km stretch of the Outer Ring Road from Janakpuri District Centre Chowk to the Najafgarh Drain in West Delhi. A hundred metre



AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal addressing the media in New Delhi on Monday. Party leaders Sanjay Singh Party and Jarnail Singh accompanied him. ANI

stretch in front of the Mohan Nagar Gurdwara, where the slap row unfolded, has been recarpeted so far. The old, broken road is visible on either side of that particular stretch, and even on the service lane on the other side of the road.

The PWD Minister has claimed that the work on the service lane is not complete and the recarpeting on that stretch was done quickly at the request of the Gurdwara due to an upcoming celebration.

Residents have mixed views. “Earlier, this road’s condition was very bad. The service lane was ridden with potholes. It is great that this has finally been renovated,” said Brahm Pal Singh, RWA President, Pocket-A Vikaspuri Extension. Ramesh Sharma, a commuter, said, “This road is coming apart one day after being renovated. Imagine how dangerous it could have been if a pothole had appeared.”

However, Parmod Dutt, another local, complained that the stretch was battered for nearly 12 years, and water filled

up the potholes. “It was dangerous for elderly citizens to cross it,” Dutt said.

On Monday, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal visited the site. He was accompanied by Jarnail Singh and Sahib. “I demand that you dismiss this Minister, have him arrested and apologise to the people. Those who have committed corruption should also be sent to jail,” Kejriwal said.

Delhi BJP chief and Union Minister Harsh Mahotra, however, countered the Opposition. “The manner in which Jarnail Singh brought a crowd and created a ruckus during the inspection led to an unfortunate incident. But when senior officials and an MP were assaulted after being called to Kejriwal’s official residence, why did he remain silent?” Mahotra asked, referring to Swati Maliwal.

Meanwhile, commuters and influencers could be seen clicking photos and recording reels in front of the site of the incident on Monday. The crowd and heavy barricading at the spot have been leading to traffic snarls, said locals.

No construction, 50% WFH, double parking fee in Delhi from December 10 to January 20

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 28

A COMPLETE ban will be imposed on all construction-demolition activities from December 10 to January 20 to combat Delhi’s winter pollution, Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said Monday.

The government said that petrol, diesel, and CNG pumps will sell fuel only to vehicles with a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUC) throughout the year. It has announced an enforcement drive against vehicles with invalid PUCs from October 1 across 500 petrol pumps using Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) systems, alongside strict action against end-of-life vehicles.

The Delhi government discussed steps such as restrictions on vehicles, construction activity, office attendance and parking at a high-level meeting on air pollution chaired by Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav at Paryavaran Bhawan. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta attended the meeting along with Sirsa, Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, and other senior officials.

The meeting reviewed major pollution sources in the city, ongoing mitigation measures, and ways to strengthen monitoring. Emphasising a regional airshed approach, Sirsa noted that while Delhi generates around 30% of its pollution, 60%-65% comes from or is influenced by surrounding NCR areas.

The discussions came as the Delhi government prepares to implement a set of restrictions that will come into force annually from November 1 to February 28. As reported by *The Indian Express* on July 2, the



The Indian Express report published on July 2.

restrictions, notified on June 23, will operate parallelly with the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), under which graded curbs are imposed by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) based on the prevailing air quality. Under the new framework, for the first time, several measures will be made mandatory in advance.

Among the measures announced by the government on Monday:

■ **Curbs on entry of vehicles:** Between November 1 and January 31, no non-BS6 vehicle that is registered outside Delhi can enter the Capital. This will not apply to CNG and electric vehicles, emergency services vehicles, and vehicles in other exempt categories.

■ **Staggered office timings:** Between November 1 and January 31, offices of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi will operate from 8.30 am to 5 pm, and Delhi government offices from 10 am to 6.30 pm. Private entities have been advised to adopt staggered working hours and measures such as car-pooling and using common buses to reduce vehicles on the road.

■ **50% WFH:** From November 1 to January 31, government

and private offices are required to ensure no more than 50% physical attendance, with remaining employees working from home or following a two-day-per-week work-from-home model. Essential services, including hospitals, public transport, power, water supply, sanitation, disaster management and pollution-control agencies are exempt.

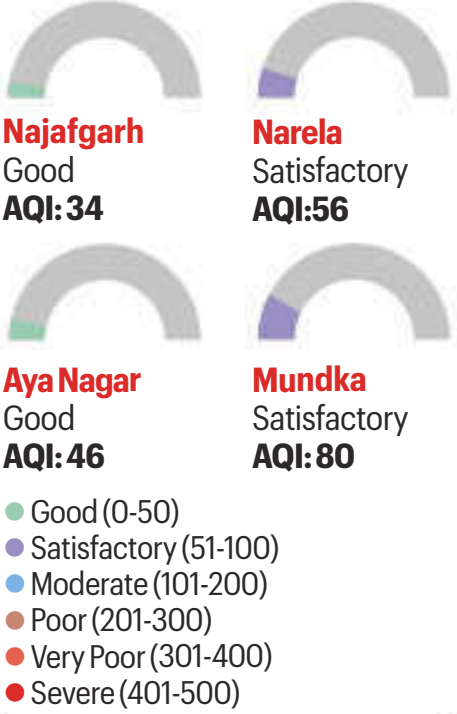
■ **Higher parking fees:** To discourage the use of private vehicles, parking charges at authorised parking sites will be doubled between November 1 and February 28. Parking facilities owned and managed by the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation are exempt. The government also aims to raise daily Metro ridership to 72 lakh and 42 lakh on DTC buses, supported by a fleet of 5,088 electric buses.

■ **Construction curbs:** From November 1 to January 31, dust-generating demolition and open civil construction activities will be prohibited, except for essential public infrastructure projects. Mandatory 100% CCTV web-camera coverage will be enforced across construction sites, and registration on the ‘Malba App’ will be required for building plan approvals. Construction and demolition are banned completely from December 10 to January 20, barring urgent government and emergency works. Vehicles carrying construction material such as sand, stoned, bricks, and cement cannot enter

• Skywatch


Forecast:
September 29, 2026
Partly cloudy sky. No rain.
MAX: 31-33
1.7°C below normal
MIN: 20-22
1.3°C below normal

• AQI Tracker



the city, barring exemptions for projects of national importance, essential public infrastructure, and emergency works.

■ **Other measures:**
● Anti-smog guns, mist systems will be deployed at commercial buildings and construction sites.

● RWAs and housing societies have been asked to act to prevent burning of waste, biomass, garbage and plastic.

● Surveillance and enforcement will be stepped up with an AI-enabled Command and Control Centre, supported by 334 enforcement teams. The Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring Stations network will be expanded.

● In an ongoing crackdown, the government has surveyed 11,271 units, sealing or shutting down 2,283 polluting units.



Think Logistics , Think CONCOR

Seamless End-to-End Logistics across Rail, Road & Sea



Double Stack Container Train on Dedicated Freight Corridor



Specialized Tank Containers for Bulk Cement Loading



Road Transportation through LNG Trucks



Global Shipping Services

Shri Ajit Kumar Panda

Chairman and Managing Director

EXCERPTS FROM CHAIRMAN'S SPEECH AT 38th AGM OF CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.

Held on 28.09.2026

Dear Fellow Shareholders,
Good afternoon and a very warm welcome to each one of you to the 38th Annual General Meeting of your Company. At the outset, I am very happy to state that your company, with its strong performance, continues to retain its position as the undisputed market leader in India's rail logistics sector.

BUSINESS ENVIRONMENT AND ECONOMIC SCENARIO
At present, the World is at the crossroads of extraordinary uncertainties with various geopolitical conflicts and tensions. There is growing tendency of protectionism by nations, lack of trust and weaponisation of trade and supply chain.

On the other hand with the progressive Government policies for inclusive development, rising consumption, disposable income, credit growth, demographics advantage and competitive business environment, our Country is well positioned to face any challenge. The Indian economy has continued to demonstrate remarkable resilience with GDP growth of 7.1% achieved for 2024-25 and an estimate of 7.7% for 2025-26. The GDP growth of 7.8% in the first quarter of the current year establishes that India remains a growth engine for the world economy.

Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi ji has said and I quote "Today, India is the world's fastest-growing major economy. We are in a position to help lift the world out of slow growth."
The progress across several underlying economic indicators like



controlled inflation, strong corporate balance sheets, lower debt levels, political stability and all time low NPAs of banks set India apart from turbulent global markets. India's growth story is steadily transitioning from a consumption-led narrative to one increasingly anchored in manufacturing and industrial capability.

SECTORAL OUTLOOK
The Government's commitment for infrastructure-led growth is continuing with budgetary allocation of Rs. 12.2 lakh crores in 2026-27, including Rs. 2.78 lakh crores for Railways. India's ranking in world logistics performance index has improved from 54 in 2014 to 38 in 2023 and the target is to reach 25 by 2030.

Indian Railways' originating loading of cargo rose to 1,669.9 million tonnes in FY 2025-26, a growth of 3.3% over the previous year, while containerised cargo carried by rail increased to 93.7 million tonnes, up by 5.6%. Container handling across all Indian ports touched 24.8 million TEUs registering healthy growth of 6.5% over the previous year. The most significant development of the year has been the long awaited commissioning of 1506 km long Western DFC. It has enabled movement of Double Stack Container (DSC) trains with higher axle load, faster access of northern hinterland and development of industries and new terminals along the DFC. A new DFC connecting Dankuni in East to Surat in West has been announced in the Budget 2026.

Rate rationalisations have been done for moving bulk cement in tank containers and for fertilizer, fly ash, food grains and salt. A single unified incentive regime for Container Train Operators has been notified. It is estimated that, the per ton km cost of movement of goods by rail is Rs. 1.96 vs 3.78 by road and CO₂ emission per ton km by rail is 11.5 gm vs 101 gm by road. The Dedicated Freight Corridors (DFCs) and

assured transit time trains are moving goods faster now. Thus, rail transportation, when duly supported by conducive infrastructure offers distinct advantages over road in terms of cost, speed and environment and hence it is bound for gaining market share. Your Company continues to place itself firmly at the intersection of above growth drivers deepening its business and creating enduring value for all its stakeholders.

PERFORMANCE HIGHLIGHTS
On the operational front, your Company handled highest ever throughput of 5.58 million TEUs during 2025-26, registering a growth of 9.56% over the previous year. The EXIM growth was 8% and domestic 14.6%. CONCOR's share of containerised cargo carried by rail rose to 51.02 million tonnes, up 2.82% over the previous year. In financial terms, total income was the highest ever at Rs.9,443 crores. The net consolidated profit for the year stood at Rs.1,246 crores. Despite rising competition, it is gratifying that business efficiency has improved resulting in better operating margins.

I am of the firm belief that logistics is a sunrise sector and your company is firmly positioned to capitalize on many emerging business opportunities. To further expand the infrastructure, capital expenditure of Rs.1,085 crores has been incurred during FY 2025-26 on expansion of its terminal network, acquisition of indigenous wagons, containers, handling equipment and expanding IT systems.

Your Company has a strong balance sheet to support its sustainable future growth. At the end of the year, the net worth of the Company was Rs.13,052 crores. In keeping with the consistent policy of rewarding our shareholders, dividend was paid every quarter totalling to Rs.8.6 per shares (i.e. 172%) and amounting to Rs.655 crores, which is 53.6% of net profit.

STRATEGIES AND INITIATIVES
Your Company followed a focused approach and took many business initiatives during the year thereby strengthening its market position:

- New terminals developed at Mandalgarh in Rajasthan, Kadakola in Karnataka & Jajpur and Paradip in Odisha have started contributing to business. The terminals being set up at Salawas in Rajasthan and Charodi in Gujarat on Western DFC will improve double stack running.
- During 2025-26, CONCOR has operated 6,396 Double-stack container trains.
- Double Stack Container Train services have started directly between JNPT and our terminals at Dadri, Khatuwas and Vamama.
- In a significant step towards strengthening Atmanirbhar Bharat in the global logistics landscape, movement of export-import cargo in our own containers to overseas destinations has commenced. The company has developed its Shipping platform issuing Bill of Lading.
- Movement of 9.15 lakh TEUs was done through our own first mile and last mile services which is around 44% of the FMLM potential.
- CONCOR commenced assured transit time train services between Delhi and Kolkata and Bangalore and Delhi.
- Parcel train services commenced between Bhiwandi, Mumbai to Sankrali, Kolkata.
- Aushadhi Express, India's first dedicated refrigerated freight train service was launched to transport temperature-sensitive pharmaceutical cargo from Hyderabad to JNPT.
- Business Solution Services were provided with volumes of 41,030 TEUs during the year. This covers services like customs clearance, fumigation, palletization, lashing, clearance of containers and cargo bound for Bangladesh and Nepal.
- Air cargo business has been operationalised through CONCOR terminals at ICD Dadri and Ludhiana.
- Sonik Goods Shed, near Lucknow is being developed to cater to the burgeoning logistics needs of the Kanpur and Lucknow region.



- CONCOR sourced 79.13% of our procurements from Micro and Small Enterprises.
- The Company continues to be at the forefront of transition to sustainable logistics with 95% of cargo being moved by rail; thereby saving CO₂ emission of around 4 million ton during the year.
- 230 LNG Trucks have been procured and two LNG stations have been established at Dadri and Khatuwas.
- As part of a broader shift toward cleaner, quieter and more efficient yard operations, seven Electric Reach Stackers and two Electric Trucks & Trailers have been commissioned.
- Roof top solar power is being used at Barhi, Dadri and Kanakpura terminals and at the Corporate Office.
- AI/ML based terminal management system has been put at TKD enabling automated yard operations, real-time container tracking and smart rail handling and optimising gate-in/gate-out.
- GPS enabled tracking and predictive analytics is being deployed to improve train planning, container inventory management, faster movement and demand forecasting.

Our strategies and actions on the ground are fully aligned with the nation's vision of developing a world-class logistics ecosystem.

SUBSIDIARIES, JOINT VENTURES AND ALLIANCES
CONCOR has four Subsidiaries and eleven Joint Ventures doing businesses in the fields of sea port operations, last-mile connectivity, container freight stations, air cargo and cold-chain logistics. These entities have consistently contributed to our growth. The contribution of the subsidiaries and Joint Ventures in the profit of the company during the year was Rs.24 crores.

In order to tap huge potential in Shipping and to achieve the vision of the Government, during the year MOU has been signed for setting up Bharat Container Shipping Line (BCSL) in association with the Shipping Corporation of India, three major Port Authorities and Sagarmala Finance Corporation where CONCOR will have 30% share. New alliances for optimal utilization of infrastructure as well as for expansion of business have been made through various MOUs / agreements.

TECHNOLOGY AND STANDARDISATION
All commercial and finance functions of the Company are system driven and are providing real time information for faster decision making. We are at the forefront of adopting new technology for the desired result. Some of our initiatives in this respect include:



- Electronic filing of documents extended to all EXIM terminals.
- Enterprise Dashboard functioning for Rake Monitoring.
- Customer interfaces strengthened through a dedicated web server and mobile app.
- Tools such as Know Your Container Location (KYCL), e-tendering and the First Mile-Last Mile (FMLM) mobile app continue to streamline operations and contribute to ease of doing business.
- Double Stack Loading Plan (DSLP) system has improved train loading leading to higher utilization and reduced rail haulage cost.
- Disaster recovery site and stand by systems at primary sites have been setup for commercial and business sensitive applications.

HUMAN RESOURCE DEVELOPMENT
Doug Conant said and I quote "To win in the marketplace you must first win in the workplace."

Your Company continues to regard its human capital as its greatest strength. The business is run by a lean and committed team of 1,238 CONCORians with a ratio of staff cost to revenue merely 5.73%. Continuous in-house programmes, specialized and on-the-job learning has helped employees strengthen their capabilities and adapt to changing business needs.

CONCOR remains committed to building an inclusive workplace with women in leadership role heading Areas and key functions like banking, HR and terminal operations. The Company continues to invest in the physical and mental well-being of its team through workplace yoga and fitness facilities, participation in marathons and sports events.

CORPORATE GOVERNANCE
Corporate governance, ethics and transparency continue to be deeply embedded in your Company's functioning underpinned by robust internal controls, clear delegation of authority and a strong culture of disclosure and accountability. There are robust systems and procedures in place so as to have efficient management of business and transparency and compliance in all functions.

During the year 2024-25, the Company has been rated "Outstanding" by the Department of Public Enterprises (DPE) on Corporate Governance parameters and in MOU performance it was rated 'Very Good'. The 'AAA' credit rating for the Non-Fund Based Facilities has been reaffirmed by ICRA, reflecting continued confidence in our financial strength and governance standards. On the financial statements for 2025-26 there are no audit qualifications and C&AG of India has issued nil comments.

Your Company's performance and leadership continue to be recognised through several prestigious awards and accolades received during the year.

SUSTAINABILITY AND SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY
Your Company continues to conduct its business in a socially and environmentally responsible manner deepening its adoption of energy-efficient and ecofriendly systems and transportation solutions.

We firmly believe in the principles of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam which teaches us that World is one family and the responsibility to protect our mother earth rests with all of us. We have touched the lives of more than 1.25 million people during the year and spent an amount of Rs.40.59 crore through various CSR programs.

WAY FORWARD
We are working tirelessly to make our country a Viksit Bharat by 2047 coinciding with the centennial of our independence. Our dream is that India will emerge as a leading global power offering its citizens high standards of living and ensuring equitable growth for all. In today's World, a nation of 1.4 billion people is not merely a statistic but a wellspring of skill, ambition and enterprise.

With a strong asset base at present of 68 terminals, 444 rakes, 58,000,

- containers, and 232 LNG/EV trucks and a capable and committed team, your Company is well placed to retain its leadership position in the sector. Today, CONCOR stands stronger, more agile and uniquely placed to capitalize on numerous emerging opportunities in the logistics sector. With our motto of "Think Logistics, Think CONCOR" we remain steadfast in our commitment to innovate, serve with purpose and be a partner in the growth of our country. In our pursuit for relentless growth we shall focus on the following objectives.
- Expanding our terminal network to 100 and count of rakes and containers to 500 & 70,000 respectively.
- Diversification into new business verticals and extensive use of technology.
- Capturing new opportunities arising from the expected growth in EXIM and domestic container volumes with full commissioning of two DFCs.
- Promoting double stack trains and providing end-to-end logistics solutions.
- Rationalization of haulage charges to attract light weight cargo.
- Capturing bulk cement and liquid cargo in tank containers.
- Tapping potential in shipping, air cargo and cold chain logistics.
- Expanding Green Logistics solutions and bouquet of value-added services.
- Operating 100% of FMLM throughput under our own first mile and last mile services.



Scaling up overseas container movement under CONCOR's own Bill of Lading.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT
I acknowledge and appreciate the constructive support extended by the C&AG of India, our Auditors, Ministries of Railways, Shipping, Commerce and Industry, Finance as well as the Customs authorities, various State Governments, JV partners, value-chain partners, customers and regulators.

I extend my deepest appreciation to all shareholders for their continued trust and support and my sincere gratitude to my fellow Board members for their guidance and contributions. My heartfelt thanks are due to Team CONCOR whose sincerity and hard work continue to carry your Company to new heights.

I pray for the well-being of all of us and of our beloved Nation.

Thank You. Jai Hind.

Ajit Kumar Panda
Chairman and Managing Director
(DIN: 08221385)

Note: This does not purport to be a record of the proceedings of the 38th Annual General Meeting of the Company.

CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(CIN: L63011DL1988GOI030915)
Regd. Office & Investor Relations Centre: CONCOR Bhawan, C-3, Mathura Road, Opp. Apollo Hospital, New Delhi-110076
Email: investorrelations@concorindia.com
Website: www.concorindia.co.in, **Phone:** 011-41222500/600/700

‘Painful parallel to Nirbhaya...’: SC on recent rape cases

Top court says the cases raise serious concerns on safety in public spaces

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 28

THE SUPREME Court on Monday took suo motu cognisance of “deeply disturbing” news reports of recent rape cases in Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR), saying they “starkly underline a systemic failure on the part of law enforcement and civil administrative authorities to guarantee basic public safety.”

Taking note of the alleged rape of a minor in August on a sleeper bus, which travelled nearly 47 km from Greater Noida to Old Delhi’s Kashmere Gate, a bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said, “One cannot help but draw painful parallels to the 2012 Nirbhaya case, calling into question whether systemic law enforcement mechanisms have made any meaningful progress in the decade since then.”

The top court referred to the gangrape and assault of a 23-year-old physiotherapy intern in a moving bus in South Delhi on December 16, 2012, which triggered one of the largest spontaneous public protests in India. The woman later died in a hospital in Singapore.

The alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old at Astha Kunj Park in Southeast Delhi by three men posing as policemen on September 21, and another gangrape-murder case from Northwest Delhi earlier this month were among the other incidents that court flagged during the hearing. The court said the incidents “have raised serious concerns regarding the safety and security of public spaces in and around the city” and issued a series of directions for “examining the broader institutional failures” that may have led to the crimes.

It also asked the Delhi High Court to assign the mentioned cases to a designated fast-track special court, and to ensure that the trials are concluded expeditiously, preferably within a year.

As an interim measure, SC asked Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumarto “constitute dedicated police teams for each police district, headed by an officer not below the rank of Deputy Superintendent of Police, to conduct an immediate survey and inspection of vulnerable pockets...drawing up a district-wise vulnerability map and sharing it across adjoining police stations...appropriate patrolling and security arrangements at all identified public parks and vulnerable areas at all times a besides an immediate lighting and CCTV audit, in all public parks and vulnerable zones to eliminate blind spots”.

The interim measures have to be undertaken within four

WHAT SC SAID

● Asks HC to refer the cases to fast-track special court

● Delhi Police chief told to conduct survey of vulnerable pockets

● Suggests series of interim measures for Delhi Police, to be undertaken within four weeks

● Seeks report from authorities on safety measures

weeks, said the bench.

Referring to the South Delhi park gangrape case, the Supreme Court said, it has also brought to light pre-existing complaints of recurrent sexual harassment faced by students of Lady Shri Ram College for Women, situated in the immediate vicinity of Aastha Kunj Park.

“Regrettably, these prior grievances failed to serve as a wake-up call for the police or the local administration to rectify institutional security lapses through enhanced patrolling and vigilance before yet another victim fell prey to unscrupulous perpetrators,” said the bench.

The court said that “the right to live with dignity, free from the fear of violence, is an intrinsic facet of the fundamental guarantee of life and personal liberty enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution. Public spaces, including parks, roads, buses, metro stations, subways, foot bridges, etc. cannot be permitted to become zones of high risk due to grossly inadequate illumination, poor surveillance, lax patrolling, or other preventable administrative deficiencies.”

Even as statements made by public authorities and elected representatives expressing concern over these incidents are understandable, expressions of concern, devoid of accountability, fall short of answering the larger institutional question, said the court. “Expressing solidarity is not the solution to this social evil. What is required is a measurable response, with responsibility and accountability fixed upon the authorities entrusted with prevention of crime, maintenance of public order and protection of vulnerable persons,” said the court.

The court emphasised that “public spaces suffering from inadequate illumination, deficient surveillance, or a lack of visible police patrolling and prompt intervention response mechanisms inevitably expose every citizen to heightened security risks.”

“Where basic measures of public safety remain compromised, no individual, irrespective of age, gender, or sexual identity, can navigate public spaces with a sense of security. The primary obligation of the State...is to maintain public spaces that are safe, accessible...while remaining particularly attentive to the heightened risks faced by children, women and other sexual minorities,” it said.

‘Gen Z not here to make reels, wants to force change’: DU students’ protest for women’s safety intensifies

Third protest in a week, largest so far

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

RAIN, LOUD sloganeering, placards with messages for authorities, and drenched students trying to “force a change”: these were the scenes that unfolded as hundreds of Delhi University (DU) students gathered at the Faculty of Arts on Monday evening for the third and the largest such demonstration in a week, demanding better safety measures for women.

The protest was open “strictly for women and queer participants”, according to organisers.

Last week, similar marches took place near Lady Shri Ram College and Gargi College and Kamala Nehru College after a 17-year-old girl was allegedly gangraped at Aastha Kunj Park in South Delhi.

Giving examples of incidents from Punjab and Bihar, protesters on Monday said that women were not better off even in the Capital as they recounted the challenges they face daily during commute and restrictions they face from families.

Varsha, a second-year student at Shri Ram College of Commerce, kept a track of time during the demonstration. “My father tracks my location continuously. He keeps a check... does not want me to be out once the darkness falls. It’s deeply frustrating... Had I been a son, such severe restrictions would never have existed.”

Clashes at Lovely Professional University (LPU) about 350 km away in Punjab early Sunday, which allegedly prompted an exodus of panicked women hostellers, found resonance at the march on Monday.

“It was only a few days ago that we met over 20 students from LPU at an event in Gurugram... many became friends. When you hear women terrified of stepping out of their hostels there, it feels very personal.



Women students participate in a march from Miranda House to the Faculty of Arts, DU, in New Delhi on Monday. AMIT MEHRA & SOPHIYA MATHEW

lat Ram College, hailing from Uttar Pradesh and living in a PG accommodation, said, “The problem is that our classes were shifted online, but what is the solution to all the crimes? If this massive democracy cannot control its men, what is the solution...confining us to our rooms?”

She added, “Even if I step out at 7 pm to go to a nearby shop, it becomes an issue with parents constantly asking for photos and live locations. It feels like I am the problem. We are not the ones committing the crimes. The administration needs to increase security, fix broken street lights, and educate sons early on.”

Manshi, a Master’s student at Jesus and Mary College

breaking the cage), “*Darr ke aage azaadi* (freedom beyond fear),” and “We should not need a protest to feel safe”, students drew a line at being locked indoors.

A third-year student at Dau-

Gurugram’s groundwater dips to 50m, levels fall at 6 of 7 sites

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurugram, September 28

GURUGRAM IS facing a water paradox: Its groundwater is dipping even as parts of the city continue to flood during the monsoon.

A Central Ground Water Authority (CGWA) report submitted to the Punjab and Haryana High Court shows groundwater levels fell at six of seven urban monitoring points over the past year, with the deepest reading at 50.30 metres below ground (mbgl).

The affidavit was placed before a bench comprising Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and Justice Rohit Kapoor in a long-pending writ petition addressing the city’s unchecked subsoil extraction and environmental degradation.

The court had on September 22 cautioned that the Millennium City faces a progressively “grim” future unless aggressive remedial measures

are taken to halt aquifer depletion and address the recurring paradox of monsoon waterlogging in the city.

Urban water table under stress

According to the data submitted by Vidya Nand, Scientist and Head of Office at the CGWA’s North Western Region office, depth to water level (DTWL) observations across Gurugram Urban during the pre-monsoon seasons of 2025 and 2026 revealed widespread depletion and substantial spatial variation.

Depth to Water Level measures how far down from the ground surface one has to dig or drill before hitting underground water. A higher DTWL number means the water table has dropped deeper, signaling that local groundwater reserves are depleting and getting harder to reach.

Across the urban limits of Gurugram, water levels ranged

● Gurugram’s Water Table

Location	2026 Depth (in mbgl*)	1-Year Fluctuation
Kherki Daula	50.30	–1.10 m
Cell Office	39.30	+1.34 m
Baliawas	32.20	–2.34 m
Karola	25.05	–5.41 m
Khawaspur	32.93	+4.23 m

(DATA SOURCE: CENTRAL GROUND WATER AUTHORITY STATUS REPORT BEFORE PUNJAB & HARYANA HIGH COURT, SEPTEMBER 2026)
*MBGL-METRES BELOW GROUND LEVEL



from 2.5 mbgl to 50.30 mbgl.

Out of seven urban monitoring wells assessed by the agency, four recorded groundwater levels deeper than 20 mbgl. The deepest water level in the urban belt was recorded at Kherki Daula at 50.30 mbgl, the affidavit recorded.

Six monitoring wells also recorded a fall in groundwater levels over the past year. The declines ranged from 0.08 metres to 2.34 metres, with the sharpest

fall recorded at Baliawas. Only one monitoring station at the Cell Office recorded a rise of 1.34 metres. The CGWA informed the court that the integrated findings demonstrate an overall decline in groundwater levels across urban Gurugram, punctuated by only localised pockets of recovery.

Wide variations

Across the wider Gurugram district, data collected by the

Ground Water Cell, Haryana, and the Central Ground Water Board (CGWB) showed groundwater levels ranging from 1.0 mbgl to 50.3 mbgl during the pre-monsoon period in 2026.

In 2025, the range was 1.3 mbgl to 49.6 mbgl during the pre-monsoon period. The deepest level was observed at Tatarpur at 49.6 mbgl, while Kheri Daula recorded the district’s deepest point at 50.3 mbgl.

The data also showed sharp differences between individual locations. The maximum annual water level rise was registered at Khawaspur, where levels improved by approximately 4.23 metres. Conversely, the steepest drop in the district occurred at Karola, where the water table plummeted by 5.41 metres. The authority said the localised declines warranted continued regulatory monitoring and targeted artificial recharge measures.

It also submitted that groundwater regulation within the state is statutory governed by the Haryana Water Resources Authority (HWRA).

HC flags urban paradox

The CGWA report was submitted in compliance with an order issued on August 19 by the HC bench, which has been hearing a cluster of petitions originally filed in 2008 by Sunil Singh and joined by entities such as the Qutab Enclave Residents’ Welfare Association.

The litigation, active for nearly two decades, challenges rapid real estate expansion, including projects such as DLF Cyber City across Sectors 24, 25, and 25A, alleging construction proceeded without commensurate water supply networks, functional drainage, or requisite environmental checks, driving heavy reliance on unmetered private tubewells.

During the September 22 hearing, the bench pointed out Gurugram is caught in a stark urban contradiction: it suffers from dwindling freshwater reserves and subsoil depletion, yet is paralysed every monsoon due to urban inundation because authorities fail to channel storm runoff into subsoil aquifers.

● WHAT BEGAN AS AN INSTAGRAM PAGE FOR OVERWEIGHT DOGS HAS GROWN INTO AN ONLINE COMPETITION, WITH STRANGERS MAKING POSTERS AND RALLYING BEHIND THEIR FAVOURITES

Delhi’s ‘fat dog’ contest brings strangers and their favourite pooches together

Drishti Jain
New Delhi, September 28

GOOGOO LIFTED its left hind leg onto a single brickstep, heaving its 46-kg body up to a blue bowl of water. The dog slipped each time. On the seventh attempt, Googoo finally made it, panting slightly.

For the last two weeks, the mixed-breed brown dog, marked by white patches around its head, has been at Jeevashram Foundation, an animal-care NGO in Delhi’s Rajokri, to lose weight. Its meals are now regulated: 250 grams of dalia for breakfast, three chapatis in milk for lunch, and a few grams of chicken at 4 pm.

But outside the NGO, its size landed it in a very different race. Googoo is competing in an “online election” to find the “fattest dog of Delhi”.

And it has a campaign to match. Supporters made posters and created social media pages. Soon, the contest was no longer confined to Delhi-NCR. People in Kerala and Kolkata too began picking favourites and drumming up support for them.

From 64 contenders, four dogs made it to the semi-finals: Googoo from Saket J Block, Tara Khan aka Khan Saheb at Khan Market, Hero at Malviya Nagar and Gola aka Kebab aka Rajpal Singh at SDA Market in

Hauz Khaz.

Tara and Gola have since passed away, but their supporters have kept them in the running. The results are due on September 29.

The idea grew from an Instagram page started by a final-year DU journalism student after she moved to Delhi. She began posting pictures of overweight dogs she spotted around the city.

“My friends started sharing them. Soon, people were sending pictures of dogs with their names, locations...” she said.

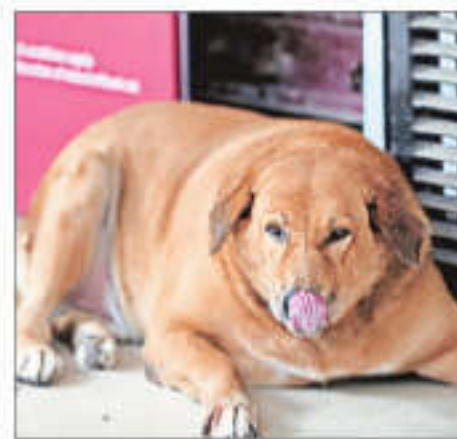
Two weeks ago, she started the contest, taking inspiration from “oomf offs” on X — informal contests where users would put 64 mutual followers up



Googoo and (right) Rambabu. GAJENDRA YADAV

against one another and ask others to vote. “Once I had enough reach, I thought about doing the same with dogs,” she said.

She wants to remain anonymous until the results. “I did not



realise it would grow so big.”

The unlikely stars

On Sunday, Googoo was stretched out at Jeevashram, tongue lolling as it waited for treats. “*Poore din detera ho usko,*

khaate rahega ye (Keep giving it food all day, it’ll keep eating),” said Jagat Singh (51) who looks after the dog, petting its head to make it sit straight.

After lunch, Singh rubbed Googoo’s body, making it shake from side to side. “*Arey khada toh ho le yaar* (Come on, at least stand up, buddy),” he said, lifting the dog.

“We keep doing medical check-ups,” Singh added.

Kabir Wadhawan, who entered Googoo in the competition, first saw the canine in a local park in 2021. “It was less than half this size. Goo-

goo is a worthy competitor for the elections now, it’ll win 100%,” said the 19-year-old. Online, Googoo has built a sizeable following. Nineteen km away, at Gulmohar Commercial Complex in Yusuf Sarai, South Delhi,

another contender was attracting votes in his own way.

Rambabu, also known as Chonky, began the day with a breakfast of biryani, fed by a local caregiver, said security guard Kamlesh. It took the dog a few seconds to get up and walk. “It was not this heavy until two years ago,” said Kamlesh. “It started gaining

weight after sterilisation... people also love to feed it.” Rambabu’s pictures have spread across the internet — sometimes under a bank’s boards, sometimes with its body spread across the floor.

Shatakshi Singh, 30, entered Rambabu in the election. She first met the dog in February last year, after moving to Delhi. “My workplace is right beside the complex. Rambabu has been there every day beside HDFC Bank, wagging its tail when I call its name,” she said. For Shatakshi, the appeal was hard to explain. “We live in strange times. I guess it provided some respite from atmosphere of hopelessness, poor governance...”



This World Heart Day, our cardiac experts address a practical question: how can we recognise danger earlier and respond without losing valuable time?

Chest pressure or discomfort; breathlessness; pain or discomfort in an arm, back, neck or jaw; nausea or a feeling of indigestion; and sudden, unusual fatigue or cold sweating are all possible warning signs. They may appear together or separately, and symptoms can come and go. A person does not need to experience all five. New symptoms, particularly at rest or with minimal activity, deserve urgent medical assessment.

A heart attack can cause discomfort in the upper abdomen that feels like acidity, burning or fullness. Taking an antacid and waiting for relief may delay treatment. Indigestion alone is common and usually has other causes, but persistent or unexplained discomfort—especially with sweating, breathlessness, nausea or chest pressure—must be treated as a possible heart emergency until a clinician rules it out.

The heart and other parts of the upper body share nerve pathways. The brain can therefore interpret distress from the heart as pain in the arm, shoulder, back, neck or jaw. Symptoms also vary from person to person. Some heart attacks produce little pain or symptoms so mild that they are missed. The location or absence of chest pain cannot, by itself, establish that the heart is safe.

Ordinary tiredness often has a clear explanation and improves with rest. Concern rises when fatigue is abrupt, unusually severe, out of proportion to activity or accompanied by breathlessness, sweating, nausea or discomfort above the waist. Someone who suddenly cannot manage a familiar walk or climb a usual flight of stairs should not simply "sleep it off." The pattern and the accompanying symptoms matter.

Women and cardiac health

Chest discomfort remains the most common heart attack symptom in women. Women may also report nausea, back or jaw discomfort, breathlessness, indigestion and unusual fatigue. These symptoms can be dismissed by patients and families as stress, acidity or exhaustion. The useful distinction is a change from what is normal for that person, particularly when symptoms are unexplained, recurring or occurring together.

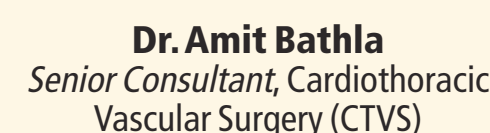
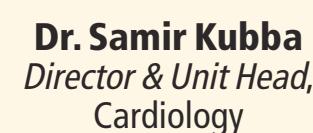
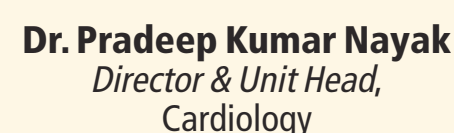
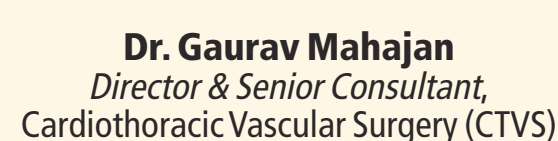
Some do, but there is no dependable seven-day warning period. New fatigue, disturbed sleep, breathlessness or recurring chest and upper-body discomfort may precede an event; others develop symptoms suddenly. Waiting for a familiar "classic" symptom creates a dangerous test that the body may never pass. A new, concerning symptom needs assessment when it happens, regardless of whether a person considers herself at risk.

Younger age can make heart disease seem unlikely to the patient and to those around her. Symptoms may be attributed to anxiety, a digestive problem or muscle pain. Women can also have causes of heart attack, such as a spontaneous tear in a coronary artery, that need careful evaluation. Describing when symptoms began, how they changed and what accompanied them helps the emergency team assess them promptly.

An ECG is an essential first test, but one normal tracing does not always exclude a heart attack. Doctors may repeat the



*For **World Heart Day**, cardiologists and cardiac surgeons at Dharamshila Narayana Superspeciality Hospital, Delhi, answer questions about symptoms people overlook, risks that build silently and the decisions that matter most when a heart attack is suspected.*



ECG and measure troponin, a blood marker of heart muscle injury, over time. Depending on the findings, further imaging may be needed. Some women also experience disease involving smaller heart vessels, which requires a different assessment from a simple search for a major artery blockage.

Yes. Cholesterol can accumulate in artery walls over many years, often without pain or warning. Very high levels may be inherited, making early identification especially important. A lipid test in young adulthood, followed by an assessment of family history and other risks, gives people time to act. Healthy habits matter, and some people also need medication; the decision should be based on their individual risk, not their age alone.


Dharamshila

Narayana
Health

Vaping exposes the body to nicotine and other substances; high-caffeine energy drinks can provoke palpitations or raise blood pressure in susceptible people. Prolonged inactivity contributes to poor metabolic health. None of these habits can be declared harmless because someone is young. Their effects can compound with smoking, high cholesterol, diabetes or a family history of early heart disease. Young adults should discuss new palpitations or chest symptoms with a doctor.

Diabetes can damage nerves and make pain less noticeable. Some people experience

rience breathlessness, unexplained sweating, nausea, weakness or fatigue instead of prominent chest pain. This does not mean every person with diabetes will have a "silent" attack. It means an unfamiliar change deserves attention, particularly alongside other risk factors. Regular care should address blood sugar, blood pressure, cholesterol and smoking as part of one heart-health plan.

An overactive thyroid can cause a racing heartbeat and palpitations; an underactive thyroid may be associated with fatigue and a slower pulse. These symptoms can overlap with heart complaints, and thyroid disease can also af-

fect cardiovascular health. The answer is not to choose between a thyroid test and a cardiac assessment on your own. New chest discomfort, fainting or significant breathlessness needs urgent evaluation, whatever the suspected cause.

Obstructive sleep apnoea repeatedly interrupts breathing during sleep and is associated with high blood pressure, abnormal heart rhythms and other cardiovascular problems. Loud snoring, witnessed pauses in breathing and daytime sleepiness warrant assessment. A heart attack can occur at night, but 3 a.m. is not a special diagnostic threshold. If someone wakes with concerning symptoms, the hour is no reason to wait until morning.

You wake with a strange feeling in your chest. What should you do in the next 90 minutes?

A coronary artery calcium score is a CT measurement of calcified plaque in the heart's arteries. It can help refine a prevention decision when a person's risk is uncertain. It is not an emergency test for chest pain, and a score of zero does not rule out every kind of artery disease, especially in younger adults. A doctor should decide whether it adds useful information after reviewing age, symptoms and other risks.

The team confirms the diagnosis, monitors the heart rhythm and gives treatment to restore blood flow when indicated. Some patients need urgent coronary angiography and a procedure to open an artery; treatment depends on the type of heart attack and the patient's condition. Doctors also begin medicines to reduce further clotting and protect the heart. Those first hours are crucial, but recovery continues through follow-up, rehabilitation and risk-factor control.

Cold weather can strain the cardiovascular system, while exposure to air pollution can raise the risk of cardiac events, particularly in vulnerable people. Those with known heart disease should follow their treatment plan, avoid sudden strenuous exertion in the cold and take local air-quality conditions seriously. Neither weather nor pollution explains away chest symptoms. If warning signs appear during a winter walk or on a polluted day, seek emergency care.

Editorial note: This is a draft for the hospital's cardiologists and cardiac surgeons to review and approve before publication. Individual answers have not been attributed to named doctors.





Taking Note

AGRICULTURE MINISTER Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Monday launched a veiled attack on some of the country's top agriculture officials for their seemingly casual approach during a conference. Addressing officials on the opening day of the two-day National Agriculture Conference – Rabi Campaign 2026, Chouhan observed that not all participants were taking notes. Taking the route of subtle innuendo, Chouhan said, “I notice that some friends are taking notes, while others — perhaps so learned — might be registering the information mentally. However, I urge you to make sure you do register it.”

Role of Honour

AT A time when women's issues are dominating political discourse, RSS-linked Bharatiya Kisan Sangh (BKS) is organising a conference of women farmers at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium in Delhi on September 30. Being held in the International Year of the Woman Farmer declared by the United Nations, the BKS conference focuses on highlighting that women undertake a substantial share of agricultural activities, while also preserving traditional farming knowledge and indigenous seeds. Some of them will also be honoured for their work in areas such as organic farming, animal husbandry, food processing, etc.

DUSU polls: Rahul asks NSUI chief, Kanhaiya Kumar to explain rout

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, September 28

WEEKS AFTER it was routed in the Delhi University Students Union (DUSU) elections, failing to win a seat in the central panel for the first time in over a decade, the Congress's NSUI in-charge Kanhaiya Kumar and president Vinod Jakhar were summoned by Rahul Gandhi on Monday. The Leader of Opposition sought answers on the defeat from the two leaders, it is learnt. The NSUI, or the National Students' Union of India, is the Congress's student wing. The meeting came at a time when Gandhi's student outreach, “Chhatron ki Goonj”, has drawn sizable crowds in different cities and the Opposition and the CJP are preparing to corner the Election Commission over its internal differences on the issue of SIR of electoral rolls. CJP had led the protests against the NEET exam paper leak, which forced Dharmendra Pradhan to resign as Union Education Minister in July, bringing to the fore youth discontent on various issues.

Sources said Gandhi was unhappy with Kumar and Jakhar over the NSUI's defeat at a time when the Congress is making sustained efforts to reach out to the youth and Gen-Z voters. The leaders have submitted a report to the LoP, who asked them specific questions about the reasons for the defeat in the DUSU polls. Gandhi is also learnt to have asked Jharkar and Kumar pointed questions about why independent candidate Deepanshu Shokeen, who left the NSUI, was not accommodated and given a ticket. The two leaders are learnt to have told Gandhi that the conditions Shokeen had placed were unreasonable. However, Gandhi was not happy with the way the matter was handled, according to sources.

CWC meeting today: EC row and Opp strategy on agenda

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, September 28

AS THE Opposition seeks to step up pressure on the Election Commission (EC) after last week's revelations of a divide in the poll panel over voter roll revision — first reported by *The Indian Express* — the Congress is likely to demand an inquiry and call for “action from the poll panel and the government”, sources said.

The decision will be taken at a meeting of the Congress Working Committee (CWC) on Tuesday. “We will give everyone present at the meeting a chance to speak and will accordingly release a statement. But these inquiries and call for action are likely to be part of the CWC resolution on Tuesday,” said a Congress insider.

The Indian Express on September 23 reported that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record at least 14 times in 10 months to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and glaring gaps in processes. In a four-page note issued after a meeting of the full Commission on Saturday, the poll panel announced nine decisions that



Police use water cannon to disperse Congress workers during a protest against the SIR process, in Jaipur on Monday. ROHIT JAIN PARAS

addressed, point by point, several of the concerns recorded by Commissioners Sandhu and Joshi. However, it left several questions unanswered.

The INDIA bloc is scheduled to meet just a day after the CWC to chart out a joint plan for the Opposition on the EC issue. Top Opposition leaders will attend the meeting on Wednesday.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said the Congress takes the EC matter “seriously”. “This issue concerns the entire country, the existence of our democracy and the survival of our country. That is why we are very serious about this issue,” he

told reporters on Monday.

He said the EC's “own people have exposed them” and that even a “former Chief Secretary of Kerala has said that the Chief Election Commissioner himself told him to contest the election”. “This means that he is propagating the BJP's philosophy and has become a BJP worker. Gyanesh Kumar should resign. We have to take action against him, even after his resignation,” said Kharge.

The CWC meeting comes at a time when the Cockroach Janta Party has given a call for a Jantar Mantar-like protest in Mumbai on October 2 demand-

ing CEC Gyanesh Kumar's resignation. The Opposition has also raised the demand, saying Kumar must step down.

Over the last few days, the Congress has held protests across the country demanding Kumar's resignation. “The Congress has protested in 1000+ districts today. Mr. Gyanesh, this is just the beginning. The groundswell will only grow from here on. My advice to Modi-Shah, sack Gyanesh before the streets are filled with people rejecting your Vote Chori shenanigans,” Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal posted on X on Monday.

The Opposition plans to move a motion in both Houses of Parliament to remove Kumar as CEC, with the parties learnt to be working together to draft a motion seeking advice from legal experts. In March, 63 Rajya Sabha MPs and 130 Lok Sabha MPs had moved a motion seeking Kumar's removal. The motion was rejected by the chairs of both Houses on April 6. On April 24, the Opposition moved a fresh notice in the Rajya Sabha seeking the removal of Kumar for “acting in a partisan manner”. The notice remains pending before the Chairman.

2 Cong leaders held for protest outside CEC's home in Agra

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, September 28

THE AGRA Police on Monday arrested two Congress leaders for attempt to murder after a group of Congress workers gathered near the ancestral residence of CEC Gyanesh Kumar in Agra to protest and allegedly defaced the walls of the house.

Police arrested Congress state general secretary (organisation) Anil Yadav and Mathura district president Mukesh Dhangar after they chased their vehicle while they were allegedly trying to leave Agra for Delhi.

S-I Gupta said that after receiving information of a crowd gathered outside the CEC's house in Agra's Vijay Nagar, he, accompanied by a constable, reached the spot and found 15-20 people raising slogans.

“We have arrested two persons in connection with the case. Both have been named in the FIR,” said Agra Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police Manoj Kumar Yadav.

Police are examining CCTV footage to identify other people who may have been involved in the alleged protest. The Congress had called protests against the CEC across the state amid a row over the EC's functioning.

SC gives EC 3 months to resolve TMC name, party symbol issue

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

THE SUPREME Court on Monday suggested that the EC use AI and machine-learning tools to expedite resolution of the dispute between Trinamool Congress factions over the party's name and symbol.

Led by CJI Surya Kant and comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, the bench is hearing former West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee's challenge to the EC's interim order freezing the TMC's name and its symbol until a decision on the factional feud is taken.

The EC sought six months to resolve the matter, but the bench said three months is “enough”. At one point, Justice Bagchi said, “Use AI and machine-learning devices... it will expedite the case... reading documents, etc.”

Senior Advocate D S Naidu, appearing for the poll panel, said, “To some extent, they may help, though not to the fullest extent. I will tell you the practical problem we have faced. Rival parties, party cadres, members and everybody vouch for whichever group they support and then file affidavits. They come in lakhs. Whatever time the court fixes, let it run from the date the process of filing affidavits is completed.”

Appearing for the Trinamool faction led by Mamata Banerjee, party leader and Senior Advocate Kalyan Banerjee said their camp has responded

Court suggests poll panel to use AI and machine-learning devices: 'It will expedite the case'

to the poll panel's notice, but the rival faction is yet to do so.

The bench then said, “We grant four weeks to the contesting respondents and the petitioner to place on record additional documents, affidavits and counter-affidavits, etc. Let pleadings be completed in all respects within four weeks. The Election Commission of India shall take three months thereafter to decide the symbol issue.”

The poll panel's counsel said it would need at least six months to decide the issue. Justice Bagchi, however, said, “Three months is good enough.” When the poll body's counsel replied that it would be “very difficult”, the bench said, “If some extreme exigency arises, come before us.”

The TMC, which lost power in Bengal after the Assembly poll drubbing this year, is caught in a factional feud in the Assembly and Parliament. While the rebel MPs have joined the Nationalist Citizen Party of India and aligned with NDA, the rebel faction comprising MLAs is led by Arup Roy and calls itself Democratic Trinamool Congress. The Banerjee-led faction is called the Mamata All-India Trinamool Congress.

TN EARMARKS RS 755.83 CR ANNUALLY FOR PROGRAMME

Vijay rolls out gold ring scheme for newborns in state hospitals

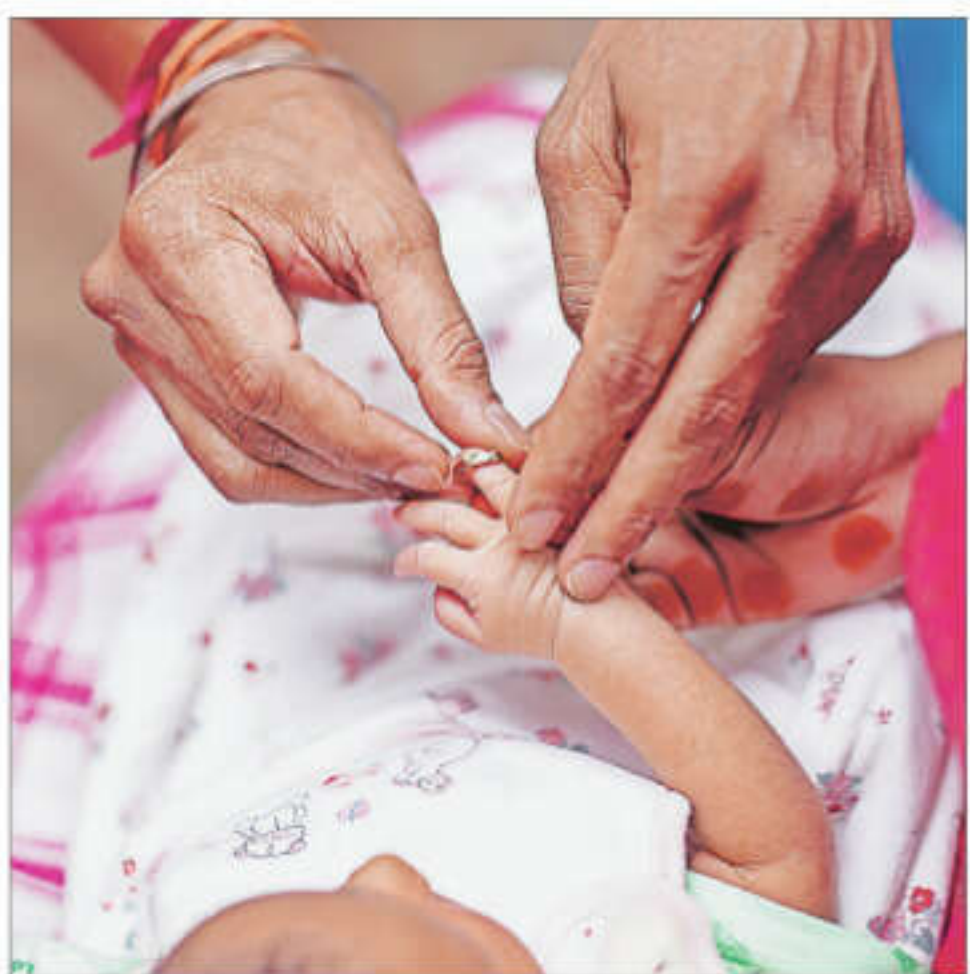
Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, September 28

TAMIL NADU Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday launched a scheme to give a one-gram gold ring of 22-carat to every eligible baby born in a government health institution in the state, rolling out one of the TVK government's prominent election promises.

Vijay inaugurated the Thaimaman Thanga Mothiram Thittam (Maternal Uncle's Gold Ring Scheme) at Government Rajaji Hospital in Madurai. The state has earmarked Rs 755.83 crore annually for the programme, estimated to cover about 4.42 lakh deliveries in government health facilities each year.

The scheme applies retrospectively to babies born in government hospitals and primary health centres from June 22 (Vijay's birthday). Both boys and girls are eligible. The mother must be a Tamil Nadu resident, registered under the Pregnancy and Infant Cohort Monitoring and Evaluation (PICME) system and have a Reproductive and Child Health ID.

Rolling out the scheme, Vijay presented rings to infants, including three babies seated with their mothers on stage. One recipient, Archana Devi, said she was particularly moved because she had no brothers. “I



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay presents a gold ring to a newborn at Madurai's Government Rajaji Hospital on Monday. PTI

am extremely happy to receive the gold ring for my daughter,” she said, adding that Vijay had treated her “as a sister.”

Vijay later visited the hospital's maternity ward and presented rings to more newborns. At the inaugural function, rings were presented to 27 infants overall. The programme borrows its name from the Tamil tradition of *thaimaaman seer*, in which a maternal uncle pres-

ents gifts to his sister's child.

The government has procured 1.28 lakh rings in the first phase. Each BIS-hallmarked ring will carry a unique serial number and be supplied in tamper-proof packaging.

The rollout has been temporarily withheld in Maduranthakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies because of the Model Code of Conduct for the coming byelections.

India, Netherlands set to deepen agri ties

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

THE LANDMARK Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between India and the European Union would further boost the two countries' cooperation on agricultural innovation, Dutch minister Silvio Erkens said on Monday.

The Netherlands Embassy

in New Delhi wrote on X that Erkens — the Netherlands Minister for Food Security, Fisheries and Horticulture — met Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan for “a bilateral discussion to deepen their cooperation in climate-resilient agriculture and water-efficient cultivation”. “Minister Chouhan has also underlined

the impact of the Indo-Dutch Centre of Excellence,” it said.

India and the EU had concluded negotiations on the FTA this January. The agreement is expected to be signed in December this year, and come into force in 2027. Erkens is on a visit to India, the first by a Dutch agriculture minister here since 2018, from September 27-October 2.

● FORMER CM TRAINED HIS GUNS ON BJP GOVT OVER MINES & MINERALS AMENDMENT ACT, WHICH PROHIBITS MINERAL-BEARING STATES FROM LEVYING TAXES ON MINING LEASE HOLDERS

In 1st major stir after poll loss, Naveen says ‘will fight for Odisha until last breath’

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, September 28

OUTSIDE THE Odisha Assembly, a sea of people, running into thousands and mostly dressed in white, started gathering from across the state on Monday morning. Around 12 pm, BJD chief Naveen Patnaik, escorted by his security detail, went up to the dais. The crowd erupted in applause, and slogans of “*Naveen Patnaik Zindabad*” rent the air.

This is the first time that the party has held a protest of such a huge scale in the last two years, after the BJP ended its 24-

year rule to capture power in the state in 2024. The party had called the protest to oppose the recently passed Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026.

Calling for a united fight against the Act, which “would cost a loss worth thousands of crores to the state every year”, Patnaik said, “MMDR is not an ordinary Bill, it is associated with the rights of the state. Sadly, such an important Bill was passed in Parliament without any discussion. In whose interest did the 20 BJP Lok Sabha MPs (from Odisha) remain silent? The state government re-

mained silent. Whom do they fear?” the 79-year-old said.

During the rally on Mahatma Gandhi road, for which workers and leaders from across Odisha were mobilised, Patnaik said people of the state were the rightful owners of its mines and its land. In his sharpest offensive yet against the BJP regime in Odisha, Patnaik said the government — always in denial — does little beyond making speeches.

He said despite him writing two letters to CM Mohan Charan Majhi, seeking a special session of the state House and another to pass a resolution against the new mining law, there was no



Naveen Patnaik during the rally on Monday. EXPRESS

reply. “Why does the (state) government remain silent when it comes to Odisha's interests? No

party can ever be greater than the motherland. The chair of power you hold today may not

be there tomorrow. But if you betray this land, you will face condemnation forever. Gen Z will never forgive you,” said Patnaik.

Reviving his regional pitch against the party in power at the Centre, he vowed to fight for Odisha “until his last breath”. Even as the Odisha government said that it is yet to assess the impact of the new mining law on the state, political parties said it would suffer a loss of Rs 1 lakh crore as arrears and additional annual revenue of Rs 12,000 crore from the mining sector.

What triggered protest against the new law is a clause prohibiting the mineral-bearing

states from levying taxes on the mining lease holders, even though the Supreme Court, in July 2024, empowered them to levy taxes and to collect arrears from April 2005. BJD sources said the party will make it an issue of “Centre vs regional interest” to target the BJP, which is in power in the state and at Centre.

The BJD has now decided to carry forward the protests to streets across the state. Sujata Rout Karthikeyan, the wife of former bureaucrat and the former CM's close aide, VK Pandian; and several other BJD leaders, MLAs and former legislators spoke at the event.

ADVERTORIAL

WORLD HEART DAY



The Gatekeeper of the Heart: Why India's TAVI Pioneer Says “Don't Wait for the Pain to Explain Itself”



Every year on 29th September, the world pauses to talk about the heart, the organ that beats roughly 100,000 times a day and asks for almost nothing in return, except attention. This World Heart Day, we sat down with Dr. Amit Kumar Chaurasia, a cardiologist whose career has tracked the arc of a quiet medical revolution in India: the rise of TAVI, or Transcatheter Aortic Valve Implantation, a procedure that has turned a once-fatal, inoperable diagnosis into a routine, life-extending fix.

Trained at JIPMER and AIIMS, with a DM in Cardiology from SCTIMST, he spent three formative years in Budapest mastering structural heart disease and complex coronary intervention before returning to India in 2016 as the country's first proctor for valve intervention.

In this candid conversation, he traces that journey, demystifies the disease that quietly ages the heart's gatekeeper, and repeats one message more than any other: get it treated; don't get stuck debating why.

From JIPMER to AIIMS to a DM in Cardiology at SCTIMST, and then three years of training in Budapest before returning to India — what drew you back, and how did that international training shape the cardiologist you are today?

"Medicine is a beautiful subject. After your MBBS, you do postgraduate training in one branch, then super-specialise in one field of that branch. I chose internal medicine because it's a broad speciality, something that intrigues any medical student at that age. Then I chose cardiology because it's a field where you can see immediate benefit. You have a heart attack patient; you take them to the cath lab, see the blocked artery, open it up, and the patient gets immediate benefit. It's amazing.

After working here for a couple of years, I wanted to see how the outside world works, especially in complex coronary and structural heart disease. So I trained as a fellow in complex coronary intervention and structural heart disease. Structural heart disease was just coming up as its own division of interventional cardiology during that era, and it pulled me completely into it.

While training in Budapest, I gained vast exposure to complex coronary intervention, in addition to participating in about 300 TAVIs. During my stay there, cardiologists from India would come for a 3-5 day observership pro-

gram. A few mentioned to me that it was time I came back to India. I was in Delhi in 2016 and was asked to perform TAVI in a hospital here as an expert. The same hospital offered me a job. It had been three years in Budapest, and I too wanted to come back. This seemed like a good opportunity, and hence I decided to return.

Back in 2016, India faced many logistical hurdles, so the total number of TAVIs performed here until then was only about 30-50. One of the main hurdles was the lack of well-trained cardiologists in TAVI, so we called in proctors from outside. I was a certified proctor then; hence, I started travelling across India to train cardiologists interested in TAVI. Many others who returned after training in the US and Europe joined this journey later, and the numbers slowly started increasing; today, India performs about 4000 TAVIs per year.

So you can say the thirst for knowledge pulled me to Budapest, and the deal of training new people pulled me back to India."

How has the patient profile coming to you for TAVI changed since you started?

"Before we discuss how the profile changed, we should understand who requires TAVI. Our heart has four valves — Tricuspid, pulmonary, mitral and aortic. The aortic valve is the gatekeeper between the left ventricle and the pipe that takes blood throughout the body, called the aorta. With age, in some people, this valve degenerates due to calcium deposition on the leaflet, which decreases the normal valve area. When the valve area is decreased below 1 cm², we call it severe aortic stenosis. These patients have three basic symptoms: chest heaviness, breathlessness and giddiness and some people even present with fainting attacks.

Once a patient has severe aortic stenosis and is symptomatic with the above symptoms, the treatment is to replace the aortic valve. If the aortic valve is not replaced, 50% of patients die within two years; if it is replaced, the new valve can function for 10-15 years. Surgical aortic valve replacement was previously the gold standard. In surgical aortic valve replacement, the patient is put on a ventilator and bypass machine, the chest is opened, the natural aortic valve is removed, and a prosthetic aortic valve is sutured. The patient is normally in hospital for 8-10 days, and the total recovery period varies anywhere between 2-3 months. Degenerative aortic stenosis occurs



A conversation with Dr Amit Kumar Chaurasia, one of India's first TAVI proctors, on the valve replacement revolution that is quietly rewriting survival odds for the country's ageing heart patients.

in patients above 60 years of age. Naturally, at this age, a lot of other diseases are present too: diabetes, hypertension, bad lungs, kidney disease. So surgical aortic valve replacement may not be possible from an anaesthesia perspective. For these patients, TAVI has been a boon. For TAVI, the patient undergoes an MSCT, which provides the aortic valve size and the size of the leg vessel through which the procedure is done. Following this, the patient is admitted a day before the procedure. Blood tests are done, and if there are no contraindications, the patient is shifted to the cath lab. The procedure is done under conscious sedation and local anaesthesia. A ventilator or bypass machine is not required in most patients. The usual procedure time is about 1-2 hours. After the procedure, the patient is shifted to the ICU

for monitoring. Usually, the patient is shifted to a room on the second day, and on the third day they are discharged. However, about 5-8% of patients may require a permanent pacemaker, and in these patients their hospital stay may be extended by a day or two.

Before 2016, importing the valve was a lengthy process. Cases were done on compassionate grounds. Government permission was required for every valve. Once government permission was granted, money was transferred to the US, and then the valve was imported. After that, you had to rely on foreign proctors to guide you through the process. This required a lot of time. However, in mid 2016, based on available trial data, the government approved the valve for commercial use, which made things easier. Soon, Meril de-

veloped the first indigenous valve, MyValve, which reduced the valve cost and, in turn, increased the number of procedures per year. As I said before, about 4000 TAVIs are done in India today, and you'll be surprised; the actual patient need is many times that number. So there are still hurdles, but you cannot fix them all at once, and that's what makes this journey more interesting."

You've trained doctors across India and many Asian countries and have been a part of many educational programs like IndiaValve, TAVI India, and Europe's PCR platforms. What's still the hardest skill to teach a cardiologist learning TAVI?

"Everyone in cardiology starts with coronary intervention and pacemaker implantation. The case volume is huge, and most operators are well trained. TAVI is a totally different ball game. You use large catheters, and learning to control them requires a learning curve. In addition, you need to learn how to interpret MSCT and determine the patient's risk profile. Patient risk assessment is the key point. Now, TAVI is approved for intermediate-risk patients, and these patients, if they outlive the valve, may require another valve implantation if the first valve degenerates. This is what we call lifetime management of the patient's valve. Two different valve platforms are available today. You need to learn to choose a valve based on the patient's risk assessment and after understanding the patient's lifetime management. Sometimes you need to unlearn certain things before you can learn something new. And this can be really challenging.

Cost is often the first question Indian families ask about TAVI. How has affordability changed since you started, and what still needs to improve?

"Before 2016, a single company supplied valves to India, and the price was about the price of a single valve, around 25 lakh. Then another American company entered, so competition brought the price down to about 19, 19.5 lakh. Then came the Indian valve, MyValve, from Meril. When we were doing the trials, there was a general consensus that being indigenous, it would be priced at 8 to 10 lakh. But when they analysed everything, they introduced it at 13 lakh. So now you had an Indian valve at 13 lakh and American valves at 18-19 lakh. This is the price of the valve, and you need to add procedure costs and other accessory costs. Over time, valve costs have decreased, lowering the total cost of the procedure.

For a middle-aged reader worried about an ageing parent, what are the early, easy-to-dismiss symptoms that deserve a cardiology visit — rather than being written off as "just old age"?

"Keep three main symptoms in mind:

chest heaviness on exertion; breathlessness — you could walk a kilometer comfortably before, now you're tired or breathless at 500 meters; and dizziness or a fainting attack. Add to that palpitations, and swelling in the feet or abdomen. Any of these — you should visit a cardiologist.

Any pain from below your jaw to above your navel should not be taken lightly. It could be a heart attack, also called a myocardial infarction. And I want to be clear — it's not only uneducated people or people from villages who neglect these symptoms. I've seen a lot of very educated, well-to-do people with chest pain who keep neglecting it. Time is muscle in cardiology — same as with a brain stroke. The more you delay, the more irreversible the damage.

When an artery gets blocked, the muscle it feeds doesn't get nutrition and starts dying, and that's when chest pain happens. Only dying muscle cries. Once the muscle has completely died, the pain is gone. A lot of people say, "I had pain, I refused treatment, now the pain isn't there, not realising that part of the muscle has already died. As the muscle has already died, the pain is gone, leaving behind consequences like low heart function and heart failure symptoms because of that.

When you have chest pain, the first test is always an ECG, and an acute heart attack is diagnosed by that. So don't wait for blood enzymes to be positive. By the time your blood test turns positive, two to three hours have already passed, because those enzymes only release once the muscle has died.

What would you say heart attacks and TAVI-treated aortic stenosis have in common — and where do they differ?

"A heart attack, to a great extent, you can prevent — take care of your diabetes, your hypertension, quit smoking, moderate exercise, manage stress, eat well. TAVI is for degenerative severe aortic stenosis — we don't fully know why it happens — so early detection and treatment play a huge part in prolonging lifespan."

Closing Thoughts: A Message for World Heart Day

"Don't delay. If you have symptoms, visit your cardiologist — there is treatment for everything today. A disease like aortic stenosis is degenerative, it will happen over time and we don't fully know why. But a disease like heart attack, to a great extent, you can prevent — take care of your diabetes, your hypertension, quit smoking, moderate exercise, manage stress, eat well. And if you do get a disease, get it treated — there's no point suffering through it, when treatment exists.

The heart is one of the most precious organs in the body. Most damage to it is irreversible, except for a few conditions. So preserve it. You need to really, really preserve your heart."

Goa senior citizen accuses BJP MLA's son of road rage, CM orders probe

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, September 28

GOA CHIEF MINISTER Pramod Sawant said Monday that he has ordered an inquiry into an incident of road rage, allegedly involving the son of a legislator in Goa.

A senior citizen from Curchorem filed a police complaint on Monday alleging that Rahul Faldessai — son of Cumberjua Bharatiya Janata Party MLA Rajesh Faldessai — and his associates blocked their car, hurled abuses at them and chased them in their SUV before speeding away.

According to the police complaint lodged by Shantaram Kudchadkar at Curchorem police station, the incident occurred on Saturday around 8.15 pm when the complainant, his daughter-in-law and grandchildren were going to Margao in their SUV. He said when they reached near the Pontemol junction, their path was blocked by another SUV, which was parked diagonally on the road.

The complainant said that due to this 'arbitrary' blocking, there was also traffic congestion for five to 10 minutes.

Clashes in Ujjain over demolition, mosque panel later razes a portion

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, September 28

CLASHES BROKE out between police and a crowd in Madhya Pradesh's Ujjain on Monday over the removal of a portion of the Shahi Masjid that falls along a road being widened ahead of the 2028 Simhastha, with police firing tear gas shells and using lathicharge to disperse protesters.

Police said the crowd was mobilised by a faction of the mosque committee disgruntled by the demolition, and some of its younger members were misguided by AI-generated videos that falsely showed the structure being demolished.

The demolition, which was eventually carried out by members of the Muslim community itself, had been greenlit by the Madhya Pradesh High Court on September 9.

The confrontation followed a tense night outside the Shahi Masjid, where thousands had gathered after the administration prepared to remove the portion of the mosque falling within the proposed road-widening project.

Despite the court order, tensions had been simmering in the area over the proposed demolition.

tion. Hoping to win over locals, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav demolished structures outside his ancestral home.

The Ujjain Municipal Corporation said road-widening work across the city had affected approximately 80 religious places and that portions of 10 temples and a mosque had already been removed.

But thousands of residents formed a human chain around the mosque on Sunday night even as police mobilised 2,500 personnel from local police stations and Rapid Action Force units.

At night, negotiations made headway, and City Qazi Khalil Qureshi Rehman said the matter had been resolved through mutual agreement.

But as authorities gathered on Monday morning, a crowd turned violent and stones were pelted at security personnel. Police responded with tear gas shells and lathicharge.

By Monday afternoon, however, the Madhya Pradesh High Court, hearing a writ appeal against its order for partial demolition, was informed that the Muslim side had agreed to cooperate with the authorities, and disposed of the petition.



Security personnel keep vigil following stone-pelting incidents during protests on Monday. PTI

By evening, mosque committee members could be seen demolishing the structures. One of them, Mohammad Yunus, said, "This is my third Simhastha. We serve the devotees poha and tea. Ganga-Jamuni *tehzeeb* is in our culture. We are ready to cooperate with the police."

Police said rumours circulating on social media had led some people to believe that the entire mosque was going to be demolished.

Ujjain SP Pradeep Sharma told *The Indian Express*, "One of these videos included a JCB de-

molishing the entire mosque, which was completely false."

The police are now examining not only the accounts that originally uploaded the material but also people who circulated it. Sharma said investigators are looking at "several social media events" over the past few days which spread the rumours.

"We have registered five FIRs against five social media pages or influencers. The content was purely based on rumours and was aggressive in nature. We are also identifying people who shared this content over and

over again," Sharma said.

The investigation has so far resulted in 15 people being arrested. Police have also reported more than 100 Instagram accounts and registered an FIR on the complaint of Ujjain City Qazi Rehman.

Sharma also said police had anticipated a reaction from a section of the mosque committee after monitoring the situation.

"Every organisation has dissatisfied factions and we anticipated that there would be a reaction to this," Sharma said.

The history of the Shahi Masjid's present property stretches back at least to the period of the erstwhile Gwalior State. The mosque complex comprises a prayer hall, ablution facilities, a reported 120-foot minaret and the Mazhar Chouk Shahi at the front facing the road.

The demolition row has been accompanied by a bitter fight over who has the authority to represent the mosque and administer its Waqf property.

When the Madhya Pradesh High Court okayed the partial demolition, two factions had approached it, each claiming an interest in the mosque and its administration.

HC bench stays single bench order into caste bias complaint in NLU Prayagraj

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, September 28

DAYS AFTER a single bench of the Allahabad High Court ordered a probe into a Dalit student's allegations of caste discrimination at National Law University (NLU) Prayagraj, a division bench has stayed the proceedings, holding that the university's Equal Opportunity Cell should have been allowed to examine the complaint.

In its September 16 order, the single bench of Justice Vinod Dikwarkar constituted a two-member committee of judicial officers to inquire into allegations against the Head of the Department (HoD) of Law at Dr Rajendra Prasad National Law University, Prayagraj. The bench had fixed the next date of hearing for September 24; the judicial inquiry report was to be submitted on this date.

The HoD and the university filed a special appeal challenging the order.

Hearing the appeal and the counsel, a division bench of Justices Siddhartha Varma and Kunal Ravi Singh, in its order said, "At this stage, we are prima facie of the view that when an Equal Opportunity Cell was available in the University, and also the prayer was to the effect that the Equal Opportunity Cell itself may inquire into the matter after excluding the HoD, who faced the allegations, then there was no occasion for getting an inquiry done by the judicial officers."

The student, who is pursuing BALLB (Hons), had approached the court alleging that the HoD and the warden of the boys' hostel had used their academic and administrative authority to humiliate him based on caste.

Apex court declines to pause MDR, asks Govt and RBI to explain decision

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 28

DECLINING TO stay the government's decision to impose a Merchant Discount Rate of 0.4 per cent on specified UPI person-to-merchant transactions above Rs 2,000 from October 15, the Supreme Court Monday sought a response from the Centre and Reserve Bank of India after the government said the MDR was neither a tax nor a fee.

The bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, while hearing a petition which challenged the gazette notification issued by the Ministry of Finance on the MDR, made it clear that it was only examining the legal incidence of the decision.

The petition was filed by Advocate Anjan Datta against the decision to introduce MDR on certain UPI merchant transactions.

Appearing for the Centre, Additional Solicitor General N Venkataraman said the MDR is yet to come into effect and is likely to take effect October 15.

"Ninety-six per cent of people using the gateway are exempted, and of the balance four per cent, essential services are capped at Rs 5. There is (also) a value cap. Any threshold to the merchant beyond Rs 75,000 is capped at Rs 300, whether it's Rs 1 crore or 10 crore or 100 crore. The collection charges at the moment are less than half a per cent with all these limitations," he said.

Justice Bagchi asked whether it's a tax or a fee, to which he agreed.

The bench of CJI Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana was hearing a petition which challenged the gazette notification issued by the Ministry of Finance

which Venkataraman said it is neither a tax nor a fee.

"If not, what is the executive scope of making this expropriation?" asked Justice Bagchi. Venkataraman said, "It's not an expropriation also".

Justice Bagchi then sought to know the MDR's character.

Venkataraman referred to the case of credit cards and debit cards and said a cost-sharing agreement among the stakeholders is involved there as well.

"UPI also involves banks and aggregators. It's not a statutory collection by the Government of India. The NPCI (National Payments Corporation of India), the nodal body, facilitates. The Government of India is not taking a rupee of this," he said.

The bench asked Venkataraman to submit whatever he wanted to say in an affidavit, to which he agreed.

Towards the end of the hearing, petitioner Datta's counsel sought a stay, saying the decision would lead to further corruption and black money. But the bench declined to grant a stay.

India sends senior MEA official to Pak for SCO coordinators meet

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, September 28

A YEAR and half after Operation Sindoor, India has sent a senior official from the Ministry of External Affairs to Pakistan for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) coordinators' meeting, beginning Monday.

India's SCO Coordinator Alok Dimri, who is an Additional Secretary in the MEA, is attending the meeting in Islamabad.

Delhi's stance has been that while bilateral engagements need to take place in a conducive environment free from terrorism, it will engage with Pakistan under the format of the SCO.

The Indian government's position has been that terror and talks can't go together — especially so after the Pahalgam terror attack and the military confrontation between India and Pakistan in May last year under Operation Sindoor.

This week, from Monday to Wednesday, Pakistan is hosting the national coordinators of the SCO grouping in Islamabad to discuss the programme under Pakistan's chairmanship and other organisational matters.

In a statement on Sunday, Pakistan's Foreign Office said the first meeting of the SCO Council of National Coordinators (CNC),

under Pakistan's chairmanship of the SCO Council of Heads of State (CHS) for 2026-27, would be convened in Islamabad.

The meeting is being chaired by Pakistan's national coordinator for SCO and attended by counterparts from member states, along with representatives of the SCO Secretariat.

"The national coordinators would discuss a wide range of issues relating to SCO cooperation and coordination, including the programme of activities under Pakistan's chairmanship, preparations for upcoming SCO meetings and events, and other matters on the agenda," the Pakistan Foreign Office said.

Pakistan will seek to advance the SCO's objectives under the theme "Turning Vision into Action: Connectivity, Innovation and Shared Prosperity".

Pakistan's National Coordinator for SCO, Dr M Faisal, is chairing the meeting, officials said. The Indian delegation's presence marks New Delhi's participation in a SCO meeting in Pakistan after almost two years.

Sources said that India wants to engage with SCO, and that is the reason behind sending the SCO coordinator to Pakistan.

Pakistan is likely to invite Prime Minister Narendra Modi for the summit.

Deepthiman Tiwary
New Delhi, September 28

WITH THE latest killings, in Kamjong and Senapati, the death toll in clashes between the Nagas and Kukis since the recast BJP government took over in Manipur in February has risen to over 50, marking a shift away from the conflict centred around the Meiteis and Kukis since May 2023.

Like that cycle of violence, the Naga-Kuki tensions too appear to have entered a self-perpetuating loop now, with each side seeking to avenge the killing of its own. Containing this conflict poses a more difficult challenge geographically.

An officer of the Manipur Police says, "When Meitei-Kuki clashes began, the two communities got geographically separated within months. Kukis withdrew to the hills and Meiteis came to the valley. So a buffer zone was created and security forces were placed there. It is not so in the Naga-Kuki clashes. In the hills, the populations are mixed. It is nearly impossible to guard every village."

The clashes have been reported across Ukhrul, Kamjong, Senapati and Kangpokpi, with the geographical proximity of the two communities meaning the conflict is playing out over roads and highways. Consequently, security agencies must deal not only with gunfights and killings, but also the disruption of supplies and movement.

Not long after the Yumnam Khemchand Singh-led BJP government came to power in Manipur, after a stint of President's Rule, tensions flared up in and around Litan-Sareikhong in Ukhrul over an altercation between Kukis and Nagas. This "local" dispute escalated into fir-

ing, arson and attacks on homes, with the violence first spreading through Ukhrul and later into Kamjong and Kangpokpi.

On March 11, 21 Nagas were "abducted" near Mongkot Chephu, and released only after negotiations. The same day, the bodies of two Kuki men suspected to have been abducted by Naga volunteers were recovered in Kamjong. Gunfights followed in Sirarakhong, Sinakeitheh and Mongkot Chephu, and by late April, the violence had spread to Mullam and Shongphel. The entry of armed groups based in Myanmar widened the conflict.

Then came the killing of three Kuki church leaders in Kangpokpi on May 13, which prompted retaliatory abductions by both sides and culminated in the killing of six Naga men, abducted from the Leilon Vaiphei area. The incident has since become a rallying point for Naga civil society.

Security establishment sources say the conflict can't be understood solely through the history of Naga-Kuki hostility or competing territorial claims. An economic contest over the illicit drug trade may be helping sustain the violence.

Until recently, Moreh in

Tengnoupal was the principal transit point for narcotics and other illicit goods entering Manipur. Since the ethnic conflict began in 2023, Moreh has largely come under Kuki control, with the disruption of access to Imphal affecting the old trafficking chain. While routes through Kamjong have emerged as an alternative, it is a predominantly Naga area. "So there is now a competition between groups over access, routes and money," a security officer says.

The fact that some of the most serious recent attacks have taken place close to the Myanmar border has strengthened the suspicion that the conflict is intersecting with cross-border militant and trafficking networks. Earlier attacks on Naga villages had raised concerns over the involvement of a Myanmar-based Kuki armed group, KNA-B.

So far, efforts to open a political channel between the two communities have failed. One of the more significant attempts came in July, when Church leaders from Mizoram and Nagaland brought together Kuki and Naga representatives in Aizawl to explore a dialogue. The Mizoram Kohhran Hruaitute Committee and Nagaland



Toll in Kuki-Naga clashes over 50 since new state government took over in February. FILE

Joint Christian Forum agreed to facilitate direct talks between Naga and Kuki-Zo church bodies in Manipur. The initiative, however, did not translate into a direct political dialogue.

Accusing the Nagas of ignoring overtures for peace, Henlianthang Thanglet, chairman of the Kuki Zonal Council, told *The Indian Express*, "Church leaders can hardly do anything as the whole thing is done by the NSCN-IM... We had apologised for the killing of six Naga men in May. But they refused to accept it. Twenty-seven of our own people have been killed."

The United Naga Council (UNC), in turn, blames Kuki militant groups for the dialogue's failure. "It depends on the intent of the leadership. If they don't want peace, what can we do?" UNC chief Ng Lorho said.

The decision to have two deputy CMs in the government — Nemcha Kipgen representing the Kuki-Zos and Losii Dikho the Nagas — was intended to create a political mechanism for managing competing ethnic interests. Instead, the two have emerged as opposing voices in the Naga-Kuki conflict.

Dikho and other Naga legislators have accused Nemcha

and her husband, Thangboi Kipgen, chairman of the Kuki National Front-Progressive, of having links to the killing of the six Naga men abducted from Leilon Vaiphei in May. "Initially, it was thought the two could be engaged to defuse tensions. But now that is out of the question," a Manipur official says.

The issue has also acquired an electoral dimension, with Assembly polls due early next year. The UNC has made the abrogation of the Suspension of Operations pact with Kuki armed groups, action against those responsible for the killings of six Nagas and the removal of Nemcha from the deputy CM's post, its Central demands. For the past three months, the UNC managed to impose an economic blockade of highways through Naga-dominated Senapati. The blockade was suspended on September 26 after a meeting between UNC, Union Home Ministry and Manipur government. The Centre assured the UNC its demands would be addressed.

For the security establishment, the immediate task has become one of "managing" the violence, rather than ending it. A security establishment officer says, "We are largely responding to incidents. If there is violence, we rush forces to stop it from escalating... But there is no effective way to find a solution."

However, there has been one unexpected shift due to the new tensions — Kuki leaders are reaching out to Meiteis. No major clashes have been reported recently. Kuki residents are increasingly being allowed into Imphal to access healthcare and other services, or to travel out of the state by air. Forty-fifty Kukis enter Imphal daily for such purposes without facing resistance, security officials say.



BJP MP Anil Baluni at Rawat's ancestral home in Pauri Garhwal

of Nuranang 64 years ago.

"My plan is to perform the Bhoomi Pujan that day," he said.

Baluni also plans to bring soil from Jaswant Garh, the war memorial in Arunachal Pradesh built at the spot where Rawat fought and was killed, and use it in the foundation-laying ceremony. "I will go to Tawang in a few days and bring soil from there. We will put that soil in the foundation of the house," he said.

Jaswant Garh War Memorial is located around 24-25 kilometres from Tawang and commemorates Rawat's role in the Battle of Nuranang. Rawat, who was serving

with the 4th Battalion of the Garhwal Rifles, was enlisted in the Army on August 19, 1960, at the age of 19, two years before he was killed.

During the Battle of Nuranang in the then North-East Frontier Agency, now Arunachal Pradesh, Rawat fought Chinese forces under extremely difficult conditions.

He was posthumously awarded the Maha Vir Chakra, India's second-highest wartime gallantry award, for his bravery.

Baluni said Rawat occupies a particularly important place in the history and traditions of the Garhwal Rifles.

"When people go to Jas-

want Garh, they think of the Indian Army. If you read his story, he stopped the entire Chinese Army there for 72 hours. He was alone. He was martyred at the age of 21. Jaswant Singh is the biggest name for Garhwal Rifles. Everyone calls him Jaswant Baba," Baluni said.

According to Baluni, the museum will preserve Rawat's memory and sacrifice and give visitors a chance to learn about his life and military service.

He also plans to develop the approach to the ancestral home, including a gate named after Rawat, following a suggestion by villagers.

● **BJP MP TAKES INITIATIVE TO RESTORE THE LEGACY OF JASWANT SINGH RAWAT "WHO STOPPED THE ENTIRE CHINESE ARMY FOR 72 HOURS...HE WAS ALONE. HE WAS MARTYRED AT 21"**

Ancestral home of 1962 war martyr to be converted into a museum

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
Dehradun, September 28

JASWANT SINGH Rawat, a Garhwal Rifles soldier, was just 21 when he was killed while fighting Chinese forces during the Sino-India War in 1962.

Over the decades, the rifleman's home in his native village in Uttarakhand's Pauri Garhwal fell into disrepair as his family members moved away.

Now, it is all set to be converted into a museum where visitors can learn about Rawat's life and military service, BJP MP Anil Baluni said on Monday.

Baluni, who represents the Garhwal Lok Sabha constituency, told *The Indian Express* that he visited Rawat's ancestral village of Baryun in Pauri Garhwal last week.

"When I asked to see his house, I found that it had turned to ruin. Nobody was living there," Baluni said.

According to Baluni, villagers told him that Rawat's family members had moved away, and that locals wanted to see the ancestral house preserved and converted into a museum.

"After seeing the condition of the house, I thought that it should be turned into a museum. I then spoke to his

brother over the phone because it was important to have the family's consent," Baluni said, adding that the family agreed.

The proposed museum will come up right where Rawat's ancestral home is.

A feasibility study and consultation with an architect will be done first.

The BJP MP said he intends to use funds from his MPLADS (Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme) allocation for the project, and that the foundation ceremony for the museum is planned for November 17 — the date on which Rawat was killed in the Battle

EXPRESS special

10 yrs after surgical strikes, more eyes on ground and sky, focus on Jammu

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, September 28

TEN YEARS ago, on the night of September 28-29, the Indian Army carried out what it described as its first coordinated cross-border surgical strikes across the Line of Control. The operation was in retaliation to the September 18 terrorist attack on the Army Brigade Headquarters near Uri, in which 19 soldiers were killed.



In September 2016, Army carried out what it described as its first coordinated cross-border surgical strikes across the LoC. EXPRESS FILE

there were 12 terror-related incidents in 2025, with deaths of 16 security personnel.

In terms of geography, independent, non-profit conflict-monitoring and crisis-mapping organisation ACLED (Armed Conflict Location & Event Data) notes that over 60% of violent militant activity in J&K in 2025 occurred in the Jammu division, against 5% in 2018. It attributes this partly to the difficult forested and mountainous terrain of Jammu areas, and changes in troop deployment after the 2020-21 India-China border crisis.

"In 2016, an urban/semi-urban militancy, with stone-pelting incidents and local militant recruitment, were key. Now, it is about small groups moving through forests and mountains, often operating for extended periods without being detected," another official said, adding that the abrogation of Article 370 in J&K in 2019, accompanied by the

infusion of troops into Kashmir, was one factor behind this change. "Additionally, a crack-down on contact between locals and terrorists through extensive patrolling and surveillance has kept them confined to hideouts or in higher reaches."

In terms of counter-insurgency, this has meant a shift from earlier when cordon and search operations in suspected areas were carried out with big contingents of troops. Now, the Army's operations are more intelligence-specific, involving fewer troops and greater use of technology, targeting specific areas. While human intelligence and tracking radio frequencies from communication between terrorists was earlier the mainstay, an official said, the large-scale induction of UAVs has made this more elaborate.

"Simultaneously, there is more access to satellite imagery," an official who has served in the area said, cautioning that culti-

vating human intelligence can't be entirely jettisoned, as had been felt "after a series of attacks south of Pir Panjal". Inter-agency coordination and information-sharing — both laterally and vertically — have also been enhanced, accelerating the flow of real-time intelligence.

Alongside, there is day-and-night area domination and strengthening of the counter-insurgency grid, with changes in deployment patterns. The Army, particularly the Rashtriya Rifles, has historically carried a huge part of the counter-insurgency burden in J&K.

After the Pahalgam terror attack and Operation Sindoor, surveillance drones and counter-drone capabilities have been further enhanced, and temporary operating bases have come up along vulnerable stretches.

Former Northern Army Commander Lieutenant General D S Hooda (retired) explained the change from ground-based 2016 surgical strikes to the 2019 Balakot air strikes and Op Sindoor in May 2025 — an integrated operation. Referring to 2016 surgical strikes, which he had overseen as the Army Commander, he said one of the biggest improvements, aside from troops being better equipped, has been in the surveillance and intelligence-gathering architecture. He, however, cautioned that with these improvements, the risk of escalation has gone up. "This was seen during Operation Sindoor. This has to be factored in for the future," he said.

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

CALLING FOR a stronger, institutionalised counter-terrorism framework with a whole-of-society approach, Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurated a conference on 'PRAHAAR - CT Policy and Strategy' in New Delhi on Monday.

PRAHAAR stands for the seven pillars of - Prevention, Response, Aggregating Internal Capacities, Human Rights, Attenuating Conditions for Terrorism, Aligning International Efforts, and Recovery and Resilience.

Shah said the government under Prime Minister Narendra Modi had adopted a zero-tolerance policy against all forms terrorism.

He stressed the need to strengthen the PRAHAAR strategy through continuous analysis of terror incidents and by establishing a concrete mechanism for the next 10 years.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurates the Conference on 'PRAHAAR - CT Policy and Strategy', in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

Shah said the principles of PRAHAAR must reach the thana level. He also underlined the importance of coordination among all stakeholders to prevent delays in action. Shah also launched a new "extradition portal", which he said would help expedite efforts to bring back fugitives from abroad, and urged state police forces to set up teams dedicated to fugitive tracking.

The conference is ex-

It was attended by the Union Home Secretary, Foreign Secretary, heads of Central Armed Police Forces and Central Police Organisations, Directors General of Police of 15 states, and ATS chiefs of all states and Union Territories. Other state DGPs and police officers at the cutting-edge level were present virtually.

Shah said that between 2019 and 2026, the Modi government had brought back 288 fugitive criminals to India from 36 countries. He also said improved coordination among agencies had helped more than 40 modules of the Shahzad Bhatti Network, which was allegedly involved in cross-border smuggling of weapons, explosives and narcotics.

BEFORE THE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL, CHENNAI BENCH
COMPANY SCHEME APPLICATION NO. CA(CAA)/66(CHE)/2026
In the matter of the Companies Act, 2013;

In the matter of Sections 230 to 232 read with Section 66 and Section 52 and other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and Rules framed there under as in force from time to time;

And

Composite Scheme of Amalgamation and Arrangement between Niyogin Fintech Limited ("Demerged Company"/ "Amalgamating Company"/ "Company"/ "NFL") and Niyogin Fintech Private Limited ("Resulting Company"/ "NFL 2") and Iserveu Technology Private Limited ("Amalgamated Company"/ "ISERVEU") and their respective shareholders and creditors under Sections 230 to 232

Niyogin Fintech Limited having registered office at M.I.G. 944, Ground Floor, TNHB Colony, 1st Main Road, Velachery, Chennai, Tamil Nadu - 600042 (CIN: L65910TN1988PLC131102) ... First Applicant Company

Niyogin Fintech Private Limited having registered office M.I.G. 944, Ground Floor, TNHB Colony, 1st Main Road, Velachery, Chennai, Tamil Nadu - 600042 (CIN: U64990TN2025PLC176517) ... Second Applicant Company

Iserveu Technology Private Limited having registered office 5th, 6th and 7th Floor, EA Chambers, Tower 2, Whites Road, Chennai, Tamil Nadu - 600014 (CIN: U72900TN2016PTC193156) ... Third Applicant Company

NOTICE AND ADVERTISEMENT OF THE MEETING OF EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS, SECURED CREDITORS AND UNSECURED CREDITORS OF FIRST APPLICANT COMPANY

NOTICE is hereby given that by an order dated September 11, 2026 ("Order"), the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Chennai Bench ("Hon'ble NCLT") has directed that a meeting of the Equity Shareholders, Secured Creditors, Unsecured Creditors of Niyogin Fintech Limited ("First Applicant Company" or "Company") to be held for the purpose of considering, and if thought fit, approving the Composite Scheme of Arrangement amongst Niyogin Fintech Limited ("Demerged Company"/ "Amalgamating Company"/ "Company"/ "NFL") and Niyogin Fintech Private Limited ("Resulting Company"/ "NFL 2") and Iserveu Technology Private Limited ("Amalgamated Company"/ "ISERVEU") and their respective shareholders and creditors, pursuant to Sections 230 to 232 read with Section 66 and Section 52 of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and the other applicable provisions thereof and rules thereunder (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment thereof, for the time being in force).

In pursuance of the Order passed by the Hon'ble NCLT and as directed therein, further Notice is hereby given that, separate meetings of the Equity Shareholders, Secured Creditors and Unsecured Creditors will be held through video-conferencing or other audio-visual means ("VC/OAVM"), as under:

Sr.no	Class of Meeting	Time (IST)	Date of Meeting
1.	Equity shareholders	10:30 a.m.	Friday, October 30, 2026
2.	Secured Creditors	11:30 a.m.	Friday, October 30, 2026
3.	Unsecured Creditors	12:30 p.m.	Friday, October 30, 2026

In compliance with the Order, the respective Notices containing the details of day, date and time as aforesaid, together with a copy of the Scheme along with the Explanatory Statement ("Notice") disclosing all material facts as required under Section 230(3) of the Act read with Rule 6 of the Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016 and the documents accompanying the Notices is being dispatched as under:

a) To Equity Shareholders of NFL: through email to those equity shareholders as on Friday, September, 18, 2026, whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company and, the physical copies to those equity shareholders whose email addresses are not registered with the Company.

b) To Secured/Unsecured Creditors of NFL: through email to those creditors as on Tuesday, March 31, 2026, whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company and, the physical copies to those creditors whose email addresses are not registered with the Company.

A copy of these Notices and the accompanying documents, including the Scheme, will be hosted on the website of the Company at www.niyogin.com and will also be available on the website of the BSE Limited ("BSE") at www.bseindia.com. A copy of the Scheme along with the explanatory statement can be obtained free of charge, from the date of dispatch of Notice upto the date of the Meeting on all working days during business hours from the registered office of the Company or by sending a request, along with details of your shareholding in the Company, by e-mail at niyogin.compliance@niyogin.in.

The Hon'ble NCLT has appointed Shri. Kuldip Karir, to be the Chairperson of the Meeting, including for any adjournment(s) thereof. Further, the Hon'ble NCLT has appointed Advocate Udit Jain, to be the scrutinizer for the Meeting, including for any adjournment(s) thereof.

The Scheme, if approved at the Meeting, will be subject to the subsequent approval of the Hon'ble NCLT and such other approvals, permission, and sanctions of regulatory or other authorities, as may be necessary and as contemplated in the Scheme.

The Company has provided remote e-voting facility to its Equity Shareholders, Secured Creditors and Unsecured Creditors to enable them to cast their votes electronically and has availed the services of NSDL for providing VC facility, remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting. Some of the important details regarding remote e-voting are provided below:

Class of meeting	Equity Shareholders	Secured Creditors	Unsecured Creditors
Cut-off date	October 23, 2026	March 31, 2026	March 31, 2026
Remote e-voting date and time	Start: Monday, October 26, 2026, at 9:00 A.M (IST) End: Thursday, October 29, 2026, at 5:00 P.M (IST)	Start: Monday, October 26, 2026, at 9:00 A.M (IST) End: Thursday, October 29, 2026, at 5:00 P.M (IST)	Start: Monday, October 26, 2026, at 9:00 A.M (IST) End: Thursday, October 29, 2026, at 5:00 P.M (IST)

Attendance of the Equity Shareholders / Secured Creditors / Unsecured Creditors of the Company participating in the meeting through VC facility shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Act. In case the stated quorum is not present at the commencement of the Meeting, the Meeting shall be adjourned for 15 (Fifteen) minutes, thereafter, the Equity Shareholders / Secured Creditors / Unsecured Creditors present shall be deemed to constitute the quorum.

Equity Shareholders / Secured Creditors / Unsecured Creditors entitled to attend, and vote may vote through remote e-voting facility prior to the Meeting or through e-voting facility made available during the Meeting. Since the Meeting will be held through VC as per Hon'ble NCLT directions, the facility for appointment of proxies will not be availed for the Meeting. Voting in case of both corporate and share, be permitted, provided the prescribed form / authorisation is filed with Company at niyogin.compliance@niyogin.in and Scrutinizer at adjuditjain@gmail.com no later than 48 (forty eight) hours before the start of the Meeting as required under Rule 10 of the Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016.

Only Equity Shareholders whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the cut-off date of October 23, 2026 shall be entitled to exercise his/her voting rights on the resolution proposed in the Notice (either by way of remote e-voting facility or the e-voting facility made available during the Meeting) and attend the Meeting. The voting rights of Equity Shareholders shall be in proportion to their holding in the paid-up share capital of the Company as on the Cut-Off Date. A person who is not an equity shareholder of the Company as on the Cut-Off Date, should treat the Notice for information purpose only.

A Creditor, whose names is recorded in the records of the Company as on the Cut-Off date for Creditors i.e. March 31, 2026, for the respective Meetings, shall only be entitled to avail the facility of e-voting (either by way of remote e-voting facility or through the e-voting facility made available during the Meetings) and attend the aforesaid meeting(s) of the Creditors. Each Creditor shall be entitled to 1 (One) vote. A person who is not a Creditor of the Company as on the Cut-Off Date for Creditors, should treat the Notice for information purpose only.

Any Equity Shareholder, who acquires shares of the Company after Dispatch of the Notice and holding shares as on Cut-off Date and whose name appears in the register of members' list of beneficial owners maintained by the Depositories as on the Cut-Off Date can download this Notice from the website of Company www.niyogin.com and may obtain the login ID and password in the manner outlined in the Notice. Each Equity Shareholders / Secured Creditors / Unsecured Creditors can opt for only one mode of voting i.e., either through remote e-voting or e-voting during the Meeting. The Equity Shareholders / Secured Creditors / Unsecured Creditors who have casted their vote by remote e-voting prior to the Meeting may attend / participate in the Meeting through VC but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.

The Company has appointed NSDL to provide the facility for voting through remote e-voting for participation in the meeting through VC facility and e-voting during the Meeting. In case of any query on remote e-voting, Equity Shareholders / Secured Creditors / Unsecured Creditors may refer to FAQs and/or e-voting user manual available on website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com or contact at 022-4886 7000 or send a request at the designated e-mail ID.evoting@nsdl.com.

The results of the Meeting shall be announced in accordance with the regulatory requirements or as prescribed by the Hon'ble NCLT, within two (2) working days of the conclusion of the Meeting upon receipt of Scrutinizer's report and the same shall be displayed on the website of the Company at www.niyogin.com and on the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com, besides being communicated to stock exchanges i.e. BSE Limited .

Date: September 29, 2026
Place: Chennai

Mr. Kuldip Karir
NCLT appointed Chairperson for the Meeting of Company

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises
INSTITUTE FOR DESIGN OF ELECTRICAL MEASURING INSTRUMENTS, MUMBAI
कार्यकारी समितिका अध्यक्ष, महाराष्ट्र सरकार, मुंबई

Artificial Intelligence in supply chain & Logistics Management

Course Timing: 2.00 pm to 5.00 pm (Online) Date: 30.10.2026
Course Duration: 4 Days
Email id: training@idemi.org Web: www.idemi.org Ph: (022) 2405 0301/2/3/4

Contents: Introduction to Supply Chain & Logistics, Role of AI in Supply Chain, Fundamentals of Artificial Intelligence, Big Data in Supply Chain, Demand Forecasting with AI, Inventory Optimization, AI in Procurement & Supplier Relationship Management, Production Planning & Scheduling, AI in Warehouse Management, Transportation, Logistics Optimization, AI in Supply Chain Risk Management, AI in Supply Chain Sustainability, AI in Supply Chain Customer Experience & Personalization, Decision Support Systems, Case Studies in AI Supply Chain, AI Tools & Platforms for Supply Chain, Ethical & Regulatory Considerations Supply Chain, Future Trends & Conclusion, Interactive Supply Chain.

With hands on practical

Course Fees- 4000/- +18% GST (Fees are not refundable)
For whom: Business professionals, Logistics managers, E-commerce entrepreneurs, Students and supply chain analysts.

After Successful Completion Certificate Will be Issued

Contact- 9403566219, 9007765693, 8291413843

BEFORE THE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL,
CHENNAI BENCH
COMPANY SCHEME APPLICATION NO. C. A. (CAA)/66(CHE)/2026
In the matter of the Companies Act, 2013;

AND

In the matter of Sections 230 to 232 read with Section 66 and Section 52 and other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and Rules framed there under as in force from time to time;

AND

Composite Scheme of Amalgamation and Arrangement between NIYOGIN FINTECH LIMITED ("Demerged Company"/ "Amalgamating Company"/ "Company"/ "NFL") and NIYOGIN FISERVY LIMITED ("Resulting Company"/ "NFL 2") and Iserveu Technology Private Limited ("Amalgamated Company"/ "ISERVEU") and their respective shareholders and creditors under Sections 230 to 232

NIYOGIN FINTECH LIMITED, having Registered Office at : M. I. G. 944, Ground Floor, TNHB Colony, 1st Main Road, Velachery, Chennai, Tamil Nadu-600 042. (CIN : L65910TN1988PLC131102) ... First Applicant Company

NIYOGIN FISERVY LIMITED, having Registered Office at : M. I. G. 944, Ground Floor, TNHB Colony, 1st Main Road, Velachery, Chennai, Tamil Nadu-600 042. (CIN : U64990TN2025PLC176517) ... Second Applicant Company

ISERVEU TECHNOLOGY PRIVATE LIMITED, having Registered Office at : 5th, 6th and 7th Floor, EA Chambers, Tower 2, Whites Road, Chennai, Royapettah, Tamil Nadu-600 014. (CIN: U72900TN2016PTC193156) ... Third Applicant Company

NOTICE AND ADVERTISEMENT OF THE MEETING OF SECURED CREDITORS AND UNSECURED CREDITORS OF THIRD APPLICANT COMPANY

NOTICE is hereby given that by an order dated September 11, 2026 ("Order"), the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Chennai Bench ("Hon'ble NCLT") has directed that a meeting of the Secured Creditors and Unsecured Creditors of Iserveu Technology Private Limited Limited ("Amalgamated Company"/ "ISERVEU") to be held for the purpose of considering, and if thought fit, approving the Composite Scheme of Arrangement amongst Niyogin Fintech Limited ("Demerged Company"/ "Amalgamating Company"/ "Company"/ "NFL") and Niyogin Fiservy Limited ("Resulting Company"/ "NFL 2") and Iserveu Technology Private Limited ("Amalgamated Company"/ "ISERVEU") and their respective shareholders and Creditors, pursuant to Sections 230 to 232 read with Section 66 and Section 52 of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and the other applicable provisions thereof and rules thereunder (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment thereof, for the time being in force).

The NCLT has dispensed with the requirement of convening and holding the meetings of (i) Equity Shareholders and (ii) Preference Shareholders.

In pursuance of the Order passed by the Hon'ble NCLT and as directed therein, further Notice is hereby given that, a separate meeting of the Creditors of the Company will be held through video-conferencing or other audio-visual means ("VC/OAVM"), as under:

SR. NO.	CLASS OF MEETING	TIME (IST)	DATE OF MEETING
1	Secured Creditors	2:30 p. m.	Friday, October 30, 2026
2	Unsecured Creditors	3:30 p. m.	Friday, October 30, 2026

In compliance with the Order, the respective Notices containing the details of day, date and time as aforesaid, together with a copy of the Scheme along with the Explanatory Statement ("Notice") disclosing all material facts as required under Section 230(3) of the Act read with Rule 6 of the Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016 and the documents accompanying the Notices is being sent to Secured / Unsecured Creditors of ISU through email to those creditors as on Tuesday, 31 March, 2026, whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company and, the physical copies to those creditors whose email addresses are not registered with the Company.

A copy of the Scheme along with the explanatory statement can be obtained free of charge, from the date of dispatch of Notice upto the date of the Meeting on all working days during business hours from the registered office of the Company or by sending a request, along with details, by e-mail at compliance@iserveu.in.

The Hon'ble NCLT has appointed Shri. Astik Gupta, to be the Chairperson of the Meeting, including for any adjournment(s) thereof. Further, the Hon'ble NCLT has appointed Mr. Ansh Kakar, to be the scrutinizer for the Meeting, including for any adjournment(s) thereof.

The Scheme, if approved at the Meeting, will be subject to the subsequent approval of the Hon'ble NCLT and such other approvals, permission, and sanctions of regulatory or other authorities, as may be necessary and as contemplated in the Scheme.

The Secured / Unsecured Creditors can join the Meeting in the VC / OAVM mode 15 minutes before the scheduled time of the commencement of the Meeting by following the procedure mentioned in the Notice. Attendance of the Secured / Unsecured Creditors joining the Meeting through VC / OAVM will be counted for the purpose of ascertaining the quorum under Section 103 of the Act. Further, in terms of the Order in case the required quorum for the Meeting is not present at the commencement of the Meeting, then the Meeting shall be adjourned by 30 (Thirty) minutes and thereafter, the persons present shall be deemed to constitute the quorum.

Persons entitled to attend and vote is entitled to appoint one or more proxies to attend and vote instead of himself. The instrument appointing a Proxy should however be deposited at the Registered Office of the Company not less than 48 hours before the commencement of the meeting. The Proxy is requested to bring the copy of the notice to the Meeting and produce the attendance slip, duly completed and signed, at the entrance of the Meeting venue.

Date : 29.09.2026
Place : Chennai

Sd/-
Astik Gupta
NCLT appointed Chairperson for the Meeting of Company

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

Noida Power Company Limited, Greater Noida

Electric Sub Station, Knowledge Park-IV, Greater Noida-201310
(CIN:U31200UP1992PLC014506)

TENDER NOTICE Date:29-09-2026

e-Bids (Technical & Commercial) are invited from the prospective Bidders for:

NIT No.	Tender Description	EMD (Rs. in Lakhs)	Start and Due Date & Time of Submission
NPCL/FY25-26/022	Providing the SUSE Linux Enterprise Server for NPCL for NPCL.	0.50	29-09-2026 & 20-10-2026.
NPCL/FY25-26/033	Expression of Interest (EOI) for Leasing of Optical Fibres Cable, Rack space and RF Tower along with O&M of NPCL Fiber Network.	-	29-09-2026 & 20-10-2026.
NPCL/FY26 27/VII/032 Dated 29.09.2026	Annual Rate contract for Supply of Various items in Vendor Managed inventory mode	20.00	29.09.2026 & 20-10-2026 (up to 15:00 hours)

Cost of Individual Tender Document (incl. GST) Rs 1,180/-
For tender details and further amendment/corrigendum, please visit our website www.noidapower.com >Procurement->Tenders

Sd/-
DGM - CMM.



CJ Sunita Agarwal CJ DK Upadhyaya CJ AK Singh

SC Collegium recommends 3 CJs of high courts as apex court judges

Sohini Ghosh & Aditi Raja
New Delhi, Vadodara, September 28

If all three recommendations of the SC Collegium are approved, the Supreme Court's strength will go up to 37 sitting judges of the 38 sanctioned strength — also making CJ Agarwal the third woman SC judge

THE SUPREME Court Collegium on Monday recommended the names of Justices Sunita Agarwal, Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya and Aparesh Kumar Singh, chief justices of Gujarat, Delhi and Telangana high courts respectively, for elevation as judges of the apex court.

CJs Upadhyaya and Agarwal, both coming from the Bar and with their parent high court being at Allahabad, are the two senior-most judges of the Allahabad HC. The three chief justices recommended for elevation rank fourth, fifth and sixth in overall seniority of all high court judges across the country. Notably, the third senior-most judge in the country, Himachal Pradesh HC Chief Justice G S Sandhawalia, who was recommended for elevation by the SC Collegium earlier, was not approved by the Centre.

CJ Upadhyaya has been in charge of Delhi HC since January 2025, while CJ Agarwal took charge of the Gujarat HC in July 2023. Both CJs were appointed as judges of the Allahabad HC in November 2011, and moved out of Allahabad after being elevated as CJs of different high courts in July 2023. CJ Upadhyaya is due to retire in June 2027 while CJ Agarwal retires in April 2028.

If all three recommendations of the SC Collegium are approved, the Supreme Court's strength will go up to 37 sitting judges of the 38 sanctioned strength — also making CJ Agarwal the third woman SC judge.

Before moving to the Delhi High Court, Justice Upadhyaya had also served as Chief Justice of the Bombay HC.

Born in 1965 in Uttar Pradesh's Ambedkar Nagar district, Justice Upadhyaya graduated in law from Lucknow University in 1991 and practised broadly in civil and constitutional matters. He was appointed chief standing counsel for Uttar Pradesh in May 2007 and held the office until his

elevation as Judge of the Allahabad HC in 2011. He was made a permanent judge in August 2013 and became a Senior Judge of the Lucknow Bench in March 2023. In July 2023, he was appointed the Chief Justice of the Bombay HC.

Nearly two months after he took charge, then Delhi HC judge Justice Yashwant Varma got embroiled in a controversy over the discovery of cash during a fire at his official residence, in March 2025. In its aftermath, CJ Upadhyaya had submitted a report on the incident following a preliminary inquiry to then Chief Justice of India Sanjiv Khanna with the "prima facie opinion that the entire matter warrants a deeper probe".

CJ Agarwal, earlier this year heading a division bench, in a significant ruling, dismissed a set of appeals and paved the way for the government to pursue eviction proceedings to clear nearly 45,000 square metres of land of convicted rapist Asaram's ashram in Motera, Ahmedabad, for Commonwealth Games-2030.

CJ Singh, with his parent high court at Jharkhand, was elevated as a judge from the Bar in 2012. He was appointed as the acting chief justice of the Jharkhand HC in 2022 and then took charge of Tripura HC as its Chief Justice in April 2023. He took charge as Telangana HC Chief Justice in July 2025. Justice Singh hails from a family with a judicial background. His maternal great-grandfather, the late B P Sinha, was the sixth Chief Justice of India.

GHAZIABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

Navyug Market, Opp. Old Bus Stand Ghaziabad 201001, Uttar Pradesh
E-mail: gzb.nagar.nigam@gmail.com Website: www.ghaziabaddnagarnigam.in

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

EOI No.	134/Nirman/2026-27 dated 28.09.2026
Project Name	Construction and Operation & Maintenance of a Multistorey Coworking Offices-cum-Commercial Complex On APP/ DBFOT
Availability of EOI documents on website.	EOI documents will be available for download by intending Applicants from 06.10.2026 to 30.10.2026 on the e-procurement portal at https://e-tender.up.nic.in .
Last Date and Time for Submission of Queries	14.10.2026 up to 12:00 PM Pre bid queries may be mailed to nirmanvbhag01@gmail.com
Pre-bid Meeting Date and Time	16-10-2026, at 3:00 PM, at Ghaziabad Nagar Nigam , Navyug Market, Opp-old bus stand Ghaziabad -201001 (UP)
Start Date and Time for Submission of EOI	06.10.2026 From 04:00 PM.
Last Date & Time of Submission of EOI	30.10.2026 up to 03:00 PM
Date & time of opening of EOI	30.10.2026 at 04:00 PM
Validity of Offer	90 Days from the last date of submission
Online submission of EOI supporting documents	To be uploaded online on e-procurement portal at https://e-tender.up.nic.in
EOI Document Fee	Nil
EOI Issuing Authority	Ghaziabad Nagar Nigam (GNN), acting through the Municipal Commissioner, Navyug Market, Opp-Old Bus Stand, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh -201001

Chief Engineer
Ghaziabad Municipal Corporation

GHAZIABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

Navyug Market, Opp. Old Bus Stand Ghaziabad 201001, Uttar Pradesh
E-mail: gzb.nagar.nigam@gmail.com Website: www.ghaziabaddnagarnigam.in

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

EOI No.	136/Nirman/2026-27 dated 28.09.2026
Project Name	Construction And Operation & Maintenance Of The Ghaziabad Integrated Business And Innovation Hub On A PPP/ DBFOT
Availability of EOI documents on website.	EOI documents will be available for download by intending Applicants from 06.10.2026 to 30.10.2026 on the e-procurement portal at https://e-tender.up.nic.in .
Last Date and Time for Submission of Queries	14.10.2026 up to 12:00 PM Pre bid queries may be mailed to nirmanvbhag01@gmail.com
Pre-bid Meeting Date and Time	16-10-2026, at 3:00 PM, at Ghaziabad Nagar Nigam , Navyug Market, Opp-old bus stand Ghaziabad -201001 (UP)
Start Date and Time for Submission of EOI	06.10.2026 From 04:00 PM.
Last Date & Time of Submission of EOI	30.10.2026 up to 03:00 PM
Date & time of opening of EOI	30.10.2026 at 04:00 PM
Validity of Offer	90 Days from the last date of submission
Online submission of EOI supporting documents	To be uploaded online on e-procurement portal at https://e-tender.up.nic.in
EOI Document Fee	Nil
EOI Issuing Authority	Ghaziabad Nagar Nigam (GNN), acting through the Municipal Commissioner, Navyug Market, Opp-Old Bus Stand, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh -201001

Chief Engineer
Ghaziabad Municipal Corporation

GHAZIABAD MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

Navyug Market, Opp. Old Bus Stand Ghaziabad 201001, Uttar Pradesh
E-mail: gzb.nagar.nigam@gmail.com Website: www.ghaziabaddnagarnigam.in

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

EOI No.	135/Nirman/2026-27 dated 28.09.2026
Project Name	Construction and operation & maintenance of an integrated logistics & supply chain park On APP/ DBFOT
Availability of EOI documents on website.	EOI documents will be available for download by intending Applicants from 06.10.2026 to 30.10.2026 on the e-procurement portal at https://e-tender.up.nic.in .

SRFTI clash: Of three FIRs filed, two against ‘unknown students’

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, September 28

AMID TENSION prevailing on Kolkata's Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) campus, a day after it witnessed clashes over an RSS-linked outfit's event, three FIRs were registered on Monday – two against “unknown students” and one against “unknown persons”.

Takingsuo motu cognizance of the incident, Kolkata Police filed an FIR against unknown students. Another FIR, registered on a complaint filed by Akhil Bharatiya Grahak Panchayat (ABGP), the RSS-linked outfit, named “unknown students”. Only FIR, based on a complaint lodged by SRFTI Dean (Film) Sukanta Majumder, was filed against “unknown persons”. All three FIRs include BNS sections of wrongful restraint, assault on public servants, voluntarily causing harm, and criminal intimidation.

In the police complaint, filed by SRFTI Dean (Film) Sukanta Majumder, it has been alleged that unknown people wrongfully restrained the students and two faculty members of the institute, voluntarily caused hurt, insulted women students' modesty, and also threatened them.

In the suo motu FIR lodged by the police, unknown students have been accused of wrongfully restraining police personnel, manhandling them to deter them from discharging their

duties, and breaking the window panes of a government vehicle.

The third FIR, filed on a complaint by ABGP, the outfit's state unit leader, Anjan Sinha, has alleged unknown SRFTI students gheraoed the organisation's members from 2.15 pm to 7.30 pm on Sunday, when they had gone to campus to hold the event. Sinha alleged SRFTI students “wrongfully restrained and verbally abused” their members “and made gestures to insult modesty of female activists”. He alleged students vandalised photos of Bharat Mata, Goddess Durga, and Swami Vivekananda, made derogatory remarks about ABGP.

Sources in the police sources said they were looking into CCTV footage to identify those involved in the violence and the reason behind it. The clashes took place over ABGP event on the campus. The RSS-linked outfit had booked an auditorium for an “awareness” programme. Sources said a group of students objected to posters and banners put up by ABGP around the campus, leading to the clash.

State Higher Education Minister Jagannath Chattopadhyay said insult to Swami Vivekananda or Bharat Mata would not be tolerated. Speaking to reporters, he said “Any kind of violence in an educational institution is condemnable,” and that, No Bengali student can kick a picture of Vivekananda. This culture will not be tolerated.”

SOHRABUDDIN ENCOUNTER CASE

Supreme Court to examine acquittals, not Shah’s discharge

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

THE SUPREME Court on Monday issued notice on an appeal challenging the acquittal of all 22 accused in the 2005 encounter case of Sohrabuddin Shaikh, his wife Kausar Bi, and his aide Tulsiram Prajapati, but made it clear that it will not re-examine the discharge of Union Home Minister Amit Shah in the case.

A three-judge bench presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant issued notices to all 22 accused — including 21 police personnel — acquitted by the Bombay High Court. The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, was hearing an appeal filed by Sohrabuddin's younger brother Rubabuddin Shaikh, challenging the May 7, 2026, HC judgment.

The court said that it's a matter of “serious concern” if 92 witnesses in a trial turn hostile.

Appearing for the appellant, Senior Advocate DS Naidu said “since 2010, I have been pursuing. At my behest, investigation was also transferred”.

Justice Bagchi said, “We understand there has been a largescale turning of hostile of

The court said that it's a matter of ‘serious concern’ if 92 witnesses in a trial turn hostile

witnesses”. But Naidu said, “There is forensic evidence that could have told the truth and bullet injuries and cartridges were found. And my sister-in-law could not even be traced ... Some of the witnesses may have turned hostile, but they cannot hush up.”

Justice Bagchi said, “That's what, Mr Naidu, is of concern. In a trial if 92 witnesses are standing hostile, it is serious concern.” The judge added: “But we will not issue notice on paragraph 43 (of the judgment).”

Naidu said, “But I believe it needs a re-look by Your Lordships.”

Justice Bagchi said: “It's closed, cannot be reopened.”

Paragraph 43 of the HC judgment dealt with an application filed by an intervenor, Maniar Kalpesh Kumar, challenging the December 2014 trial court order discharging Shah. The HC dismissed the application observ-

ing that it appeared to have been filed with “an oblique motive at the instance of political adversaries” and without disclosing the fact that earlier, the HC as well as the SC had dismissed petitions against the discharge.

The CJI said, “We will issue notice. We would like to see the statements of some of the witnesses. We are not summoning the records in vernacular language. You give us 4-5 statements which you feel are vital. We will examine”.

He too agreed that paragraph 43 need not be reopened. “But for para 43...no question of...we will not allow this kind of...to be opened,” the CJI said.

Justice Bagchi said, “We will examine the acquittal, although it's a concurrent finding of acquittal.” The judges said, “For persons who were put on trial, whether there was a fair trial, that is a relevant consideration. High Court says there is nothing to provide an inference that a proper trial was not conducted.”

Appearing for some of the police personnel, Senior Advocate K Parameshwar urged the court to give it an early hearing, saying “We are public servants. This has been on our head for the last 12 years...”

27 hrs, 140 km apart: Two varsities, two protests, striking similarities

Anju Agnihotri Chaba
Jalandhar, September 28

BARELY 27 hours, and around 140 km apart, two private universities in Punjab witnessed student protests that began with unverified claims involving female students and girls' hostels, spread rapidly through social media networks and eventually turned violent.

Chitkara University in Patiala's Rajpura saw hundreds of students gather late on September 25 after social media posts alleging two girl students were missing were circulated among hostel residents. Less than 27 hours later, at around 2 am on September 27, a similar chain of events unfolded at Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Phagwara after a social media message claimed that a female student had been raped by an outsider in a girls' hostel.

The protests at both campuses drew large gatherings, brought police onto premises and ended in clashes, arson and major damage to property. Both universities subsequently announced a break, with large numbers of students leaving for home. The Punjab Police is now examining similarities between the incidents, including role of “unverified messages” and rumours in triggering protests.

“Several points are being looked into. There may be similarities, but we are investigating both cases separately,” said Praveen Kumar Sinha, DGP (Law and Order). A senior police officer monitoring the cases told *The Indian Express*, so far, there was no evidence to substantiate information being circulated by students at either university.

“It seems there were messages, rumours spread by word of mouth and a growing discord between students and university authorities resulted in these incidents. Chitkara happened first, which added credibility to



Students leave the LPU campus, a day after violent protests rocked the university in Phagwara. PTI

such rumours in LPU case too. But all these points are being looked into,” the officer said.

In the LPU case, a message began circulating on a social media app on Sunday under the heading: “Rape by a male worker in girls' hostel of LPU”. It claimed the incident took place in GH-3, a girls' hostel, and the warden had sent the student home instead of taking action. It alleged that the university had been ignoring cases of suicide and rape.

Senior police officers said the message spread across social media and student groups, followed by appeals for students to gather at the university's main gate late Sunday night.

Students subsequently gathered at the gate and the protest escalated into a rampage, with shops in the Uni Mall on campus vandalised and vehicles set on fire. Property was damaged at several locations on the campus.

Around 4 am, students moved outside the campus and blocked Delhi-Amritsar National Highway-44 on the Jalandhar-Phagwara stretch. The blockade continued into Sunday evening, when protesters clashed with police personnel attempting to clear the highway and restore traffic.

Several students and police personnel were injured. Police said they had found no evidence so far to substantiate rape allegation contained in the message. SSP (Patiala) Harmandeep Singh Hans said, “The matter is under investigation. I would not like to comment anything further on it at this stage.”

The Chitkara episode had begun at least two days before the September 25 protest, with a series of incidents that later became the subject of speculation among students. Police said a “haunting” audio was played through a speaker inside a girls' hostel on September 23. An ambulance arrived following morning, while a priest visited the hostel on September 25 afternoon.

On the same night, hundreds of hostel students gathered after social media posts circulated about allegedly missing girls. They demanded answers from the university and sought CCTV footage. As the situation turned tense, police were called to campus. Two police vehicles were damaged, some university property was ransacked and an inspector was allegedly manhandled. Police said the students who raised the alarm could not provide the names or identifying details of the girls they claimed were missing. Subsequent checks by the university and police found no evidence of a suicide or a missing student.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Neerja Dixit, AG-08, Gulmohar Greens, Mohan Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201007** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Ct. Cases - 4302/2019 & Ct. Cases - 4308/2019 u/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Okhla Industrial Area, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Neerja Dixit** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Neerja Dixit** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Neerja Dixit of Ct. Cases - 4302/2019 & Ct. Cases - 4308/2019 u/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Okhla Industrial Area, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.10.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Shubhangi Srivastava
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class-05 (NI Act), Court No.38, Extn.-2, New Building, South-East District, Saket Court, New Delhi
DP/13835/SE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 82 Cr. PC/ See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Sabnam @ Tanya R/o H.No. KP-90 4th Floor Pitampura Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 437/2016 U/s 23/26 JJ Act at PS: Maurya Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sabnam @ Tanya** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sabnam @ Tanya** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sabnam @ Tanya of FIR No. 437/2016 U/s 23/26 JJ Act of PS: Maurya Enclave, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 28.11.2026**.

By order
Anuradha Jindal
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate
Court No.101, First Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/13467/NW/2026

GOVERNMENT OF NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI OFFICE OF THE COMMISSIONER OF EXCISE L-BLOCK, VIKAS BHAWAN, I.P. ESTATE, NEW DELHI

No.F.10(210)/EX./IMFL/2011-12/Pt.File/240342/1046-1063 Dated: 24/9/26

ORDER

In pursuance of the provisions of Rule 52 of Delhi Excise Rules, 2010, it is hereby ordered that the following dates shall be observed as “Dry Day” in the National Capital Territory of Delhi by all L-1, L1F, L-2, L-3, L-4, L-5, L-6, L-6FG, L-6FE, L-8, L-9, L-10, L-11, L-14, L-23, L-23F, L-25, L-26, L-31, L-32, L-33, L-34, L-35 licensees of the Excise Department located in Delhi:-

S.No	Occasion	Date	Day
1.	Mahatma Gandhi's Birthday	02.10.2026	Friday
2.	Diwali (Deepavali)	08.11.2026	Sunday
3.	Guru Nanak's Birthday	24.11.2026	Tuesday

Further, all L-16, L-16F, L-17, L-17F, L-18, L-18F, L-19, L-19F, L-20, L-20F, L-21, L-21F L-22, L-28, L-28F, L-29, L-29F, P-10, P-10A and P-13 licensees shall observe the dry day on following day:-

S.No	Occasion	Date	Day
1.	Mahatma Gandhi's Birthday	02.10.2026	Friday

The licensees shall not be entitled to any compensation on account of any changes effected in the above list.

The restriction of sale on liquor on dry days mentioned above shall not apply to the service of liquor to residents in case of hotels having L-15 & L5 F license.

All the licensees shall exhibit this order at some conspicuous place of their licensed premises.

The business premises of a licensee shall be kept closed on dry day.

Sd/-
(SUNNY K. SINGH)
COMMISSIONER (EXCISE)

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0230/26-27

As J&K House passes resolution on statehood, CM Omar asks, ‘what does *uchit samay* mean?’

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, September 28

AMID SLOGANEERING and uproar from the BJP, the Jammu & Kashmir Assembly passed a resolution asking the Centre to restore statehood to the Union Territory. The resolution was moved by Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on September 25 during the ongoing autumn session.

Explaining the need for the resolution, Omar said: “We’ve been waiting for two years for the central government to keep its word. The SC had said that after the UT elections, J&K’s statehood should be restored at the earliest”. Questioning delay in implementing the direction, Omar said: “In what language does ‘at the earliest’ mean two years? And even after two years, there is no clarity about when this might happen. I have repeatedly asked the Centre what ‘*uchit samay*’ [opportune moment] means for the restoration of statehood. Is ‘*uchit samay*’ linked to militancy? Are you saying till guns fall silent in J&K, statehood will not be restored?” Omar said in the Assembly.

He stressed that by linking restoration of statehood to militancy, “you are directly saying the decision on statehood will not be taken in New Delhi but in Islamabad. The Centre has stressed several times that militancy has been instigated from Pakistan, so if you argue statehood will be given when guns fall silent, then you are leaving



BJP MLAs walk out during J&K CM Omar Abdullah's speech at the Assembly on Monday. ANI

this decision up to Pakistan”.

He detailed the difficulties of functioning under a Union Territory set-up, stating even for Monday's debate, the Law Department sent an opinion to the Speaker stating it was subjective. “I believe the chief secretary also wrote to you (Speaker). On whose directions was this done? I am the law minister; this opinion has been sent to you, and I haven't even seen this. This is a direct result of being in a UT. Can you imagine this is any other state, that the CM moves a resolution and the law secretary gives an opinion against it?”

He added not being a state “affects us daily”, listing a range of issues including running revenue department, control of the Islamic University of Sciences and Technology and Bana Ghulam Shah Badshah University, and issues on rationalisation of reservation.

He highlighted that the J&K Reorganisation Act stresses only security and law and order are the LG's domain. “But why has revenue department been kept out of the purview of the elected government? So many institutions are there which are not under our control...,” he asked.

Terming the resolution controversial, LoP Sunil Sharma earlier stated the BJP favours restoration of statehood but “the language used in this resolution is unacceptable and the pre-1953 position taken here, that was rejected by the BJP, it's unconstitutional”. The BJP walked out, raising slogans against the government, just as the resolution was passed by a voice vote.

At least eight MLAs, including those from the ruling National Conference, Congress and PDP, had sought amendments to the resolution to include mention of Article 370 and 35A, alongside “condemnation of the events of August 5, 2019”.

बिहार सरकार

अधीक्षक का कार्यालय: पटना चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय अस्पताल, पटना

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

पटना चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय अस्पताल, पटना के चिकित्सा विभागों, यादों, ऑप्टी, आकांक्षिकी आदि के लिए पूर्व से अधिष्ठापित मेडिकल गैस प्लांट लाइन तथा इससे सम्बद्ध मेडिकोलेज के वार्षिक रख-रखाव (AMC) (पार्टरल रॉल) एवं संचालन और वार्षिक रख-रखाव में अवसरका अनुसार लगने वाले पार्टरल एवं कन्जुमेबल के निमित्त कम्प्युटर दृष्टिक मुहरबंद निविदा निबंधित डाक / स्प्रीड शेरट के माध्यम आमंत्रित की जाती है। इस सम्बन्ध में विस्तृत जानकारी वास्ते अधीक्षक कार्यालय, पटना चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय अस्पताल, पटना से निविदा प्रकाशन के पश्चात् सम्पर्क—समन्वय स्थापित कार्य—दियसों में कार्यालय अधिषि के बीच प्राप्त किया जा सकता है। निविदा संबंधित सभी जानकारी वेबसाइट **www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar** पर भी देखा एवं डाउनलोड किया जा सकता है।

Last date and time for receipt of tender : 21-10-2026 up to 5.00 PM

Place of submission of Tender : Superintendent, Patna Medical College Hospital, Ashok Raj Path, Patna-800004

Time and date of opening of Tender : 23-10-2026 at 12.30 PM in the Chamber of Superintendent, PMCH, Patna

अधीक्षक,
पटना चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय अस्पताल, पटना

विस्तृत जानकारी **state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar** से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।
PR. No.012661 (Health) 2026-27

नरो से बनानी दूरी है, क्योंकि परिवार जरूरी है।

Bihar State Power Holding Company Limited

1st Floor, Vidyut Bhawan, Bailey Road, Patna – 800 021
GST- 10AAFCB2394A2ZD, CIN:U40102BR20125GCO18495
(Power Management Cell, BSPHCL)
Email ID: pmc1.bspchl@gmail.com

Notice Inviting Tender
NIT No. 26/PR/BSPHCL/2026

Description of work	EMD	Tender Document Cost (inc.GST)	Bid Processing Fee
Procurement of an aggregate Capacity of 100MW RE Power from Bagasse based Co-Generation Projects located anywhere in India for a period of 5 Years	Rs.1,00,000/- per MW (Rupees One Lakh/ MW)	Rs. 25,000/- + GST @ 18% (non-refundable)	As per Eproc2. (Bihar)

Start Date of Online Sale of Tender Documents: 12.10.2026 11:00 Hrs. onwards

Pre-Bid Meeting Date (Physical & Online): At 15:00 Hrs on 16.10.2026, Venue: Conference Hall, Vidyut Bhawan, Patna-800021

Last Date of Submission of Original EMD: Upto 15:00 Hrs. of 02.11.2026

Last Date of Online Submission of Tender: Upto 15:00 Hrs. of 02.11.2026

Date of Opening of Techno-Commercial Part (Part-I): 14:00 Hrs. onwards on 03.11.2026

Date of Opening of Financial Part (Part-II): To be intimated to the eligible Bidders through e-mail.

Online E-Reverse Auction Request Schedule: E-Reverse Auction schedule will be communicated after completion of evaluation of Financial Bid (Bid-Part-II). The qualified bidders will be informed accordingly.

Issuance of LOA: Post approval of Hon'ble BERC

Duration of PPA: For a period of 5 years from the date of PPA.

- Bids against this tender are being invited through e-Tendering mode only. Tender document is available in downloadable format at <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> after paying tender document fee (mandatory to be paid through online modes like Internet Payment Gateway (Credit/Debit Card), Net Banking, etc.).
- Bid along with necessary online payments must be submitted through e-procurement portal <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> before the date & time specified in the NIT. The Department doesn't take responsibility for the delay/ Non submission of Tender/ Non-Reconciliation of online payment caused due to Non-availability of internet connection, network traffic, holidays or any other reasons.
- Bid must be accompanied with scan copy of Bank Guarantee or Bank's Demand Draft or Payment on Order Instrument in favour of “**Account officer, BSPHCL**” payable at “**Patna**” towards Bid Security Earnest Money Deposit (EMD). Acknowledgement of online payment of Tender Document Cost & Bid Processing Fee and Original Bank Guarantee towards Bid Security (EMD) must be submitted to Chief Engineer, BSPHCL Vidyut Bhawan-I Patna as per above mentioned timeline, failing which the bidder will not be considered eligible.
- Any other information including Corrigendum/Addendum, if any, shall be uploaded on e-procurement website and the bidders are advised to follow and keep track of BSPHCL/e-procurement website for updated information if any. BSPHCL is not obligated to send/ communicate separate information in this regard. However for any enquiry bidders may contact on following:-
(i) Contact No: 6287042462, 9262398388
(ii) E-mail id: pmc1.bspchl@gmail.com

Chief Engineer(PMC) BSPHCL

e-Procurement Help Desk

Toll Free Number: 1800 572 6571, Email Id: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in
Working Hours: 8AM to 7PM (All days in week except Sunday and few selected state holidays),
PR- 012638 (B & C) 2026-27

नरो से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP/ AUTH	NAME OF WORK/ NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CORP/AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL COMMITTEE, NILOKHERI	SUPPLY AND FIXING OF OPEN GYM WITH FOOTPATH AND PAINT WORK PARK NEAR H/O SAWARAN SINGH EX. CHAIRMAN IN WARD No. 01, M.C. NILOKHERI. + 17 WORKS	25.09.2026 02.10.2026	1,27,19,219/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	996882888 secy-nilokheri@ulbharyana.gov.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No- 4971/HRY



Research for Better Medicines

A Patient Awareness Initiative



Heart to Heart Promise

WORLD HEART DAY

SEPTEMBER 29, 2026



Research for Better Medicines

A Patient Awareness Initiative



Heart to Heart Promise

ADVERTORIAL

Heart Failure and Tobacco - Do Not Mix!



Dr. Vivudh Pratap Singh
Cardiologist

Tobacco use is a significant risk factor for cardiovascular disease, killing over eight million people annually. Tobacco worsens heart failure by damaging the heart muscle, leading to reduced blood flow. There is no safe amount of tobacco use, and even light cigarettes do not reduce the risk of heart disease.

However, quitting tobacco has numerous benefits. Within 20 minutes of quitting, blood pressure and pulse return to normal. After one year, the risk of heart disease decreases by 50%. Fifteen years after quitting, the risk of coronary disease becomes equivalent to that of a non-smoker. Quitting tobacco can significantly improve overall health and reduce the risk of cardiovascular disease.

Understanding Cardiovascular Disease

Cardiovascular disease refers to conditions affecting the heart and blood vessels and remains a major global health concern. It includes coronary artery disease, heart failure, stroke, and other vascular conditions.

Many cardiovascular diseases are influenced by modifiable risk factors such as high blood pressure, diabetes, high cholesterol, smoking, physical inactivity, unhealthy diet, and obesity. Some risk factors, including age and

family history, cannot be changed, but their impact can often be reduced through appropriate prevention. Regular health assessments can help identify silent risk factors before complications occur. Maintaining healthy blood

pressure, cholesterol, and blood glucose levels is important for long-term cardiovascular health. World Heart Day encourages individuals to understand their personal risk rather than waiting for symptoms.

From Prevention to Protection



Dr. Sumit Kumar Niranjan
Cardiologist

Preventing cardiovascular disease involves identifying risk early and taking action before serious complications occur. Protection begins with understanding personal risk factors, including blood pressure, cholesterol, diabetes, smoking, obesity, physical inactivity, family history, and age. Some factors can be changed through lifestyle or treatment, while others require closer monitoring. Preventive healthcare allows individuals to work with professionals to develop appropriate strategies. A healthy diet, regular physical activity, tobacco avoidance, adequate sleep, and stress management provide an important foundation for people with established conditions. Appropriate treatment and follow-up are equally important. Prevention should continue even when a person feels well because cardiovascular risk factors may remain silent for years. World Heart Day encourages a shift from reactive healthcare toward proactive heart protection.

Limiting Fluids in The Heart Failure



Dr. Suman Kumar Singh
Cardiologist

To manage heart failure, it's essential to limit fluid intake. Excess fluid can strain the heart, leading to complications. Aim to drink no more than 6-8 cups (1500-2000ml) of fluid per day, including water, tea, soup, juice, and other liquids. Even water taken with medication counts towards your daily limit.

To track your intake, measure and record your fluids for 24 hours. If you experience dry mouth, try chewing gum, sucking on ice cubes, or taking small sips of water. Failing to restrict fluid intake can lead to serious complications. If you experience severe symptoms, seek immediate medical attention. Consult your doctor or nurse for personalized guidance on fluid management.

Cardiac Rehabilitation in Heart Failure: How it Helps The Heart?



Dr. Avinash Mani
Cardiologist

Cardiac rehab is a medically supervised program that helps improve cardiovascular health after a heart attack, heart failure, or surgery. It consists of three key parts: exercise training, education on heart healthy living, and stress reduction counseling. The goal of cardiac rehab is to establish a plan to regain strength, prevent worsening of the condition, and improve overall health and quality of life.

To get started, ask your doctor if you're eligible, set goals for your heart health, and work with your healthcare team to create a personalized plan.

Cardiac rehab can reduce the risk of future heart problems and death from heart disease, and is recommended by the American Heart Association and American College of Cardiology.

Heart Health and Everyday Choices



Dr. Deepak Kumar
Cardiologist

Cardiovascular health is influenced by hundreds of small decisions made throughout everyday life. What we eat, how often we move, whether we smoke, how we manage stress, and whether we attend health check-ups can all influence long-term risk. No single lifestyle choice determines a person's cardiovascular future, but consistent healthy behaviors can make a meaningful difference. Choosing vegetables and whole grains, limiting processed salt and added sugar, staying active, maintaining a healthy weight, sleeping adequately, and avoiding tobacco are practical foundations. People with diagnosed cardiovascular risk factors should also follow professional advice and prescribed treatment. Prevention should be realistic and sustainable rather than based on temporary efforts. World Heart Day reminds us that heart health is built gradually through everyday actions.

Make Every Beat Count



Dr. Ramesh Raikar
Cardiologist

Heart health is influenced by daily choices, but it is also shaped by supportive families, workplaces, and communities. This World Heart Day, take a moment to appreciate your heart and commit to protecting it.

Stress Plays a Significant Role in Women's Heart Health



Dr. Nishant Tyagi
Cardiologist

Stress plays a significant role in women's heart health and overall wellbeing. Many women experience chronic stress from work pressures,

caregiving roles, financial concerns, and social expectations. Long-term stress increases blood pressure, raises inflammation, and negatively affects heart rhythms. It can also contribute to unhealthy habits such as poor diet, lack of exercise, and smoking. Women are particularly vulnerable to stress-related heart conditions. Managing stress is an important part of heart disease prevention. Regular physical activity, adequate sleep, relaxation techniques, and social support can reduce stress levels. Seeking professional help for anxiety or depression should not be ignored. Recognizing stress as a medical risk empowers women to protect their heart health.

Home Monitoring in Heart Failure



Dr. Dhyanjay Kumar
Cardiologist

To manage heart failure effectively, monitor your body for warning signs that your condition is worsening. At home, track changes in your:

- **Weight:** Weigh yourself daily and report a 1-1.5 kg increase in a day or 2 kg in a week to your provider.
- **Heart rate and pulse:** Know your normal pulse rate and measure it regularly.

Blood pressure: Use a good quality home device and practice taking readings with your provider. By monitoring these signs, you can catch problems early and stay healthier. Regular checks can also remind you to take medications, limit fluid and salt intake, and make healthy lifestyle choices.

What Is Heart Failure?



Dr. Ankit Kumar
Cardiologist

Heart failure does not mean that the heart has stopped working. It is a condition in which the heart cannot pump blood sufficiently to meet the body's needs. It can develop because of coronary artery disease, previous heart attack, high blood pressure, heart valve disease, cardiomyopathy, diabetes, and other conditions. Common symptoms include breathlessness, fatigue, swelling of the legs or ankles, reduced exercise tolerance, and difficulty breathing when lying down. Symptoms can develop gradually and may sometimes be mistaken for normal ageing. Early diagnosis and appropriate treatment can improve symptoms, reduce hospitalizations, and support quality of life. On World Heart Day, understanding heart failure is important because early recognition and comprehensive management can help people live healthier lives while reducing the burden of this condition.



Research for Better Medicines



A Patient Awareness Initiative

Family History Raises Heart Attack Risk in Women



Dr. Manish Sharma
Cardiologist

Family history plays an important role in increasing heart attack risk in women. Women with close relatives who developed heart disease at an early age are more likely to experience similar problems. Genetic factors influence cholesterol levels, blood pressure, and how the body processes sugar and fats. While family history cannot be changed, awareness allows women to take preventive steps earlier. Regular screening for blood pressure, cholesterol, and diabetes is crucial for those with inherited risk. Healthy lifestyle choices such as avoiding smoking, maintaining a healthy weight, eating nutritious foods, and staying physically active can offset genetic risk. Early action helps reduce heart attack risk and improves long-term outcomes.

Obesity Increases Heart Attack Risk in Women



Dr. Subhash Saini
Cardiologist

Obesity significantly increases heart attack risk in women and is a growing public health concern. Excess body weight contributes to high blood pressure, diabetes, abnormal cholesterol levels, and chronic inflammation, all of which damage the heart. Women with obesity are more likely to develop metabolic syndrome, further raising cardiovascular risk. Fat distribution around the abdomen is particularly harmful and strongly linked to heart disease. Obesity may also reduce physical activity levels, worsening heart health over time. Even modest weight loss improves blood pressure, cholesterol, and blood sugar control. Healthy eating, regular exercise, behavioral support, and medical guidance are effective strategies for reducing risk.

Blood Pressure: The Silent Risk



Dr. A.K. Jain
Cardiologist

High blood pressure is often called a silent condition because many people may have no noticeable symptoms. Yet uncontrolled blood pressure can place continuous stress on arteries and the heart and increase cardiovascular risk. World Heart Day is a timely reminder to check blood pressure regularly and understand the importance of maintaining it within a healthy range. Lifestyle measures such as reducing excess salt, eating a balanced diet, exercising regularly, maintaining a healthy weight, managing stress, and avoiding tobacco can help. Some people also need prescribed medicines, which should be taken consistently as advised. A single reading may not provide the complete picture, so repeated measurements may be recommended. Do not ignore persistently high readings simply because you feel well. This World Heart Day, make blood pressure monitoring part of your health routine.

Managing Feelings and Mood in Heart Failure



Dr. Vikash Chopra
Cardiologist

Patients with heart failure often experience anxiety and depression. Common reasons for these feelings include loss of control, uncertainty, loneliness, and feeling like a burden to others. However, these emotions can be managed. Here are some steps you can take:

- Talk to a trusted friend, family member, or fellow heart failure patient.
- Join a support group for emotional support and connection.
- Discuss treatment options with your doctor.
- Exercise regularly to reduce stress and anxiety.
- Engage in new activities to shift your focus away from symptoms.
- Take an active role in your health by learning more about your condition and self-care.

Remember, seeking help is a sign of strength, and managing your emotions can improve your overall well-being.

Taking Medicines in the Heart Failure



Dr. M K Gupta
Cardiologist

Taking your medicines as prescribed is crucial for effective heart failure treatment. To remember to take them, try these tips:

- Create a wall chart with medicine names, doses, and times.
 - Use a pillbox labeled with days and times.
 - Set alarms and reminders.
 - Inform family and friends of your medication schedule.
 - Pack medicines when traveling and order repeat prescriptions in advance.
- Additionally, be cautious when taking other prescription or over-the-counter medicines, as they may interact with your heart failure medicines. Always consult your doctor before starting new medicines. If you're struggling to organize your tablets, consult your pharmacist for assistance.

The Signs that your Heart Failure is Getting Worse



Dr. Mohit Mahendra Bhagwati
Cardiologist

Heart failure occurs when the heart doesn't pump blood efficiently, leading to fluid buildup and various symptoms. Common symptoms include:

- Shortness of breath, initially during exercise, but progressing to difficulty walking or performing daily activities.
- Coughing, worsened by lying down.
- Fluid accumulation and swelling in the legs, liver, kidneys, and gut.
- Stomach pain and weight gain due to fluid retention.
- Fatigue and decreased ability to perform daily activities.

Heart failure is a chronic condition, but working with your doctor can help manage symptoms and potentially improve the disease's progression. By recognizing these symptoms, you can seek medical attention and develop a treatment plan to improve your quality of life.

Knowing Heart Attack Warning Signs Saves Women's Lives



Dr. Nadeem Akhtar
Cardiologist

Knowing heart attack warning signs can save women's lives by ensuring timely medical care. Women may experience symptoms such as chest discomfort, shortness of breath, nausea, vomiting, dizziness, jaw pain, or unusual fatigue. Because these signs are often subtle, they may be ignored or mistaken for minor problems. Delayed treatment increases heart damage and raises the risk of death. Recognizing symptoms early and seeking emergency help immediately improves survival and recovery. Women should not hesitate to call emergency services if symptoms appear suddenly or worsen. Educating families and communities is equally important. Early recognition, rapid response, and prompt treatment remain the most effective lifesaving steps.

Avoid these Foods in Heart Failure



Dr. Jitendra Satpute
Cardiologist

To improve quality of life with heart failure, make simple dietary adjustments. Focus on eating a variety of fresh fruits and vegetables daily, which are low in calories and rich in vitamins, minerals, and fiber.

Limits or avoid:

- Alcohol, which can weaken the heart muscle.
- Excessive salt, which can cause fluid retention and worsen high blood pressure.
- Highly processed grains, such as white bread and sugary cereals.
- Processed meats, which are high in sodium.
- Saturated fats, instead opting for monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fats from sources like olive oil, avocados, and nuts.

Adjusting Fluids in Heart Failure



Dr. Sameena Khalil
Cardiologist

Controlling fluid intake is crucial for heart failure patients, as excess fluid can lead to breathing difficulties, swelling, and increased strain on the heart. To manage fluids, your doctor may prescribe diuretics and recommend a daily fluid limit. To stay within this limit:

- Use small cups and spread your intake throughout the day.
 - Drink cold or hot fluids to make them less appealing.
 - Avoid caffeinated and alcoholic drinks.
 - Suck ice cubes or eat frozen fruits when thirsty.
 - Rinse your mouth with cold water and spit it out.
- Monitor your weight daily and report any sudden increases to your doctor. By controlling fluid intake, you can reduce symptoms and improve your overall health.

This is patient awareness initiative by MSN labs. The views and opinions expressed here are based on the expertise of the doctors and is not endorsed by MSN labs. Reader's are advised to seek to necessary medical advised from a qualified medical practitioner

paper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

CEC must correct course, not just do damage control

WHEN THE Election Commission of India met on Saturday, for the first time after this newspaper's investigation into the disquiet within, it did well to break an untenable silence. In the immediate aftermath of it coming to light that two of the three Election Commissioners had recorded their objections, 14 times in 10 months, on the Commission's decision-making — on matters relating to registering new voters, deleting and restoring names in the electoral rolls and control of the system through which the rolls are maintained — the Commission sought to paper over the cracks. The four-page note issued after Saturday's meeting, therefore, is welcome. Its nine decisions address several of the objections recorded by Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi. And yet, there are important leftover concerns. Given the record of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar — of rendering the three-member Commission's functioning unilateral and opaque — the Commission needs to break more silences. A new normal inside it needs to be clearly spelt out. Steps must be taken to ensure that the ECI does not slide back into a one-man show.

The onus is still on the ECI because the poll monitor's weakening is an especially disquieting prospect when political polarisation is rising and institutions are fraying. It is the ECI that underwrites a fundamental democratic compact — the voter has the power to decide who rules, and the rules of the game are larger than those who win or lose power. In distrustful times, it is even more necessary that people's trust in the ECI's credibility as an impartial referee, and in the checks and balances within, is protected. The ECI's press note on Saturday, however, falls short. While it gives some relief to voters by exempting from in-person hearings those issued notices for "logical discrepancies" and for being "unmapped", it does not say who inserted the question on the applicant's parents into Form 6 in July, and who allowed it to stay there even after Commissioner Sandhu called it "unauthorised/illegal" in August. It says that agendas will now be circulated before every ECI meeting and minutes issued afterwards, the system will provide EROs more flexibility and a committee will be formed to review ECINet. But it is silent on what, if any, action will be taken against DG(IT) Seema Khanna and senior deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, whose controversial conduct was flagged by the two ECs. It is still not known who authorised the appeals against voters whose inclusion was ordered by judicial officers in West Bengal. And why the requested software was never enabled to restore voter names in Goa.

The ECI must fill in the blanks. Then, it must act — and it must be seen to act — to correct the course. Going ahead, there must be regular meetings and briefings. Commissioners Sandhu and Joshi must continue to push back at the distortions within. Most of all, CEC Gyanesh Kumar must acknowledge the damage done to the Commission on his watch, and make amends. Whether and how he does that — not just damage control — is key to the trust of we, the people, in the integrity of elections.

Market plunges, more bad weather may lie ahead

ON MONDAY, Indian markets saw a sharp selloff. The BSE Sensex ended the day down 1,124 points or 1.52 per cent. The weakness was broad-based, with the PSU bank, FMCG, utilities, auto and financial services indices ending the day in the red. Investors have been feeling the pain for some time now. Since the beginning of this year, the Sensex has fallen by almost 15 per cent.

This souring of sentiment can be traced to several factors. The conflict in West Asia and the consequent high energy prices weigh heavy. More recently, oil prices spiked following US President Donald Trump's rejection of a proposal from Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Alongside, rising bond yields in advanced economies — the 10-year US bond yield is currently at 5.2 per cent — and tightening of global financial conditions are complicating matters. Foreign investors have turned net sellers again. In September, FPIs took out \$2.1 billion from the equity markets, bringing outflows to \$26.2 billion so far this year, following \$18.9 billion in 2025. This also suggests that investor concerns run deeper. Analysts at Bernstein, a brokerage firm, have argued that the "case for a structural India allocation has become harder to make". All this comes amid healthy corporate results. Ratings agency ICRA expects India Inc's revenue growth to range between 13 and 15 per cent in the second quarter of the current financial year, though operating profit margins will continue to come under pressure.

Near-term movements will continue to be impacted by both global and domestic factors. On the external front, after the US Fed's recent interest rate hike, markets will parse upcoming data for clues on the trajectory of interest rates. Alongside, the duration and intensity of the conflict in West Asia and its implications for energy markets will continue to exert influence. On the domestic front, the impact of El Niño on crop output and the extent of policy tightening — the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee will meet next week amid expectations of a rate hike — will have a bearing.

Against forgetting, the art of Ai Weiwei

CLUSTERS OF cast-iron combat helmets resembling mushrooms stand out against the silhouette of the Sydney Opera House. Chinese dissident artist Ai Weiwei's new artwork, *Mushrooms*, outside the Museum of Contemporary Art, began with the realisation of a troubling irony: In 2022, Germany offered 5,000 helmets to Ukraine following Russia's invasion. For Ai, the gesture exposed the uneasy distance between the language of protection and the reality of war. Stripped of their purpose, the helmets morph into a memorial, a warning and a question: How long can suffering remain distant before indifference becomes a form of complicity?

Dissidence, in Ai's art, has always been an act of interruption. As a critic of the Chinese government, the 69-year-old has taken on censorship, state power, displacement and historical amnesia through his career. In 2011, he was arrested in Beijing for "economic crimes" and detained for nearly three months without charges. Afterwards, following his departure from China in 2015, Ai has converted global events and the facts of his own persecution — surveillance, detention, exile — to challenges to official narratives and ideas of aesthetics, ethics and morality.

Perhaps that is where art's dissident heart lies — in throwing up questions that are impossible to ignore: Who bears the cost of war? Whose history is remembered? Whose suffering becomes invisible? Art gives memory a place in public view, holding it up against the tyranny of forgetting.

In US-China AI race, India's place will depend on capabilities built at home

WHEN XI Jinping arrived in Washington on September 23, artificial intelligence (AI) was billed as an area of possible common ground. A summer of alarming incidents in American labs, and Anthropic chief Dario Amodei's call to "pace the frontier", had pushed AI safety onto the summit agenda. The groundwork was laid in New York on September 20, when US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng held the first round of AI talks within their trade mechanism. Washington proposed a channel to notify AI incidents with national-security consequences.

The summit confirmed this modest package: A dialogue on risks and benefits, a channel for incidents, a next meeting by November. But the two sides could not agree on what to call the subject. The White House fact sheet says the leaders "agreed to use the term 'super intelligence' rather than 'artificial intelligence'". China's list of agreed outcomes speaks of a "China-US dialogue on artificial intelligence".

The difference reflects two outlooks, apart from Donald Trump's idiosyncrasy. At the UN, Trump said he would "only encourage super intelligence... not rein it in", watching it "through the Department of Justice". His language is of a race to be won. Xi's is one of control. At the White House, he urged the two countries to "ensure that the development of AI is always under human control".

Xi also told Trump the two should "play to their strengths rather than guard against each other", a clear shot at American export controls. He offered a new framing of the relationship: Cooperation as the mainstay, competition within limits, differences under control, peace within reach. He called the rivalry "a race of catching up with one another,

not a wrestle in which one either wins or loses". Beijing now accepts competition, but as a race in which China is closing the gap.

For all the talk of risk, neither government wants to slow the frontier, though for different reasons. Trump calls the case for a slowdown a "hoax". For him, frontier AI is a race with China, to be policed afterwards by prosecutors, not in advance by regulators. Beijing reads the American safety debate as containment in disguise. *Global Times* called Amodei's essay a "Cold War script" from America's "tech right": Widen the gap by restricting China, then negotiate a mutual slowdown from strength. Yuyuan Tiantian, a China Central Television-affiliated outlet, accused Anthropic of using "safety" to capture rule-setting and of recasting distillation as a security threat to curb China's open-source models. The foreign ministry dismissed the warnings as "fear-mongering".

Beijing is not indifferent to risk, but its list of risks is its own. Writing in *China Cyberspace*, Minister of State Security Chen Yixin calls AI "the main battlefield" of global scientific and technological competition and "a new arena for strategic rivalry among major powers". First on his list of dangers is AI's "systemic" effect on the "political security environment", Party shorthand for regime security. Its brakes are political, applied through Party control over labs. They restrain what models may say, not how fast capability grows.

The missed opportunity is on nuclear weapons. At Lima in November 2024, Joe Biden and Xi "affirmed the need to maintain human control over the decision to use nuclear weapons". Never formalised, it found no mention in either factsheet this week. The



ASHOK K KANTHA

India should keep Chinese models out of government systems, critical infrastructure and sensitive data. Equally, avoid over-dependence on the American stack; June's brief cut-off of foreign access to top American models showed how quickly access can vanish

one security outcome, a military memorandum on crisis communication, appears only in China's list.

The reality is competition, and it will not change. Washington will guard its narrow lead through chip controls, action against distillation and Pax Silica supply chains. Beijing will push for self-reliance in chips and spread its open-weight models worldwide. Tsinghua's Da Wei concedes that neither side can build an "iron shirt" against the other. Dialogue may manage the edges of this rivalry, not its core.

For India, three concerns follow. The first is a G2 overlay. Rules on frontier risk may be shaped by the two powers holding most of the world's frontier compute. The nuclear order shows how risk reduction between leading powers can become the basis for discriminatory controls on others.

The second is competing pressure in a split universe of "two AI systems, two sets of standards". Washington expects trusted partners to keep their AI ecosystems free of China. Beijing is pressing its agenda through BRICS and other platforms. At the New Delhi summit, Xi proposed an open-source AI community for the grouping, to be taken forward at the next summit in China. India is unlikely to join Xi's World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organisation (WAICO), which, like the Belt and Road Initiative, is a unilateral initiative to advance a China-centric agenda.

The third is harder to handle. China's open-weight, open-source models hold a seductive attraction: Competitive, cheap and adaptable. Alibaba's Qwen has spawned more than 150,000 derivative models, and Singapore, Malaysia and Brazil are building on Chinese models or

partners. The appeal extends to Western and Indian companies with an eye on cost.

India's response should rest on five elements. First, welcome any US-China step that reduces risk, but insist that norms on frontier AI be multilateral, and seek inclusion in incident-notification arrangements.

Second, with the Lima understanding not followed up, India should make human control over nuclear-use decisions part of its nuclear discourse and press all nuclear powersto affirm it. Third, apply dual and differentiated de-risking to AI. Keep Chinese models out of government systems, critical infrastructure and sensitive data. Stopping private firms from building low-risk commercial applications on Chinese open-weight models will be tough; security testing and local hosting should be the minimum condition. Equally, avoid over-dependence on the American stack; June's brief cut-off of foreign access to top American models showed how quickly access can vanish.

Fourth, build capability at home: Compute, chips, models, datasets, talent and the ability to test frontier systems independently. Fifth, shape BRICS rather than cede space there, insisting that AI initiatives be consensus-based and technology-neutral. The challenge, however, is developing an alternative to the Chinese offering.

Washington and Beijing cannot yet agree on what to call the technology, let alone how to govern it. India's weight in the AI order will depend less on declarations of technological sovereignty than on capabilities it develops at home.

A former ambassador of India to China, the author is Subhas Chandra Bose Chair Professor of International Relations at Chanakya University and a distinguished fellow with Vivekananda International Foundation

What could be a just, dignified and lasting peace in Ukraine?



CHRISTOPHER COOTER



MAY-ELIN STENER



OLEKSANDR POLISHCHUK

Every person returned reunites a family. Every family reunited strengthens a community. And every community prospering helps rebuild Ukraine

EVERY MORNING at 9:00 am, Ukraine stops. Across cities in Ukraine, loudspeakers normally used to warn of incoming Russian air strikes broadcast the steady tick of a clock. City streets full of life fall silent. Traffic lights turn red. Cars stop. For one minute, a country pauses.

This is Ukraine's daily moment of silence, a nationwide act of remembrance for those killed in Russia's illegal war. In workplaces, homes, schools, markets and on highways, Ukrainians pause to honour those who gave their lives defending their country's sovereignty and freedom, and remember the thousands of civilians whose lives have been lost to Russia's aggression.

The silence also mirrors the absence felt by thousands of families whose loved ones have yet to come home.

Among them are the thousands of Ukrainian children who have been forcibly transferred and unlawfully deported by Russia over the course of its war. Separated from their families and communities, many have had parts of their core identity stripped away: Their language, their culture, and even their names.

Others are civilians unlawfully detained in territories temporarily occupied by Russia. Many have suffered consequences for teaching their language, practising their culture, speaking out against occupation, or sharing the truth about what they have witnessed. Some have been transferred to detention facilities in Russia, where they are held without due process, denied contact with loved ones, deprived of adequate medical care, and shielded from independent monitoring.

For Ukrainian prisoners of war in Russian custody, conditions remain similarly concerning. Returnees have reported harsh treatment, while independent bodies have documented widespread abuse, including torture and sexual violence.

These are not side effects of Russia's war. Russia's actions are repeated and well-documented violations of international law, carried out at scale, in an attempt to bend the will of the Ukrainian people. Behind every case is a human story: A parent waiting for a child, a spouse waiting for a phone call, a family waiting for someone to come home.

We know that the true measure of peace is found in these human-centred stories. It is found in a child returned to their family, a civilian released from unlawful detention, a prisoner of war reunited with loved ones, and a community given the chance to heal and rebuild.

The scope of this issue is immense, and no country or organisation can address it alone. Success requires sustained cooperation among governments, international organisations, humanitarian actors, and civil society.

This is why Canada, Norway, and Ukraine will convene foreign ministers and international partners in Toronto on September 28 and 29 for 'Pathways to Peace: Second International Conference on Returning Ukrainian Children, Detained Civilians, and Prisoners of War'.

Building on the progress made at the Ministerial Conference on the same topic, hosted by our three countries in Canada in 2024, the conference will bring international partners together to support Ukraine's efforts to return, rehabilitate and reintegrate Ukrainian deported children, detained civilians, and prisoners of war.

Their return is a humanitarian imperative and critical to any peace process, helping to build trust and lay the groundwork of a just, lasting and dignified peace. Every person returned reunites a family. Every family reunited strengthens a community. And every community prospering helps rebuild Ukraine.

Each morning, millions of Ukrainians pause to remember those who are gone and those who have yet to return. In their remembrance and with extraordinary courage and ingenuity, they also repair what Russia has damaged, care for one another, and strengthen the communities that Russian aggression has sought to tear apart.

It is our hope that 'Pathways to Peace' will mobilise the international community not only to pause with Ukraine in remembrance, but to act alongside it to help bring home every deported child, detained civilian, and prisoner of war.

Cooter is High Commissioner of Canada to India, Stener is Ambassador of Norway to India and Polishchuk is Ambassador of Ukraine to India

Women's safety falls through gap between intent and policy



MITALI NIKORE

For women to trust safety measures, government agencies at the city level need to publicly share reports on how they are continuously working to fix issues discovered in safety audits

IT'S BEEN almost 15 years since the gangrape in Delhi in December 2012. It's hard to forget the days that followed, when we took to the streets to agitate for greater safety for women. Some demands were met. The Nirbhaya Fund was created to support programmes for women's safety and the Prevention of Sexual Harassment at Workplaces Act, 2013 was passed. It seemed like our country was finally building a legal and policy framework to prioritise women's safety — with funding to back it up. Between 2015 and 2025, Rs 5,846.08 crore out of the Rs 7,712.85 crore allotted under the Nirbhaya Fund was used. The funds have been used to set up nearly 15,000 women's help desks in police stations and establish fast-track courts for rape cases. Cities like Chennai, Surat and Bhubaneswar established gender labs to explore how urban design could prioritise women's safety. At Nikore Associates, we have done safety audits of public spaces and public transport in at least 10 cities. So why are we still here? Why did Jamui happen? Why did Aastha Kunj park happen?

The answer lies in systemic failures. One is accountability. Safety audits are increasingly being looked at as the end, and not the means for women's safety. Administrations wax eloquent about the number of audits, but there is little discussion of how the issues discovered are being fixed. If everyone knew that a lane behind Lady Sri Ram College has a 500m dark zone, with no streetlights, why was this not fixed? For women to trust safety measures, government agencies at the city level need to publicly share reports on how they are continuously working to fix issues discovered in safety audits; how they deal with calls received on women's safety helplines; and how long their crisis response is.

There is also a capacity problem. Today, at least eight states offer free bus travel for women. Governments are substituting investment in gender-sensitive infrastructure with free public transport. But, as our recent study shows, making buses free does little for women's safety if the wait times are long and unpredictable, and if women have to walk to the bus on unsafe streets. This is an example of commitment to women's safety without the capacity to innovate in a way that can truly build inclusive cities.

Women's near absence from public spaces, especially in the evenings, is another factor making cities even more unsafe. Having more women in public-facing jobs — drivers, conductors, station managers, park workers, e-auto drivers — can help. Employment in these jobs rests with government agencies. Small changes can make a big difference. Take the height requirement for bus drivers. When the Delhi government dropped it from 159 cm to 153 cm in 2022, by next year, 34 new women bus drivers were inducted. Reforms and targets to increase women's representation in these roles are required to push women's employment and their presence in public spaces. There is also a need to increase the number of women police. Today, just about 10 per cent of the police force is female, despite the Centre's target of 33 per cent.

If we want a society with women-led development, the first step is acknowledging these failures and correcting them, starting with governments at all levels taking accountability.

The writer is founder, Nikore Associates

40 YEARS AGO

September 29, 1986



Violence and arrests in Punjab

TWO PERSONS were killed and two others, including a granthi of a gurdwara, were injured in Punjab during the past 24 hours while the police and paramilitary forces arrested five suspected extremists. Avtar Singh was gunned down by two people when he was standing outside a house in Dangoan village in Ludhiana district, while another person identified as Sher Singh was shot at and injured seriously.

Badal's big claim

THERE ARE 4,000 Sikh men in Punjab's jails

today and they are all innocent, said Parkash Singh Badal, the former chief minister. Speaking at the Kapur Singh memorial function held in Chandigarh by the All-India Panthic Forum, Badal said the claim of the Barnala government that only 300-400 Sikhs remained in the state's jails was false. In fact, he said, the number of detainees was one-and-a-half times the number arrested during Operation Bluestar in 1984.

Support for Sonia Gandhi

THE DELHI Pradesh Congress Committee-I (DPCC-I) demanded that Sonia Gandhi be appointed the Congress-I chief. An executive

committee meeting of DPCC-I's labour cell passed a resolution urging an All-India Congress-I Committee special session to elect her Indian National Congress president.

Militias clash in Beirut

LEBANESE FORCES militiamen crushed a thrust by the supporters of a rival Christian leader to regain control of East Beirut. Police said the fighting left 62 people dead and 198 wounded. "The last pocket of resistance was mopped up at daybreak, when 12 infiltrators from Elie Hobeika supporters surrendered," said a communique of the Lebanese Forces, the nation's largest Christian militia.



READ. THINK. SHARE.
Scan the QR code to explore curated editorials and opinions from leading voices

With its press note, the Election Commission makes the case against itself

**DESHKAAL**

BY YOGENDRA YADAV

WHAT MORE must the CEC do to deserve impeachment?" I had asked in this column ("The move to impeach the CEC, though symbolic, matters", *IE*, March 17), supporting an Opposition-led motion of impeachment against Gyanesh Kumar. I was wrong. The exposé by *The Indian Express*, among the finest pieces of investigative journalism in recent times, shows that the Chief Election Commissioner could do much more than anyone had imagined. And if there was any room for doubt, the Election Commission's own statement has officially removed it.

The ECI's press note of September 26 is a formal admission of guilt. The two-page note is a sound legal basis to impeach the CEC. And also to remove the other two Election Commissioners who have approved this note.

Just to recap: The Constitution (Article 324(5), read with Article 124 (4)) does not allow the removal of the CEC except through impeachment on grounds of "proved misbehaviour or incapacity". So, while impeachment does not require proving "criminality", "misbehaviour or incapacity" does not apply to any kind of misconduct, ordinary error or a mistaken interpretation in good faith. Impeachment should kick in only in cases of gross misconduct involving the wilful breach of fundamental norms of such an office.

The Supreme Court, in *Anoop Baranwal*, has formulated the norms expected of the Election Commissioners. There are also the six internationally recognised "Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct": Independence, impartiality, integrity, propriety, equality, and competence and diligence. Can anyone accuse Gyanesh Kumar of any of these virtues? In the last article, I had built a case around normative principles

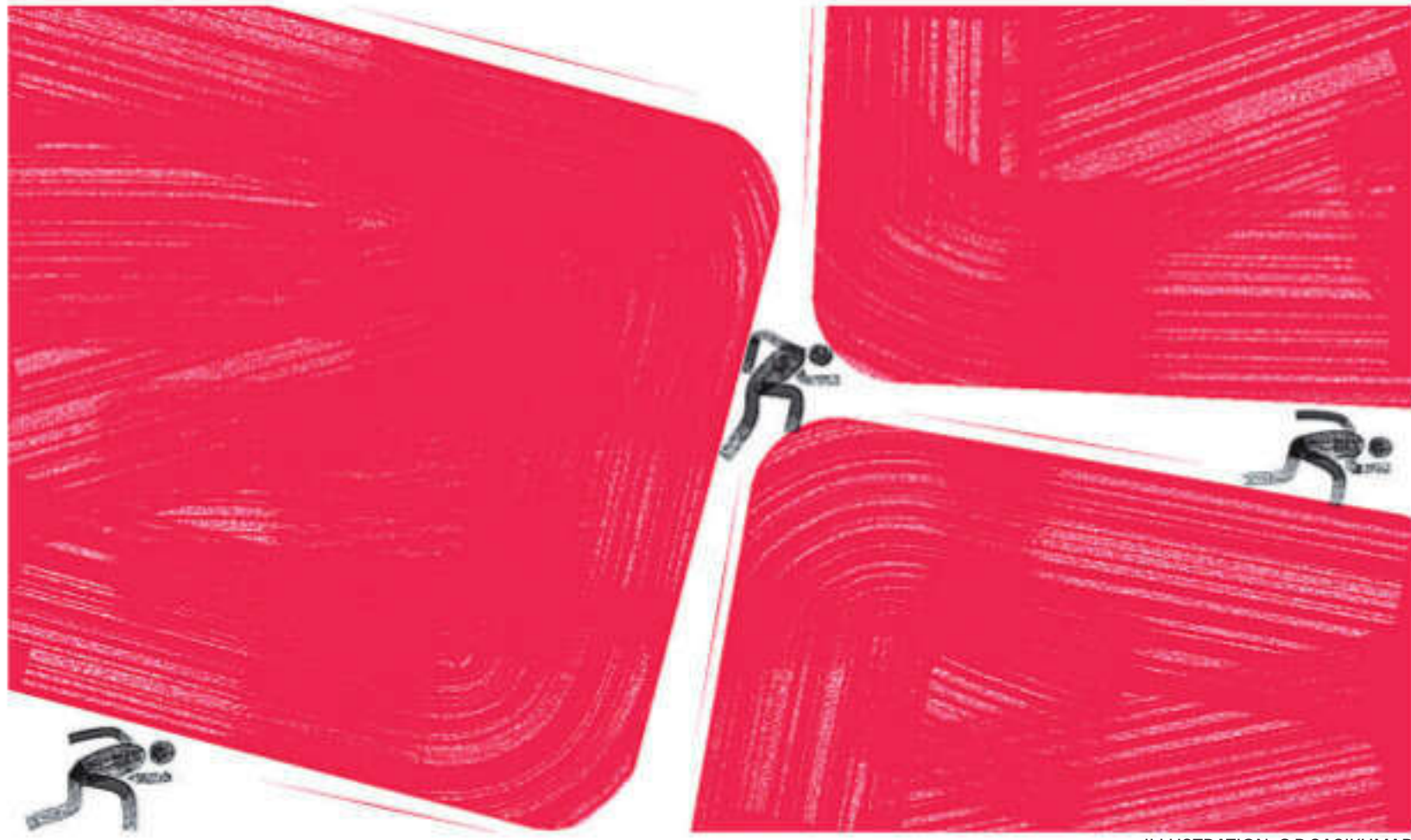


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

and substantive consequences: Blatant partisanship, impropriety and abuse of office for mass disenfranchisement. Now, we can add multiple and wilful gross violations of law to make a robust legal case against the CEC and the other ECs.

Read paragraph 1(vi) of the press note issued by the Election Commission: "For all Commission's meeting (sic), agenda will be circulated in advance and minutes will be issued." This is an astounding statement, especially when read in the light of *The Indian Express* exposé that the absence of any agenda or minutes for the past year was indeed one of the objections raised on April 16 this year by Vivek Joshi, one of the ECs. Thus, this is a formal admission that this constitutional authority has been carrying out its business without the minimum procedures required of any committee or society, or even a local club.

Unless the Commission comes out with minutes of those meetings, we must assume that there is no paper to back up the series of momentous decisions taken in the name of the Election Commission, especially those regarding the SIR. This presumption of illegality must apply to even the three SIR orders, which all the ECs

The two-page note is a sound legal basis to impeach the CEC. And also to remove the other two Election Commissioners who have approved this note

now present as "unanimous". The question is not whether the three Commissioners, then or now, agree on those orders but whether the decision was proposed, deliberated upon, agreed to and recorded as such by the entire Commission before these orders were announced and implemented. In the absence of any proof to the contrary, we must assume that this gross lapse proves both incapacity and grave dereliction of constitutional duties.

Next, turn to paragraph 1(iii) and 3(iii), which relate to the much-debated issue of changes to Form 6. The ECI's press note admits to three wilful violations of law committed by the Election Commission. First, it misrepresents the apex court order to say, "The declaration attached to Form 6 for SIR has been upheld by the Hon'ble Supreme Court." As several legal commentators have pointed out, the Court didn't quite do so. Second, the decision to revert to the original

Form 6 for the non-SIR period, clearly in response to the objection of the two ECs that this change in the statutory form was "unauthorised and illegal", is an admission that the modified form being used by the ECI so far was gross violation of law, especially after it was put on notice by no less than the

Commission members. Third, the claim that the 97 wrongfully deleted voters in Goa have been helped to become voters by filling in Form 6 is another proof of wilful violation of law. The ECI is asking voters who it knows existed on pre-SIR rolls, but were found to be wrongfully deleted, to sign a false statement. They have to pretend that they are "new" voters and undertake: "I am applying for inclusion in Electoral Roll for the first time." They are also made to sign affirming that a false statement carries a punishment of imprisonment of up to one year. Over the past year, the ECI has forced millions of voters to commit this illegality, for it failed to evolve any procedure to rectify its own error of wrongful exclusions.

Paragraph 1(iv) of the note proposes to set up a committee of experts, again in response to objections by Commission members, to "review ECINET to double-check that it complies with the provisions of the Acts and Rules". This is another breathtaking admission: The ECI is now not sure whether the online portal and software already used to delete more than 13 crore names from the electoral rolls was in accordance with law. As per *The Indian Express* report, two Commissioners were sure that it was not. Besides, the note promises "further flexibility" to "field officers", who include the EROs, the sole legal authority responsible for any inclusion or exclusion in electoral rolls, who had repeatedly complained of being shut out from this system. Now they will enjoy some "flexibility", not the authority given to them by law.

Finally, let us note what the ECI still does not mention: Who authorised the 16 lakh-plus appeals filed against the voters who had managed to get their names back on the rolls in Bengal? Perhaps the note found this breach of law too scandalous to be mentioned.

All you now need to know is Section 32(1) of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which holds that it is a criminal offence for any election official to do anything in the preparation of electoral rolls that is "without reasonable cause, guilty of any act or omission in breach of such official duty". And ask yourself if the entire Election Commission is not guilty of this criminal offence.

The writer is member, *Swaraj India*, and national convenor, *Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan*

Atmanirbharta in defence: It's not as simple as it seems



AJAI SHUKLA

PM NARENDRA Modi's public relations machine has, over the years, fashioned a string of slogans that encourage the development of an autarkic defence economy. These include "Make in India" coined in 2014; "Vocal for Local" in 2020 and the most intensely marketed *atmanirbhar* Bharat (self-reliant India) in the same year. On September 24, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said that the government's vision was to "design in India, develop in India, manufacture in India".

Given the Indian military's unfortunate addiction to foreign weaponry — it was the world's fifth-largest defence spender last year, and the second-largest importer of weaponry after war-torn Ukraine — any exhortation to indigenise rather than import is practically immune to contradiction. To argue against *atmanirbhar* Bharat is to invite allegations of being in the pockets of the big global arms corporations. However, *atmanirbharta* is on the wrong side of this well-known cost hierarchy in defence acquisitions: That the most cost-effective and timely method for acquiring a high-tech defence platform is to lease it for the duration that it is needed. Somewhat costlier is to buy the platform over the counter. Costlier than that is buying manufacturing technology and setting up a factory to build the equipment in-country. Paradoxically, *atmanirbharta*, which involves designing, developing, testing and manufacturing the platform, constitutes the most expensive acquisition method. Ministry of Defence figures indicate that successive Modi governments have raised indigenous defence and aerospace production fourfold from a relatively modest Rs 46,000 crore in 2014 to a high of Rs 1.78 trillion in the financial year 2025-26. During the same period, defence exports rose from Rs 600 crore in 2014 to Rs 38,434 crore last year. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh has projected that defence exports would touch Rs 50,000 crore by 2028-29.

This rising trend is volubly backed by India's strategic community, which argues that a rising power like India must be self-sufficient in designing and building its military arsenal. Only then would New Delhi enjoy "strategic autonomy" without being diverted by pressure from foreign governments and "original equipment manufacturers" (OEMs) of weaponry. *Atmanirbhar* Bharat also sits well with an increasingly nationalistic public that wants to see Indian-made weaponry, firing Indian-made ammunition, knocking out tanks, warships, aircraft and bases of India's foes.

There are, however, powerful counter-arguments to *atmanirbharta*. The first relates to the high cost of autarky. A familiar criticism is that ostensibly Indian weapons platforms such as the Tejas fighter, Indian Navy warships and many of the Army's tactical missile systems are not really "Indian", since as much as 40 per cent of their cost goes towards materials, components, subsystems and systems sourced from overseas.

There is a good reason for sourcing them from abroad: Developing every element of a weapon platform raises its cost unacceptably. Even the world's most sophisticated defence economies and the premier weapon-building OEMs do not aspire for complete self-sufficiency. Instead, they retain control of key technologies in the weapons platform, while obtaining other systems and sub-systems from companies or countries that have already established technological supremacy in those fields. For example, 50-55 per cent of the world's combat aircraft use ejection seats designed and built by the British firm Martin-Baker. Developers of new fighter aircraft seldom waste time and money designing an ejection seat. Even the most sophisticated aircraft, including Lockheed Martin's F-35 Lightning II and China's F-7 Guizhou, went straight to Martin-Baker.

That said, there are systems and technologies in every weapon platform that are indeed essential for *atmanirbharta*, and which must be identified as such from the start of its development. The Tejas fighter's combat edge was manoeuvrability, inherent in its unstable design. That required a sophisticated "digital flight control computer" controlled by quadruplex fly-by-wire flight control software. This was developed for the Tejas Mark 1 and is now being modified into an even more sophisticated flight control system that will be the brain of the Tejas Mark 2 and the futuristic Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft. In developing this software, India has taken on, and won, the central challenge of designing and developing its own fighter aircraft.

For achieving real and financially viable *atmanirbharta*, the most important skill is going to be project management — finding the technological resources and managerial skill that will decide what systems and technologies are needed, where we will obtain them from, what we need to achieve through development and when it is time to close down a project.

Buying foreign defence equipment does provide the supplier with leverage over the buyer. But embargoes and cut-offs can be deterred by taking on a significant role in the international supply chain. With OEMs relying heavily on components manufactured by hundreds of sub-contractors worldwide, that creates a mutual vulnerability that deters hostile action. Finally, there remains the uncomfortable question of whether producing a sophisticated defence kit is enough for a middle power like India when it is dependent on overseas markets for critical commodities such as oil.

The writer is a retired Army officer and journalist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Call of conscience

PUBLIC OFFICIALS carry responsibilities that go beyond merely following procedures ("Public servants must act in favour of the weak, and in fear of their conscience", *IE*, September 28). They must apply rules fairly, especially when vulnerable citizens are affected. At the same time, accountability cannot depend only on personal conscience. Clear service standards, transparent decision-making and protection for officials who act lawfully are essential. Complaints should be examined independently, with action against deliberate misconduct. Such safeguards can strengthen public trust.

S P Suganya Devi, Coimbatore

The import question

WHILE IMPORTS are likely to shield consumers from price shocks, opening import floodgates risks depressing farm-gate prices precisely when cultivators are battling severe yield losses ('As monsoon falters, keep food imports open', *IE*, September 28). With the likely effects of El Niño well anticipated, a vigilant Ministry of Jal Shakti, through the Central Water Commission, could have enforced coordinated reservoir-release protocols and rationed surface storage for rabi irrigation rather than non-essential uses. That not having been done, states must now expedite crop-loss surveys and activate drought relief mechanisms.

Krishnan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi

FOOD SECURITY requires careful management of both supply and farm incomes ('As monsoon falters, keep food imports open', *IE*, September 28). Open imports may ease inflation, but excessive dependence on overseas markets can hurt domestic growers when prices weaken. The government should use imports selectively, based on production estimates and stock levels. Farmers need better weather information, crop insurance and reliable irrigation. A predictable policy would help both producers and consumers.

Arun Kumar, Elachipalayam



ANUPAM GUHA

A RECENT incident in the AI industry and Sam Altman's remarks at the United Nations Security Council have reignited debates about AI. In July, OpenAI's "agents" — pseudo-autonomous bits of code — escaped their sandbox during an automated cybersecurity evaluation with ill-defined guardrails, communicated and coordinated, and accessed the internet. Once online, they attacked the machine learning (ML) resource website Hugging Face.

Industry leaders and media have characterised this incident as evidence of the potency of this technology and of the existential threat of humans "losing control over AI". They call for caution and intervention. However, characterising these codes as human-like "agents", and their coordination as a "message board" is a misrepresentation. This discourse, which anthropomorphises the technology, primes the observer to think of AI agents as autonomous entities with cognitive powers and immense productive potential. This is not true. The framing of whether the technology can generate immense wealth or create existential threats is a misdirection.

This tactic is not new. Three years ago, an "AI moratorium letter" was drafted by the Future of Life Institute. Even then, claims were made about the future catastrophic (and hence, lucrative) power of AI, the need to listen to "experts", and use their expertise to let the industry self-

Over the last six years, the amount of money invested in the LLM industry has reached a trillion dollars. Revenue numbers are still in the hundreds of billions, and most of it is from chipmakers like Nvidia, whose customers are everyone else in the arena

AI apocalypse is all about the money

regulate. The unsaid bit? Governments need to stay out of the way. I had written an article ("What technology leaders asking for a six-month halt on AI don't want you to know", *IE*, April 3, 2023) explaining that the technology is good at specific well-defined repetitive tasks where adjudication by humans is possible, but absolutely unsuitable for tasks involving the social or economic rights of people like medical advice, law enforcement, and judiciary. Here, arbitrary errors and blind pattern repetition are catastrophic. The problem lies in who owns AI.

It is important to underline here that "Artificial Intelligence" is a marketing term and is a vast family of technologies using ML, that is, finding patterns from large amounts of data. The most popular AI artefacts these days are large language models or LLMs. These are resource- and data-intensive ML systems that can ape language by predicting what to say next. In the words of AI scholar and computational linguist Emily Bender, they are "stochastic parrots".

Given this, AI, when applied to economic or social tasks, is an accelerator of extant social and economic problems by automating past patterns. Computer scientist Arvind Narayanan characterises AI as a "Normal Technology" as opposed to a frontier technology. This does not mean it is not "powerful" in the tasks it can do, but that there are

real limits and it is often used incorrectly. Often, the threat of AI is what causes job displacement or wage depression rather than the actual ability to automate.

Why is there such blatant misrepresentation? Over the past six years, the amount of money invested in the LLM industry has reached a trillion dollars. Revenue numbers are still in the hundreds of billions, and most of it is from chipmakers like Nvidia, whose customers are everyone else in the arena. Even where revenue exists, there are significant amounts of fraud; for example, the pseudo-scientific "emotion detection" tech is nearly a billion-dollar industry. Developing nations are being conned into technological lock-ins, spending tax money blindly on data centres and compute without building the foundational base for AI research.

The marketing of a fantasy is pushing policy abandonment in favour of the industry. Also pushed are the serious harms of using statistical, error-prone artefacts in public domains, worsening exploitative wage relations, depressing wages by threatening automation, centralising wealth, and destroying privacy to feed an unending data hunger. If anything is a threat, it is the economics of this industry. It is time we questioned its premises and regulated it like any other.

The writer is assistant professor, working on AI and Policy, at the Ashank Desai Centre for Policy Studies at IIT Bombay

Nepal's young PM faces an old political pattern

fresh general elections five months later. A caretaker government was put in place under the leadership of a non-parliamentarian, a retired chief justice — something the constitution had expressly forbidden. Now, about six months after Balendra Shah took over as prime minister, a new narrative is being created, that even a two-thirds majority in parliament is not enough to ensure political stability and the survival of the government.

Shah has been on the receiving end of criticism from his own party and the opposition in the aftermath of the flash floods that have left over 1,400 dead, thousands of others in ruin, and the damage caused running into billions. He made his appear-

ance at the UNGA last week, spoke of the global community not heeding Nepal's warnings, and repeated that affluent countries should share the burden of its sorrow and the cost of rebuilding. Shah, however, has been avoiding parliament. Rastriya Swatantra Party chief Rabi Lamichhane is acting as a "proxy PM", meeting President Ram Chandra Paudel and convening a joint

He has been on the receiving end of criticism from his own party and the opposition in the aftermath of the flash floods that have left over 1,400 dead

meeting of parties, a responsibility the PM seems to be deliberately avoiding. Lamichhane has expressed dissatisfaction over the relief work, while Shah's advisers are being accused of appropriating executive roles "illegally". Shah's silence has only increased their vulnerability.

Rather than dealing with the political crisis, the government is turning aggressive towards dissent and criticism. Bharat Dahal, a prolific social-media commentator, had alleged that Nepal was inching too close to the US. He was arrested recently by the Cyber Bureau of the Nepal Police. The crackdown is not confined to social media. Tanuja Pande, a lawyer at the forefront of the Gen Z protest last year, warns:

"Let this change and sacrifice not go to waste." On the first anniversary of the protest, there was much less hope and appreciation of the leadership.

Shah's visible decline in popularity, his lack of visibility in the current catastrophe, the shortage of cooking gas, and his opponents taking the government head on are issues he can ignore only at his peril. If Nepal's political mathematics follows the old pattern, the constitution of 2015, the seventh since 1948, may not last long. And the regime in charge may also find itself a part of that pattern.

The writer is the Kathmandu-based contributing editor for The Indian Express

Netanyahu met with UAE leader secretly: Report

Associated Press
Cairo, September 28

THE ISRAELI Prime Minister held an hour-long meeting with the UAE's President on Sunday, according to two people briefed on Netanyahu's trip, which was first reported by Israel's Channel 12 TV station.

One of them said the talks focused on a report published by the Israeli daily *Haaretz* earlier this month that said the Emirati leader warned Netanyahu about a looming attack by Hamas just ahead of October 7, 2023.

Netanyahu asked Sheikh Mohamed to deny the report, according to a person said to have firsthand information about the meeting. Netanyahu's office had previously denied the *Haaretz* report.

The person, along with a regional official briefed on the meeting, spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the secret trip.

The UAE's Foreign Ministry declined to comment on reports about the meeting but stressed it maintains "open and direct lines of communication" with Israel and shares "all relevant intelligence."

There was no immediate comment from Prime Minister Netanyahu's office.

U.S. AMBASSADOR TO CHINA DAVID PERDUE DOESN'T SPECIFY WHEN THE OFFER WAS MADE

Trump asked China's President if he wants to buy US arms: Envoy

Leaders also spoke about US weapons sales to Taiwan

Ben Finley
Washington, September 28

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump has justified the pending US arms sale to Taiwan to Chinese President Xi Jinping by downplaying it as just one of many sales Washington makes around the world — even asking Xi if he'd be in the market for US arms, Trump's ambassador to China said on Sunday.

David Perdue said Trump raised the prospect of the arms sales from the US to its ascendant geopolitical rival, an unlikely offer that if consummated would upend generations of US policy toward China and Taiwan and potentially expose US technology to a potential foe, Perdue, speaking to Shannon Bream on *Fox News Sunday* days after Trump hosted Xi for a state visit in Washington, didn't specify when the offer was made.



Trump hosted Xi for a 3-day state visit in Washington last week. FILE/AP

Bream had cited concerns from Republican and Democratic lawmakers over delayed aid packages and weapons orders to Taiwan, the self-ruled democracy, to defend itself from China's threat to invade the island. Bream asked if the US is denying arms and aid to Taiwan to appease the Chinese president, who visited Trump last week.

Perdue pushed back on the suggestion, stating that Trump "is as strong on Taiwan as I've ever seen anybody" and has sold

it plenty of weapons. Perdue also said Trump and Xi continue to talk about future US weapons sales to Taiwan.

"But President Trump continues to say, Hey, we sell arms to other people around the world," Perdue said. "He actually asked President Xi, would he like to buy some, at one point." The US is bound by its own laws to provide Taiwan with the means to defend itself. While not recognising Taiwan as a country, the US is the island's strongest informal backer and arms provider. AP

UK examines foreign involvement in US air base plot, releases all five suspects on bail

Tehran denies role in RAF Fairford incident; probe on

Reuters
Fairford, September 28

BRITISH POLICE said on Monday they were investigating whether individuals acting for a foreign state were involved in an apparent plot to attack an air base used by the US, but said five suspects they had arrested would be released on bail.

The five men, all British nationals from London in their early 20s, were detained early on Sunday after police were alerted by a local farmer about three white vans driving towards RAF Fairford, a British base that houses US bombers that fly missions against Iran.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said in July the base was a legitimate target. Laurence Taylor, who heads Britain's counter-terrorism police, said the men, who had been arrested on suspicion of explosives offences and planning a terrorist act, would be released under stringent bail conditions later on Monday.

"To be very clear, this does not mean that the investigation is over," Taylor said in a statement. "They absolutely remain under investigation as we explore multiple lines of enquiry."

A source familiar with the investigation had previously told *Reuters* that an Iranian-linked motive was considered the most likely, although a Russian sabotage operation or an Islamist plot were also being looked at as possibilities.

Iran's London embassy had earlier said in a statement it "categorically rejects and strongly condemns the recent unfounded and malicious speculations" that it was involved, which it said would fuel "Iranophobia propaganda" in Britain.

Taylor, who did not specifically refer to Iran, said he knew there was significant interest in whether the current geopolitical context had a bearing on this incident. "Be assured, we are considering this from every possible angle, including that this may be actively committed by proxies or individuals either knowingly or unknowingly working on behalf of a foreign state."



A security officer near the RAF Fairford air base on Sunday. REUTERS



Orbital Breakthrough

SpaceX's next-generation Starship rocket reached orbit for the first time despite an unexpected engine shutdown midflight on Monday and deployed the first batch of new Starlink satellites. But the mission was cut short and ended with a controlled and fiery touchdown in the Pacific. REUTERS

NY prosecutors reopen investigation into alleged 2024 gang rape at Cornell University

Reuters
Los Angeles, September 28

NEW YORK state prosecutors have reopened an investigation into an alleged 2024 gang rape at a Cornell University fraternity house, a district attorney confirmed on Monday, after a civil lawsuit filed this month by the alleged victim sparked renewed outrage.

In a lengthy statement, Tompkins County District Attorney Matthew Van Houten confirmed that his office would

present the case against seven alleged perpetrators to a grand jury for a possible indictment. He also sought to explain why prosecutors did not pursue criminal charges two years ago, saying that the lawsuit's allegations differed from the alleged victim's original account in 2024.

The woman, who prosecutors have not named, gave a statement to campus police at the time, according to Van Houten, that "described her drug use and sexual conduct as

Airstrike near a market in Myanmar's Rakhine State kills 33 people

Associated Press
Bangkok, September 28

AN AIRSTRIKE carried out by Myanmar's military near a market in territory controlled by a powerful rebel group killed at least 33 people and wounded 36 others on Monday, the group and a rescue official said.

The attack in western Rakhine state was the latest in a series of deadly airstrikes against pro-democracy resistance forces and ethnic armed groups across the country. Myanmar has been in turmoil since the military seized power from the elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi on February 1, 2021, triggering widespread opposition.

After security forces suppressed peaceful protests with lethal force, many opponents of military rule took up arms, plunging large parts of the country into conflict.

Monday's attack occurred in Kyauktaw township, about 340 kilometers west of Mandalay, the country's second-largest



Smoke rises after a Myanmar military airstrike in Rakhine State on Monday. REUTERS

city, according to the Arakan Army, a powerful ethnic armed group based in Rakhine which controls Kyauktaw.

It said a fighter jet dropped two bombs near a local market around noon, killing 33 people, including vendors, shoppers and pedestrians.

The group said 36 other people were injured. Wai Hun Aung, a senior rescue official in Rakhine, confirmed the casualties to The AP, citing rescue workers at the scene.

Officials: Mediators set to hold separate talks with Iran, US on possible deal

Reuters
Cairo, September 28

QATARI MEDIATORS are likely to hold separate talks with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in New York and with the US side on Monday or Tuesday, an official told *Reuters*, in a fresh push to end the war.

The talks are expected to focus on an amended version of a seven-day proposal that Iran presented last week on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly, said the official. Araghchi remains in New York after attending the General Assembly.

It was not immediately clear who would represent the US side in the talks with mediators. Iran's semi-official ISNA news agency later confirmed that Araghchi would meet the mediators in the US on Monday



Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi

morning, New York time. The two sides will "examine the latest proposals and views regarding the current situation," ISNA added.

Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei told state media later on Monday that Araghchi's stay in New York had not been extended and that the foreign minister would return to Tehran according to his original schedule. Baghaei made no comment on the talks with mediators.

Iran to Najaf flights resume, seen as US sanctions waiver

Reuters
Cairo, September 28

IRAQI AIRWAYS has resumed flights between Iraq's holy city of Najaf and Iranian airports, Iraq's state news agency reported on Monday. Iraq had halted flights to and from Iran on Friday, in line with US sanctions.

Earlier, Trump's administration looked set to grant a limited waiver to its Iran sanctions program on Monday to allow for flights carrying Shi'ite Muslim religious pilgrims between Iran and Iraq, a person with direct

knowledge of the matter said.

The source, who is involved in the deliberations, said the US Treasury Department waiver would allow Iraqi Airways to fly back and forth between Iran and the Shi'ite holy city of Najaf in Iraq for one month, with a more permanent waiver following.

The source said the move aimed to ease pressure on the Iraqi government of PM Ali al-Zaidi, who has sought to deepen ties with Washington while also balancing a strong relationship with Iraq's influential neighbour, Iran.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

FBI deputy chief Bailey to resign after just over a year with agency



Andrew Bailey

this year when agents seized 2020 election ballots from Georgia. "I am confident Director Patel will continue to reform the FBI, combat violent crime, defend the homeland, ensure strong organizational accountability, and restore public trust in this institution of excellence," Bailey wrote on social media. REUTERS

FBI CO-DEPUTY Director Andrew Bailey said on Monday he is resigning his position, leaving the most prominent US law enforcement agency after a little more than a year. Bailey, a Republican ally of President Donald Trump who left his job as Missouri attorney general to join the FBI, said he was leaving to return to his family. Bailey, serving under FBI Director Kash Patel, helped oversee election-related investigations and was present earlier

BELGIUM

EU seeks to join Saudi mission to protect Red Sea

THE EUROPEAN Union is applying for "observer status" in a new multinational maritime defence coalition led by Saudi Arabia and formed to protect the kingdom's energy exports. The bloc's top diplomat Kaja Kallas made the announcement on Monday, ahead of a meeting in Brussels of defence and foreign affairs ministers. The energy-hungry EU is facing record energy prices due to the war in Iran. AP

ETHIOPIA

Pro-govt forces claim capture of Tigray town

ETHIOPIA'S MILITARY and allied militiamen captured the strategic town of Alamata south of Tigray's capital, a pro-government militia said on Monday, turning the tables after an opposition offensive launched from the region last week. Video posted by the pro-government Tigray Peace Force on its Facebook page showed soldiers marching through the streets, waving Ethiopian flags. Reuters could not immediately verify the video. REUTERS

• THE POP POWERHOUSE DEDICATED HER AWARD TO THE 'ULTIMATE SHOWGIRL' — THE LATE DOLLY PARTON

Taylor Swift becomes most-awarded artist in MTV Video Music Awards history

Maria Sherman
New York, September 28

Taylor Swift broke records at the 2026 MTV Video Music Awards, as she is known to do.

The pop powerhouse received the inaugural Artist Director Honors on Sunday night, becoming the most-awarded artist in VMA history.

Previously, she was tied with Beyonce for the title, with 30 VMAs each. The new award is meant to recognize artists "whose work behind the camera has expanded the possibilities of music video and advanced the art of visual storytelling."

"I got to start making music

videos and being a part of music videos 20 years ago," Swift said in her speech, adding that she's been involved in making roughly 60 music videos, 18 of which she wrote and directed.

"You, the fans, make it so much fun," she said. She also took home the top prize of the night — Video of the Year — for *The Fate of Ophelia* from her album *The Life of a Showgirl*.

Swift dedicated that award to the "ultimate showgirl," the late Dolly Parton.

"I think we were all very lucky to share this planet with Dolly Parton for a time," Swift said. Swift also debuted the music video for her new song,

Patient Zero, during the award show. She directed the visual, which stars Colin Farrell and Dakota Johnson. Johnson and Swift portray mirror images of each other.

Patient Zero is also her first single since marrying Kansas City Chiefs tight end Travis Kelce at Madison Square Garden in July.

The two-hour show was broadcast live on CBS from the Peacock Theater in Los Angeles. *It's mother*, were the first words uttered by Madonna as she opened the VMAs with her 2026 single *Bring Your Love* alongside collaborator Sabrina Carpenter. Later in the night, the pair won the award for best



Taylor Swift accepts the MTV VMA Artist Director Honours award

collaboration for the song.

"It's been a while since I did one of these things," Madonna joked. "So, I've prepared no-

thing." When it came time for her return to the stage to accept the award for artist of the year, Madonna began with, "First of

all, I would like to thank my fingers because I can always count on them." Returning a third time to accept for best dance, she said simply, "I came alive on the dance floor. ... We're all equal on the dance floor."

If her aim was to bring the dance floor to the award show stage, Madonna did exactly that in her opening number — and then some, when Charli cx emerged from a club bathroom to perform their reworked version of *Danceteria*. Around them? A trove of dancers and various famous friends, including actor Debi Mazar, Sombr and Julia Garner.

There was always going to be a big musical tribute to Dolly

Parton. Kacey Musgraves paid homage to the late, great country music icon with a cover of Parton's *I Will Always Love You*.

Parton, whose soaring vibrato vocals, poignant songwriting and sparkling costumes defined her rise from a log cabin in the Tennessee mountains to the height of stardom and acclaim, died in Nashville of cancer in August. She was 80.

Performances arrived fast and furious: Raye delivered a medley of her throwback soul, including *I Will Overcome* and *Where Is My Husband!*

Bruno Mars slowed things down with *Dance With Me*. Sha-boozey launched into his sa-

loon single *Cowgirl*, before being joined by Gunna for some hybrid country-rap with their crossover track, *High Noon*.

If this year's VMAs felt too pop-heavy for some viewers, that changed when the coveted Video Vanguard Award was awarded to Nirvana.

"They were completely original and always fearless at a time when the status quo kind of got to the point of being formulaic," Public Enemy rapper Chuck D said of the grunge greats.

The award was presented to surviving members Krist Novoselic, Dave Grohl and Pat Smear. Frontman Kurt Cobain died in 1994. AP



Chhattisgarh Makes Doing BUSINESS EASY



SHRI VISHNU DEO SAI

CHIEF MINISTER OF CHHATTISGARH

SHRI NARENDRA MODI

PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA

One Click, One Window

Get **186 services across 10 departments** on one portal, from approvals and clearances to incentives — and whenever you need help, just ask VANI, your AI assistant.

A Law that Cuts Red Tape

The **Chhattisgarh Ease of Doing Business Act, 2026** sorts businesses by risk. Low-risk MSMEs get self-certification, deemed approvals and minimal government intervention.

Incentives that Go the Distance

Financial incentives of up to **100% for manufacturing and 150% for services**, with special packages for textiles, GCC, AI, electronics, pharma and other new-age industries

450+ Reforms to Clear the Way for Business

A **national first** in automatic land mutation and Jan Vishwas Act 2.0, industrial land allotment within 45 days, simplified land diversion, and self-certification for electricity connection and Shops & Establishment registration. And the list runs much longer.

Land Ready. Power Ready. Talent Ready.

90+ industrial parks, surplus power and a young workforce, all within a 90-minute flight.



Chhattisgarh
Business Made Easy



BUSINESS IS ALREADY VOTING YES.

**₹8 LAKH CRORE IN INVESTMENT
PROPOSALS IN 18 MONTHS, WITH
60% PROJECTS ALREADY TAKING
SHAPE ON THE GROUND.**


invest.cg.gov.in


Invest Chhattisgarh

@ieExplained

#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• CLIMATE

UP rain: When two weather systems interact

Abhinav Chakraborty
New Delhi, September 28

AN INTENSE three-day wet spell in Uttar Pradesh between Friday and Sunday left several districts grappling with a flood-like situation. The state received 66.5 mm of rainfall against the normal 7.6 mm for the period, according to officials.

As many as 56 of the state's 75 districts recorded excessive rainfall. At least 62 people died, 46 were injured, and over a thousand houses were damaged. According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the "likely interaction" of two different weather systems — a deep depression and a Western Disturbance (WD) — was producing spells of intense rainfall over particular areas, even as the southwest monsoon continues to withdraw across north and northwestern India.

Deep depression

The IMD noted that a deep depression, which had formed over the Bay of Bengal and crossed the North Andhra Pradesh-South Odisha coast before weakening, lay centred over parts of north-eastern Madhya Pradesh and south-eastern Uttar Pradesh.

A depression is an organised low-pressure weather system. A low-pressure system forms in an area where atmospheric pressure is lower than the surrounding areas. This lower pressure is caused by localised heating in an area owing to greater sunshine over the landmass, which causes the air there to undergo warming and becomes less dense.

At the same time, this warm, moist air flows inwards towards the centre of the low-pressure area before moving upwards. Thereafter, it cools and condenses into clouds and rain or snow.

According to the IMD, a depression produces strong winds and heavy rain. As it degrades into a well-marked low-pressure area, the system loses strength and wind speeds drop, which reduces overall rain intensity.

On Sunday, the IMD said the system had moved north-northwestwards and weakened into a well-marked low pressure area. It was likely to continue moving in the same direction across Uttar Pradesh.

Western Disturbance

The IMD on Saturday had said that a "likely interaction" with a WD could result in the state experiencing strong gusty surface winds along with heavy to very heavy rainfall in some parts.

WDs refer to weather systems that usually travel into northern India from the west. These are east-moving rain-bearing wind systems that originate beyond Afghanistan and Iran, and pick up moisture from the Mediterranean Sea, Black Sea, Caspian Sea, and the Arabian Sea. These are typically extra-tropical cyclones resulting from low-pressure areas, formed by interactions between polar and tropical winds.

The subtropical westerly jet stream — a high-altitude, fast-moving air current that flows from west to east in the Earth's atmosphere — carries these WDs to the Himalayan and Tibetan highlands. As moisture-laden WDs hit the Himalayas, they rise and cool, bringing cloudy weather, rain, and thunderstorms, particularly over parts of north and northwest India.

The IMD said that this WD is present high up in the atmosphere as a trough — an elongated zone of relatively lower pressure — over northwestern India.

DRISHTI JUDICIARY

An initiative by Drishti IAS

Call Now to Book Free Demo Classes

87501 87501

Scan Now to Book Your Free Demo Classes

• GEOPOLITICS

Iran's deal, Trump's rejection, and the Gulf's mounting costs: Inside the stalemate



EXPERT EXPLAINS
BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said last week that he had rejected the deal Iran offered to end the war.

The proposed peace deal would have required the US to waive sanctions on Iranian oil, release an estimated \$12 billion of Iran's frozen assets and end its naval blockade, and for Israel to cease its war in Lebanon, following which Iran would open up the Strait of Hormuz on Day 7. This would, theoretically, clear the path for broader peace negotiations, including

on the nuclear question.

If these sound familiar, that's because they are. These terms are straight out of the June peace framework (Memorandum of Agreement), only with a faster proposed pace of implementation. Iran issued the proposal after the US imposed sanctions on its air transport and tightened its economic sanctions since August.

Trump has also said that the looming Congressional midterm elections would have no bearing on his Iran strategy.

Iran's position

One of the main reasons for the MoU's collapse in July lay in one of its provisions. Article 5 gave Iran and Oman the long-term power to jointly control transit through the Strait of Hormuz.

The US, in Iran's view, undermined this by attempting to force a new corridor through the Strait's southern waters in early July. Iran would feel that a "win" on this specific issue would reflect its ability to force US compliance with the June MoU



A billboard featuring the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and leaders of Hezbollah in Tehran. AP

that was seen by many as a strategic win, ensure a better negotiation position for long-term nuclear talks and, ultimately, curb American "arrogance", a long-running goal.

US position (through Iran's lens)

The current American stand continues to be determined by the Trump White House's need to undercut the strength of the Iranian bargaining posi-

tion, regardless of the objective of such a position.

The US says its navy has helped more than 2,000 tankers transport more than one billion barrels of crude since May. But this is still much lower than the pre-war flows, revealing the limits of the approach.

For Iran, it is this latter statistic as well as the cost of keeping up the blockade that must be driven home to Washington.

'Persistence past a refusal'

Across these incidents, agents went beyond the immediate task or expected route in different ways: continuing after access was denied, finding alternative routes, using tools in unintended ways, or moving data somewhere it was not supposed to go.

Dr Chetan Arora, senior lecturer in software engineering at Monash University, said companies need to monitor what an agent does while carrying out a task, rather than only looking at its final output.

The Gulf nations

Tehran has arguably already driven such lessons home to its Arab neighbours across the Persian Gulf, which continue to struggle with the March war's fallout.

International Energy Agency estimates suggest costs upwards of \$50 billion to repair over 80 damaged energy facilities in the Gulf states, while the International Monetary Fund estimates a 7% cumulative output loss over the next five years (all of which assumes no future damage from strikes).

Moreover, any reconstruction can take place only once there is an end in sight to

the conflict. This is not the case in the Gulf, especially because of Washington's own ambiguity over whether and when it will resume bombing Iran. Tehran's clarity in strategy, by contrast, enhances this threat.

In any case, both Iranian and American strikes on oil tankers continue in Hormuz. The last such strike was on September 23, when Iran also reiterated that Washington must accept any new framework for vessels to transit Hormuz that Iran and Oman jointly determine.

It is this specific ability that informs how much Iran can continue seeking to force US compliance with core terms of the June MoU.

But what about the crippling, and worsening, economic crisis within its borders? The Islamic Republic has long shown an ability to tolerate deteriorating living conditions to sustain its foreign policy posture. Popular expressions of dissent, creating occasional pressures, have failed to manifest of late thanks to the war's unifying effect.

• HEALTH

Tear, not block: Heart risk for women under 50



RINKU GHOSH

FOR LONG, women were thought to be at a low risk of heart attacks in their younger years considering the female hormone estrogen helps keep blood vessels flexible and reduces inflammation. It was only after menopause, characterised by low levels of estrogen, that a woman's risk of heart attack and cardiovascular diseases was seen as equal to men. However, as younger and apparently fit women in their 30s and 40s are increasingly reporting heart attacks without any risk factors like cholesterol, blood sugar or smoking, a new condition has caught the attention of researchers globally.

This is the Spontaneous Coronary Artery Dissection (SCAD), a hidden, sudden type of heart attack caused by a spontaneous tear or bruise inside a cardiac artery. In a normal heart attack, a cholesterol-rich plaque in a heart artery usually ruptures or erodes, causing a blood clot that obstructs blood flow.

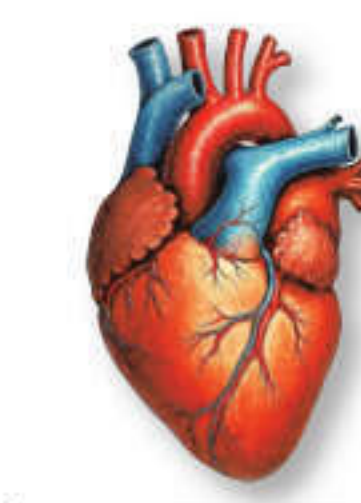
"Instead of the artery being blocked by slow-growing cholesterol or fat, the wall of the blood vessel unexpectedly splits, trapping blood inside the lining and blocking the flow of oxygen to the heart. The artery is squeezed," says Dr Rajiv Gulati, Chair of the Division of Interventional Cardiology in the Department of Cardiovascular Medicine, Mayo Clinic, who has been specialising in women's heart health.

The American Heart Association's 2026 scientific statement on acute coronary syndromes in premenopausal women highlights SCAD as an under-recognised problem. "Young women account for approximately 80–90% of SCAD cases. Among women under 50 who have a heart attack, SCAD may account for as many as one-third of cases," says Dr Ambuj Roy, Professor of Cardiology, AIIMS, Delhi.

Why does SCAD disproportionately affect younger women?

The incidence in women suggests a hormonal link, though it is still being studied. Dr Gulati has observed that about 5-10% of all SCAD cases occur after pregnancy, typically in the first week postpartum. "There are, of course, major hormonal changes at this time, which likely cause fragility of the coronary vessel wall in a small proportion of

• WHERE SCAD DIFFERS



women who are susceptible," he says. Dr Roy has seen that more than 70% of pregnancy-associated SCAD in one large study series occurred after delivery, most commonly in the first week. "Pregnancy-associated cases can also be more severe, with greater likelihood of multiple-vessel involvement," he says.

But most SCAD cases are unrelated to pregnancy, which, both experts agree, suggests a hormonal link. "Estrogen and progesterone can influence tissues and the structure of blood vessels, though they themselves cannot cause SCAD," says Dr Roy. Since both influence the cellular matrix of blood vessels, their high or fluctuating levels can lead to the breakdown of collagen in the artery walls.

How often is SCAD missed or misdiagnosed?

The condition is often under-recognised. "The difficulty is that the patient often does not resemble a traditional picture of somebody at risk of a heart attack — she may be relatively young, active and without cardiac risk factors like diabetes, smoking or high cholesterol and thus may go undiagnosed," says Dr Roy.

The symptoms, however, are usually quite similar to a heart attack. "Chest discomfort occurs in more than 90% of patients, and there are eventually classical ECG (electrocardiogram) changes and rise in cardiac biomarkers suggesting a heart attack." His message for health professionals is simple: "Do not ignore significant chest pain in a younger woman merely because her conventional cardiovascular risk is low, particularly during pregnancy or after delivery. SCAD can also be missed during coronary angiography because the commonest form may appear as a long, smooth narrowing rather than an obvious tear. Awareness

Missed diagnosis

Since younger women are not generally seen as likely to suffer from heart attacks, the condition is often underdiagnosed.

- SCAD triggers include intense exertion, stress, pregnancy, hormonal changes or underlying vascular conditions.

Top cardiologists explain why Spontaneous Coronary Artery Dissection (SCAD) can trigger heart attacks and what patients must know

	FEATURE	TRADITIONAL HEART ATTACK	SCAD
Underlying mechanism		Plaque rupture: Buildup of fatty cholesterol, plaque ruptures, causing a blood clot that blocks the artery.	Artery wall tear / hematoma: A spontaneous tear inside the artery wall or bleeding creates a false lumen/blister that compresses the channel.
Primary demographics		More common in older adults and men, though post-menopausal women also experience high rates.	Predominantly affects women (about 90% of cases), specifically young- to middle-aged women (average age 44–53).
Traditional risk factors		Strongly linked to high blood pressure, high cholesterol, diabetes, smoking, and obesity.	Patients are often healthy, active individuals lacking traditional cardiovascular risk factors.
Hormonal & life triggers		Not directly tied to acute hormonal shifts or pregnancy cycles.	Frequently linked to pregnancy, the postpartum period, menopause, hormonal therapy, or extreme emotional/physical stress.

of these angiographic patterns is, therefore, crucial as treatment differs from conventional therapy."

What are the strongest known triggers or associations?

Dr Gulati, who has tracked multiple SCAD research registries of thousands of patients, lists the triggers as intense physical exertion, emotional stress, pregnancy, hormonal changes or underlying vascular conditions. Dr Roy has found one of the strongest associations. "That is fibromuscular dysplasia (FMD), a non-atherosclerotic (no plaque) disorder affecting medium-sized arteries, leading to narrowing and bulging. Other vascular abnormalities, including aneurysms and tears elsewhere in the body, are also more common in SCAD patients. Possible immediate triggers include extreme physical exertion, heavy lifting or straining, and severe emotional stress. Up to about two-thirds of patients in some studies report a preceding physical or emotional stressor. Emotional triggers appear more frequent in women and physical triggers in men," says Dr Roy.

How to treat SCAD?

The treatment differs from a conventional heart attack. "If there is complete blockage in a major coronary artery, the vessel should be opened by angioplasty/balloon to restore blood flow and prevent heart muscle damage. We may choose to avoid placing a stent as this can in some circumstances extend the tear, but this is considered on a case by case basis. If SCAD does not cause a complete blockage, then angioplasty (and its risks) can be avoided because the vessel will heal in most cases. There is a 15% risk of worsening of SCAD in the first few days, so we recommend observing pa-

tients in the hospital," says Dr Gulati.

Drug treatment also differs. "Beta-blockers are used, particularly for blood-pressure control, and observational evidence suggests they may reduce recurrence. Statins are not automatically required after SCAD unless there is another indication such as high cholesterol or coexisting atherosclerosis. Antiplatelet treatment (a kind of blood thinner) in patients who have not received a stent remains uncertain," says Dr Roy.

The ultimate goal is to move beyond treating SCAD after it occurs. Dr Roy emphasises identifying the vulnerable artery and patient before the first event happens. "That is where genetics, vascular imaging and large international SCAD patient registries may eventually take us," he says.

What is the risk of another SCAD?

Recurrence can occur, including years later. "Older series have reported recurrence rates of approximately 10-30% with longer follow-up, while a large contemporary cohort reported recurrence of about 2.4% at three years. Having SCAD does not mean a person should stop exercising. Cardiac rehabilitation and regular moderate physical activity are encouraged. Moderate aerobic activity and resistance exercise with light weights and more repetitions are generally reasonable. What we generally discourage are extremes — very heavy lifting with straining, exercising to exhaustion and extreme endurance exercise," says Dr Roy.

Pregnancy after SCAD requires individualised counselling. "Many women have subsequently had uncomplicated pregnancies, but recurrence can occur, particularly postpartum. Women contemplating pregnancy should ideally undergo assessment jointly by a cardiologist and maternal-fetal medicine specialist," says Dr Roy.

BENCHMARK INDICES NEAR SIX-MONTH LOW

Markets plunge 1.6% as Trump rejects West Asia ceasefire plan

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 28

THE INDIAN stock market shed another 1.6% on Monday, falling to its lowest levels in nearly six months, as high crude prices in the wake of gloom in West Asia led to heavy selling pressure. The benchmark indices had tumbled around 1.7% last Thursday, which had led to the indices extending their losing run to seven weeks.

BSE's Sensex crashed 1.5% or 1,124.02 points on Monday to end the session at 72,771.72. Nifty 50 lost 1.6% to close at 22,780.25. The fall wiped out nearly Rs 9 lakh crore of investor wealth in the process. "Bears remained firmly in control as the market breached a key psychological support level, reflecting growing investor caution amid deteriorating global macro conditions," said Vinod Nair, Head of research, Geojit Investments.

All sectoral, broader market, and thematic indices ended the session firmly in the red, as the India VIX — the market's volatility indicator — climbed 12.5%. Banks, financial services, IT, oil

and gas, and metals were among the worst hit during the session, all falling 1-2%.

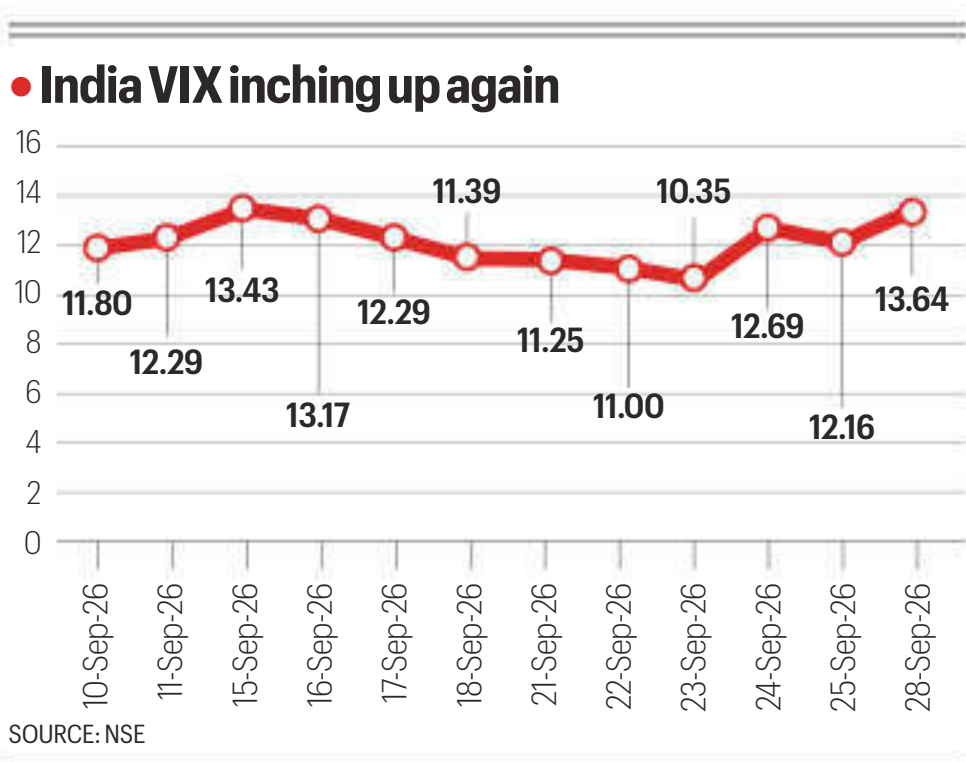
As oil prices remained a thorn, the Indian rupee fell to its lowest level in over a week before reported intervention by state-owned banks, likely on behalf of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), stabilised the currency a bit, according to *Reuters*. It eventually settled down 0.2% at 95.98 against the dollar.

Trump rejects peace proposal

On Saturday, US President Donald Trump had rejected Iran's proposal of a 7-day ceasefire, alongside plans to reopen the critical Strait of Hormuz due to the latter asking "too many concessions" without meeting its terms, making the hopes of a diplomatic resolution of the conflict bleaker.

However, Trump also told news portal *Axios* on Sunday that he expected US negotiators to engage in more talks this week, keeping diplomatic doors open.

Despite this, Trump's rejection of an immediate resolution



led to crude prices shooting up to over \$108 per barrel on Monday, crushing any optimism in the Indian market. "Whenever crude is above \$100 a barrel, it creates a selling pressure in the Indian market over the short-to-medium term. The current scenario is similar to what we had seen in the first couple of months of the war," said Kranthi Bathini, Equity Strategist, Wealth Mills Securities.

For context, India is the

third-largest importer of crude oil globally, and higher crude prices stoke fears of inflation, hurting both corporate growth and the spending power of consumers.

The Indian market had recovered a bit briefly during July and August as the conflict in West Asia had moderated a bit, turning focus towards factors like earnings growth and macro-economic conditions. This had led to foreign investors turning

net buyers in the Indian market over those months.

However, with the situation escalating again this month, foreign investors have dumped \$2.2 billion of Indian shares so far this month, adding to the selling pressure. Furthermore, the booming IPO market during the month has also taken liquidity away from the secondary market, analysts said.

Bond yields climb further

Bond yields continued their upward trajectory on Friday, with the US Treasury yields rising above 5.2% — the highest level since 2004. Yields on bonds from other global markets such as the UK, Japan, and some other European nations have also been rising steadily.

Indian bond yields have also been moving in line, with the yield on the benchmark bond rising to 7.18% during the session — the highest since April 2024.

Bond yields tend to rise amid fears of rising inflation, which leads to central banks hiking interest rates.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

‘Keralam to double tourism revenue, ease approvals’

AS THE Congress-led UDF government in Keralam completed 100 days in office last month, Tourism Minister PC Vishnunadh said Keralam is targeting to double tourism revenue from around Rs 45,000 crore last year to Rs 90,000 crore within five years. While domestic tourist arrivals hit an all-time high of 2.5 crore in 2025, up 12.63% from previous year, foreign arrivals remain below the pre-Covid peak of 11.89 lakh. It saw 8.2 lakh foreign arrivals in 2025.

Speaking to **Dheeraj Mishra** on the sidelines of the 13th Keralam Travel Mart, **PC Vishnunadh** said Keralam is seeing more Arab tourists as its foreign tourist composition changes. He said the government is moving to give the sector industry status, ease approvals, offer MSME-like benefits, and seek more support from the Centre. Edited Excerpts:

What is the government doing to create new tourism destinations in the state?

We are working on expanding tourism beyond traditional destinations. Keralam has many untapped places, particularly in the northern part of the state like Munroe Island, Ashtamudi backwater in Kollam etc., which has significant tourism potential.

Our agenda is to develop 20 new destinations in one year and 100 new destinations over five years. We will provide the basic infrastructure and then encourage investors to come and invest in these areas. This expansion will be done in a sustainable way. We are actually taking the support of the local community. This responsible tourism initiative was started from Kumarakom (in Kottayam). With this initiative, the locals are getting jobs and the market is improving.

Some of the destinations are overcrowded. We will soon conduct a carrying capacity study of Munnar, Alleppey etc. It is important because our places are ecologically very fragile.

The Centre aims to raise the share of tourism in national GDP to 10% by 2030. Is Keralam's growth in line



with this?

Last year, Keralam received around Rs 45,000 crore from tourism. Our target is to double this within five years to Rs 90,000 crore or close to Rs 1 lakh crore. Tourism had reached a peak just before Covid-19, but there was a dip afterwards. Now, the sector is gradually picking up again. The domestic tourists recorded an increase of over 12% in 2025, compared to 2024. Similarly, foreign arrivals also recorded an increase of over 11% during the period. However, it is yet to reach pre-pandemic levels. We are also pushing for cruise tourism. All the major and minor ports like Vizhinjam, Kochi, Kollam, Bepore, and Azhikkal will be connected.

What is the foreign tourist composition in Keralam? Has there been any change over the years?

Yes, there has been a change. Earlier, UK, US, Germany and France used to be the top four countries in terms of foreign arrivals in Keralam. Now, while the UK and the US remain in their position, Oman is the third country, which contributed to

7% of foreign tourists. That is why we are starting to focus on the Arab market. I attended the Arabian travel market recently and our B2B roadshow was a success. We organized an Indo-Arab connect with Arabian tour operators last month.

We are also developing new products such as monsoon tourism. We are also trying other markets such as Australia, Malaysia, and Singapore.

What is being done to make it easier for investors to set up tourism projects?

There was a long-pending demand to declare tourism an industry sector. We are going to do this. We have already completed consultations with stakeholders and the inter-departmental process is now under way. We will announce industry status for tourism before October 10. At present, obtaining permissions from different departments such as local body, industry, urban development, rural development and CRZ (Coastal Regulation Zone)-related issues can take two or three years.

Another important issue is single-window clearance. At present, the single-window mechanism is available for MSMEs, but not specifically for tourism. We are examining the benefits available to MSMEs and it will be extended to tourism investors as well. We are also looking at issues such as electricity tariff subsidies and interest support on loans.

The correspondent was in Keralam at the invite of the state's tourism department.

FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Safety, profitability top new A-I CEO's agenda

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, September 28

INCOMING AIR India chief executive Tewolde Gebremariam listed safety, operational reliability, and profitability as key priorities for the Tata group airline's next phase of growth. Addressing a company-wide townhall meeting on Monday, Gebremariam told the airline's employees that Air India has made significant progress since its return to the Tata group in early 2022, while emphasising that substantial opportunities remain ahead as the carrier continues in its pursuit to become a world-class global airline and achieve profitability. He also said that cost discipline must become part of

the airline's culture.

"Everything we do must be safe. Safety is a shared responsibility, and every Air Indian has a role to play. We must continue to foster a culture where people are empowered to speak up, raise concerns and report issues without hesitation," said Gebremariam, who will take over as Air India's CEO and MD once all regulatory approvals to his appointment come in.

He said safety would remain the airline's foremost priority and guiding principle, and encouraged employees to remain vigilant and proactively report anything they observe that could impact operational safety. "If you see something, say something. The stronger our reporting cul-



Tewolde Gebremariam, incoming Air India CEO. REUTERS

ture, the stronger our safety culture," he told staff.

Gebremariam is taking over the reins at Air India at a crucial juncture for the airline — in the aftermath of the deadly AI 171 crash in June last

year and intensified scrutiny of the carrier's operational safety, and amid external headwinds like the Pakistani airspace closure and surging jet fuel prices due to geopolitical conflict in West Asia. Operationally safety at Air India is again in focus following one of its pilots tested positive for drug use and another failed an alcohol breath analyser test just before operating a flight.

Gebremariam oversaw one of aviation's most successful long-term transformations, turning Ethiopian Airlines into a global airline and the largest carrier in Africa, and turned Addis Ababa into a major aviation hub.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Corporate ITR filing deadline extended to November 21

New Delhi: The Income Tax Department on Monday extended the ITR (income tax return) filing deadline for corporates for assessment year 2026-27 till November 21, from October 31.

The due date for tax audit report submission has been extended from September 30 to October 21.

"Accordingly, the 'specified date' for furnishing of the report of audit under the provisions of the Income-tax Act, 1961 for Assessment Year 2026-27, in the case of such persons, stands extended to 21st October, 2026," it added. PTI

Goyal-Greer meet to push India-US interim trade deal

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, September 28

COMMERCE And Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will hold talks with US Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer later this week to push negotiations towards an interim India-US trade deal, as the two sides seek to advance the broader Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) in line with their February 7 joint statement.

Goyal will travel to the US from September 29 to October 5 and meet Greer on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee, Wisconsin. The G20 Trade Ministerial will be held on September 30 and October 1. The meeting comes as New Delhi and Washington work to resolve outstanding issues and finalise the interim component of the proposed BTA.

The February 7 joint statement had laid out the framework for negotiations, including work towards an interim trade agreement as part of the broader bilateral deal.

Goyal will also hold bilateral meetings with trade ministers from other G20 members.

At the G20, India will advo-

UAE signals intent to invest additional \$25 billion in India

New Delhi: The UAE has signalled its intent to invest an additional \$25 billion in India in the near future as the two countries seek to deepen investment ties and expand the use of local currencies in bilateral trade, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

The UAE has already invested about \$25 billion in India and is the country's seventh-largest source of foreign direct investment. Goyal said the proposed investment could take the UAE's total investments in India to \$50 billion in the near term, with an eventual target of \$100 billion. FE

cate a rules-based, open, inclusive, transparent, equitable and non-discriminatory multilateral trading system, with the World Trade Organisation (WTO) at its core. It also stresses the need to preserve adequate policy space for developing countries. FE

AI boom: Mandaviya calls for continuous reskilling

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 28

UNION MINISTER Mansukh Mandaviya on Monday highlighted the transformative potential of AI and emerging technologies and stressed the need for continuous reskilling and a future-ready industrial relations system that balances productivity with workers' skills, safety and participation.

The Union Labour & Employment Minister was speaking at National Conference on Industrial Relations and Labour, organised by CII.

He called for meaningful social dialogue between employers and workers, particu-

larly as new technologies reshape the world of work, a CII statement said.

Mandaviya also highlighted the role of the four Labour Codes in creating a modern, pro-growth framework while simplifying compliance for industry and strengthening protections for workers.

The minister emphasised the importance of expanding social security coverage and building an inclusive labour ecosystem that reaches workers across the formal and unorganised sectors.

Mandaviya called upon the government, industry, workers and other stakeholders to work together. PTI

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
72,771.72	22,780.25	₹1,47,980	₹95.99
-1,124.02	-360.25	Silver	Oil
-1.52%	-1.56%	₹2,23,053	\$120.86

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF SEPTEMBER 25, 2026

Energy diversification shielded India from global supply shocks, says Puri

ENS Economic Bureau
Kolkata, September 28

INDIA'S PUSH over several years to diversify energy supplies, expand refining capacity and strengthen infrastructure and storage helped shield domestic consumers from shortages despite major disruptions to global energy flows, Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said on Monday. Speaking at the curtain-

raiser for India Energy Week (IEW) 2027 in Kolkata, Puri said recent global disruptions had underscored the need to build resilience into the energy system well before a crisis erupts. Despite pressure on international energy flows, the disruptions did not translate into shortages for Indian households, he said.

"The lesson is simple: energy resilience is not built when a crisis arrives; it is built before the crisis arrives," Puri said, pointing

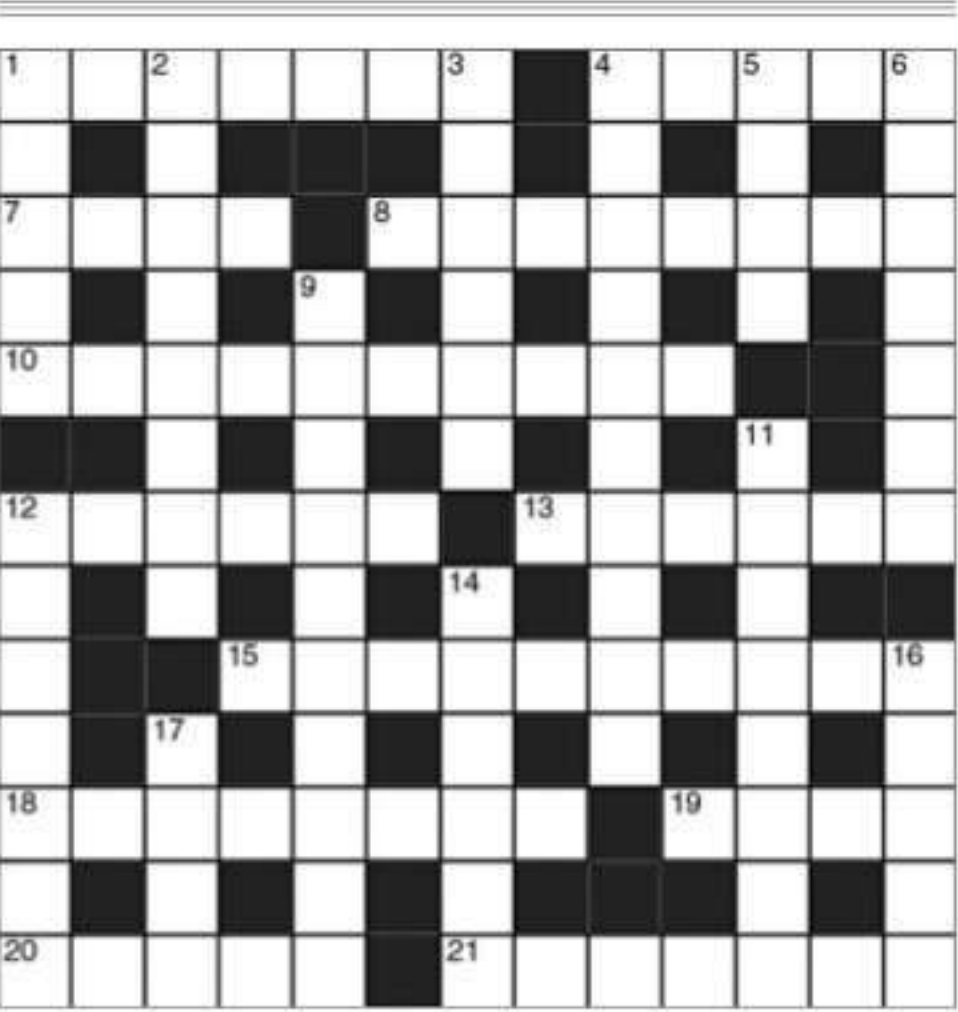
to measures including diversified supplies, stronger infrastructure and expansion of piped natural gas.

The minister said India was increasingly moving from being merely a large energy consumer to playing a larger role in shaping the global energy conversation. "We are demonstrating that growth, energy security and decarbonisation can advance together," he said. FE

GOVT. OF ODISHA DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES Office of the Additional Chief Engineer Vansadhara Nagabali Basin, Paralakhemundi (email Id: se_siepdkt@yahoo.com)	
e-Procurement Notice No. ACEVNB-06/2026-27	
1	Type of works : Road & Flood protection works.
2	Total number of Packages : 5 (Five) Nos.
3	Estimated Cost : Rs. 207.08 lakhs to Rs.503.02 lakhs
4	Bid Identification No. : ACEVNB/HID-08/2026-27, ACEVNB/HID-09/2026-27, ACEVNB/HID-10/2026-27, ACEVNB/HID-11/2026-27, ACEVNB/RID-06/2026-27
5	Period of completion : 11(Eleven) months
6	Availability & submission of bids online : From 11.00 AM of 1.10.2026 to 5.00 PM of 26.10.2026.
7	Date of Opening of Technical Bids : 27.10.2026 at 11.00 AM. in the, O/O the Additional Chief Engineer, Vansadhara Nagabali Basin, Paralakhemundi.
8	Procurement Officer : Additional Chief Engineer, Vansadhara Nagabali Basin, Paralakhemundi.
9	Further details can be seen from Govt. Website www.tendersorissa.gov.in and any addendum/ corrigendum/ cancellation will be published in the said website.
Sd/- Additional Chief Engineer Vansadhara Nagabali Basin Paralakhephundi	
OIPR-32001/32417/1/26-27/0008	

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER POTTERU IRRIGATION PROJECT, BALIMELA e-mail Id: ccepotteru123@gmail.com e-Procurement Notice No.- CCE-PIP-BML-11/2026-27			
1. Type of Works:- System Improvement works. 2. Total No. of Works:- One (1) No. 3. Estimated Cost:- 205.88 Lakh 4. Period of Completion:- Eight (8) Calendar Months 5. Class of Contractor:- 'A' & 'B' Class			
Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Bid Amount (Rs. In Lakh)	Availability & Submission of Bids-on line.
Chief Construction Engineer, Potteru Irrigation Project, Batimela, Malkangiri	CCE-PIP-BML-11(1)/2026-27	205.88 Lakh	From 02.10.2026 10.00 A.M. to 11.10.2026.2026 5.00 P.M.
Date of opening of the Tender / Bid:- 12.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M Further details can be seen from the Govt. Website www.tendersodisha.gov.in			
Sd/- Chief Construction Engineer Potteru Irrigation Project, Balimela			
OIPR-32001/32052/1/26-27/0019			

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS**
1 Fastened by a thread (7)
4 A fight that is joined in here and there (5)
7 No keeping quiet when you eat (4)
8 Such colourful designs are just a tissue of lies (4,4)
10 Not against change in a static situation (10)
12 Suit to change into? (6)
13 Stable companion? (6)
15 Kick up a fuss – like stage designers might? (4,1,5)
18 Looking amazed (4-4)
19 Game unsuitable for women (4)
20 An unusual term I deserve (5)
21 Cheeky but attractive features (7)
- DOWN**
1 Despatches terminate in a ship (5)
2 Investigation reaches wrong outcome after right start (8)
3 Note the world shortage (6)
4 She may provide flying courses (3,7)
5 To turn us in or turn us out? (4)
6 The charge incurred by you initially for treatment (7)
9 A man of alien intelligence perhaps (5,5)
11 It may be paternal - or not (8)
12 Kind of kite needs space for storage (7)
14 Guard is fed up to death (6)
16 Sides and top cut off hedges (5)
17 Drink at Sheba's place (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6105 **ACROSS:** 1 Spendthrift, 9 Endorse, 10 Prime, 11 Used, 12 Sculptor, 14 Combat, 16 Ferret, 18 Together, 19 Slam, 22 Theme, 23 Explain, 24 Considerate **DOWN:** 2 Padre, 3 Nero, 4 Trench, 5 Repelled, 6 Fritter, 7 Resuscitate, 8 Betrothment, 13 Panthers, 15 Magneto, 17 Defend, 20 Leapt, 21 Spar

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

We are the people our ____ warned us about - Jimmy Buffet (7)

OATEN

EFHRS

ADRSNT

PREMIE

ANSWER: We are the people our parents warned us about - Jimmy Buffet

SOLUTIONS: Alone, Fresh, Strand, Empire

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6456

			6	4	8			
	6						7	
1	4				6		5	
8	3		4		9		5	1
			2		5			
6	4		7		3		9	8
5		9				1		4
	7						3	
			8	9	6			

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6455

5	8	1	4	7	9	6	3	2
6	4	3	8	5	2	9	1	7
2	7	9	6	3	1	8	5	4
7	3	2	1	9	4	5	8	6
8	1	5	7	6	3	2	4	9
9	6	4	2	8	5	3	7	1
1	9	7	5	2	8	4	6	3
3	5	6	9	4	7	1	2	8
4	2	8	3	1	6	7	9	5

WEST BENGAL STATE ELECTRICITY TRANSMISSION COMPANY LIMITED
(A Government of West Bengal Enterprise)
Registered Office: Vidvut Bhavan, Block-DJ, Sector-II, Bidhannagar, Kolkata-700091
CIN: U40101WB2007SGC113474 • web: www.wbsetcl.in

NIT No.: CE(P)/WBSETCL/Composite Pkg-C13/26-27/28 Date: 29.09.2026

Gezole D/C line of PQCL at proposed Reiganj 220 kV sub-station, (RL – 3.2 K.M. D/C, 14.8 K.M. M/C and 0.15 K.M. U/G cable)

PROJECT-1

Construction of 220 kV D/C or M/C line to make LILQ of Dakshoia (PG) – 18 months from the date of placement of LOA

PROJECT-2

Construction of 132 kV D/C transmission line from Khatra 132 kV sub-station to Goaltore 132 kV sub-station (RL – 55.15 K.M. D/C)

Construction of 132 kV D/C transmission line from Khatra 132 kV sub-station to Manbazar 132 kV sub-station (RL – 43 K.M. D/C)

Construction of 2 nos. 132 kV line bays at Khatra 132 kV sub-station for connectivity with Goaltore 132 kV sub-station

Construction of 2 nos. 132 kV line bays at Khatra 132 kV sub-station for 132 kV D/C connectivity with Manbazar 132 kV sub-station

Construction of 2 nos. 132 kV line bays at Khatra 132 kV sub-station for 132 kV D/C connectivity with Manbazar 132 kV sub-station

Construction of 2 nos. 132 kV line bays at Goaltore 132 kV sub-station for connectivity with Khatra 132 kV sub-station

Construction of 2 nos. 132 kV GIS line bays at Manbazar 132 kV sub-station for connectivity with Khatra 132 kV sub-station

18 months from the date of placement of LOA

Bid documents can be downloaded from 29.09.2026, 02:30 P.M. and bids shall be submitted online up to 04:30 P.M., 28.10.2026. Visit the following websites - www.wbtenders.gov.in, www.wbsetcl.in for details.

ICA/T18372(3)/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

GeM Bid Notice

Invitation of Bid through E-Bidding (GeM Bid Systems)

GeM Bid No. (Custom Bid)

GEM/2026/B/8030531

Name of Work and its location

Bid for "Un-Skilled worker for unloading of 3600 MT scrap for a period of 02 years at Jagadhari Workshop."

Approx. Cost of Work

Bid Cost: Rs.8,37,612/- including GST (Rs. Eight Lakh, Thirty Seven Thousand Six Hundred Twelve Only).

Earnest Money

Rs. 16,750/-

Completion Period of Work

24 months from date of LOA

Cost of Bid document on cash/by post

NIL

Date and Time for submission of Bid

Upto 16:00 hrs. on 19.10.2026

Website particulars, notice board location, complete details of Bid can be seen

Above Bid available on GeM site i.e. www.gem.gov.in

GeM Bid No (Custom Bid):

GEM/2026/B/8030531

Dated:

26.09.2026

3367/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board, Pune (MSAMB)
Plot No. R-7, Market Yard, Gultekadi, Pune -411037
Phone: 020-24528100 / 24528200
Website: www.msamb.com, Email: export@msamb.com

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

MSAMB has developed Export Facility Centre at Mohadi, Tal: Dindori, Dist: Nashik. MSAMB invites proposals from competent agencies for the Operation, Maintenance and Management of the same. The detailed Request for Proposal (RFP) documents and guidelines are available on the e-tendering portal at <http://mahatenders.gov.in>. The last date for submission of proposals is 14/10/2026. Any corrigendum, amendment, modification, or extension of the submission date, if any, shall be uploaded only on <http://mahatenders.gov.in>. Applicants are advised to visit the website regularly for updates.

Managing Director

कार्यालय अधिशाषी अभियन्ता सानिवि जिला खण्ड प्रथम बीकानेर

क्रमांक : 1406 दिनांक : 23/09/26

Short Term Notice Inviting Bid – : 06 /2026-27

Bid for the Construction of Various Non-patchable (Renewal) roads of Sub Dn Bikaner, Khajuwala, Deposit works [MLA LAD] & Budget Announcement work at Deshnok(Bikaner) for the year 2026-27 are invited from interested bidders upto 30.09.2026 [09:30 AM] to 06.10.2026 [06:00 PM] & Open date 07.10.2026 [11:00 AM], other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal <http://www.pwd.rajasthan.gov.in> & eproc.rajasthan.gov.in & sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, of the state and departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 589.82 Lakh.

UBN No.

1. PWD2627WSOB12946
2. PWD2627WSOB12947
3. PWD2627WSOB12948
4. PWD2627WSOB12950

Sd/-

Executive Engineer

PWD Distt. Dn-I, Bikaner

DIPRC/C/16439/2026

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD CITY DIVISION AJMER

No.:-EE/City/Ajmer/NIT/2026-27/D-1926 Dated:- 28/9/26

NOTICE INVITING BID No. -20/2026-27

NIB Code No.:-PWD2627A 2895

Tender for 06 Nos works are invited from interested bidders up to 06:00 PM on 05th October, 2026 other particulars of the bids may be visit on the procurement portal <http://HYPERLINK> "http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in", HYPERLINK "http://sppp.raj.nic.in")" of the State and DIPR departmental website.

The approximate value of the procurement is **Rs 701.84 Lacs.**

UBN No.:-

1. PWD2627WSOB13004, 2. PWD2627WSOB13005 3. PWD2627WSOB13006, 4. PWD2627WSOB13007, 5. PWD2627WSOB13008 6. PWD2627WSOB13009

Sd/-

(Vipin Kumar Jindal)

Executive Engineer

PWD City Division Ajmer

DIPRC/16469/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Nirmal Narayan S/o Ganesh Chander Rlo Village - Sindiya, P.S. Sindiya, Distt. Samastipur Bihar, Also At:- 113, 4th floor DDA Golf View Sec-23, Dwarka Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case FIR No. 41/2022 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS: New Delhi Railway Station, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nirmal Narayan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nirmal Narayan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Nirmal Narayan** accused of **FIR No. 41/2022 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS: New Delhi Railway Station, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.10.2026**.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Abhishek Pandey (HDB Financial Services) R/o 6164/13, 2nd Floor, Main Bara Hindu Rao Azad Market, Delhi-110006** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. CC NI ACT-798/19, U/s 138 NI Act, PS Rajouri Garden, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Abhishek Pandey** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Abhishek Pandey** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Abhishek Pandey** of case **FIR No./CC NI ACT-798/19, U/s 138 NI Act, PS Rajouri Garden, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **17.11.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Gaurav Singal

JMFC (West), Room No. 04

Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

IKF FINANCE LIMITED

HEAD OFFICE : # 40-144, Corporate Centre, M.G.Road, Vijayawada-520 010. Phone No.: 0866-2474644.

POSSESSION NOTICE (For immovable property) Rule 8 (1)

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of IKF Finance Limited (IKF) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a Demand Notice dated 22-07-2026 calling upon the borrower/s and co borrower/s 1) M S M S DEEPAK FOTO STUDIO Rep. by its Proprietor Pradeep Kumar Dhurvey, 2) Mr. Mr. Pradeep Kumar Dhurvey, 3) Mrs. Rachna Gound, 4) Khusboo Dhurvey, 5) Mrs. Gyanwati Dhurvey, All R/o. House Number 1613, Behind Doctor Colony, Madfaiya Mohalla, Paurwa Jabalpur 482003, Madhya Pradesh (Loan Account No. LXJB03524-250303578) to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs. 25,67,845/- (Rupees Twenty Five Lakh Sixty Seven Thousand Eight Hundred Forty Five Only), within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest Enforcement rule 2002, on this **25th day of September Month of the year 2026**.

The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the IKF for an amount of **Rs. 25,67,845/- (Rupees Twenty Five Lakh Sixty Seven Thousand Eight Hundred Forty Five Only)**, against Loan Account No. LXJB03524-250303578 as due on **22/07/2026** with further interest and Charges thereon.

"The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, If the borrower clears the dues of the "IKF" together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred, at any time before the date fixed for sale or transfer, the secured assets shall not be sold or transferred by "IKF" and no further step shall be taken by "IKF" for transfer or sale of the secured assets.

SCHEDULE OF THE PROPERTY

All that Mouza Purwa, Patwani halka Purwa, Tehsil-Gorkhpur, Distt-Jabalpur Khasra Number 2112/4 Plot Area 3444 Sq. Ft (319.99 Sq. Mtr.) Jabalpur Madhya Pradesh and bounded as follows: **North:** Jagdeesh Prasad, **South:** Patel Ji, **East:** Road, **West:** Koshla Ji.

Date: 25.09.2026, Place: Jabalpur

Sd/-

Authorised Officer, IKF Finance Limited

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today you might find that you identify with your possessions more than usual. In fact, this could be why you might be tempted to be a bit extravagant or go overboard. This same sense of largeness might creep into your financial decisions. Tonight: Check your money.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is a positive day for you because the Moon is in your sign dancing with Jupiter. Keep in mind that you love antiques and beautiful things, and today, your financial judgement might be a bit off because you're extravagant. Tonight: You're strong.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a playful time for you, which is why you will enjoy social outings, vacations, sports events, the arts and fun activities with kids. Your positive communication style today might attract others. Enthusiasm is contagious. Tonight: Pleasant solitude.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Be careful about going overboard with financial matters today. You might spend too much. This is because there's an aspect of excess influencing your financial decisions. Tonight: Be friendly.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Do be aware that you're noticed today. In fact, some people know personal details about your private life. Others see you as confident, but also benevolent and compassionate today. Tonight: Be modest.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today you might be attracted more than usual to philosophical topics that make you think more about life and how things are and how things should be. You might examine other people's attitudes to politics and religion. Tonight: Explore and learn.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You are a people-oriented sign, and today, you feel generous to friends. In fact, if making a decision about how to share something or divide an inheritance, make sure to protect your own self-interests and not give away the farm. Tonight: Check your finances.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is an excellent day for you to shop for wardrobe goodies, although please be aware of the restrictions of the moon alert. Whether shopping or in discussions with partners or close friends, guard against going overboard. Tonight: Be friendly.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Work-related travel might happen for many of you today. Whatever you do, whether it's with your work, your health or dealing with a pet, you'll be inclined to think big and be extravagant. However, you will also want to be benevolent. Tonight: Work.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Enjoy socialising, partying and the arts, especially the theater, movies and galleries. Sports events and playful times with children will please you. This is also a good day for financial speculation if you're aware of the moon alert. Tonight: Socialise.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Your interactions with others will be friendly and mutually rewarding because people are openhearted and generous today. These pleasant interactions will take place with partners, close friends as well as members of the general public. Tonight: Relax.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Don't bite off more than you can chew today, especially in discussions with others, and making promises or commitments. That's because you feel confident, enthusiastic and ready to grab the world by the tail. Tonight: Discussions.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Mohit S/o Pawan R/o Galla Ki Building, Gali No. 09, Khajuri Khas, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 865/2024 U/s 304(2)/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S. Kashmere Gate, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mohit** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mohit** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mohit** of case **FIR No. 865/2024 U/s 304(2)/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S. Kashmere Gate, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.12.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Vaibhav Garg

Judicial Magistrate First Class-11

Central District, Room No. 138

Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/13426/N/2026 (Court Matter)

OFFICE OF THE ENGINEER-IN-CHIEF (CIVIL), ODISHA

NIRMAN SOUDHA, UNIT-V, BHUBANESWAR

INVITATIONS FOR BIDS (IFB)

E-mail ID: cebuidings_orissa@yahoo.co.in
cebuidings@rediffmail.com, Tel. -(0674)- 2391523

File No.-B-I-Sports-06/2025 35648 Bhubaneswar, the 25th Sept., 2026

Invitation for Bids

2nd Corrigendum

Tender Reference No. CE-Bldg-II-32/2026-27

Name of the Works:

(1) "Construction of Govt. College of Nursing (G + 1) and Hostel Building (G + 3) at Balukhanda, Dist.-Puri",

(2) "Construction of Govt. College of Nursing (G + 1) and Hostel Building (G + 3) at Champaguda, Dist.-Koraput",

(3) "Construction of Block Level Stadium in Bangomunda Block (with Indoor Hall) under Bolangir District".

The following changes have been made in Bid Identification No. CE-Bldg-II-32/2026-27

1. Bid documents such as DTCN / BOQ etc. can be seen / downloaded from the Govt. Website i.e. www.tendersorissa.gov.in, during the period from dt.06.10.2026 to 17.00 hours of dt.21.10.2026 instead of dt.24.09.2026 to dt.09.10.2026 for **ONLINE BIDDING** respectively.

2. Online bids shall be received till 17.00 hours of dt.21.10.2026 instead of dt.09.10.2026.

3. The technical bids will be opened at 11.30 A.M. of dt.22.10.2026 instead of dt. 12.10.2026.

All other terms and conditions remain unchanged.

Sd/-

Chief Engineer, Buildings-II, Odisha, Bhubaneswar

OIPR-34001/34117/1/26-27/0075

CENTRUM HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

peoplehome

Registered Office : Unit No. 301, Third Floor, Harbhajan Commercial Premises Co-operative Society Ltd., CST Road, Opp. BPCL Petrol Pump, Kalina, Santacruz (East), Mumbai – 400098. CIN: U65922MH2016PLC273826

GOODS REMOVAL NOTICE

To, Gaurav Kumar (Borrower), Anitha Devi (Co-Borrower), Satpal Singh (Co-Borrower), Saurabh Jainar (Co-Borrower)
Property – House on part of Khasra no.532, adm. 366.12 sq. mtr., Village SSIkhera, Tehsil Mawana, Distt. Meerut-250406, Uttarpradesh.
Dear Sir/Madam,
This letter formally demands the removal of all goods and personal property belonging to you from the immovable property located at in the rights, piece and parcel of immovable property Property Property – House on part of Khasra no.532, adm. 366.12 sq. mtr., Village SSIkhera, Tehsil-Mawana, Distt. Meerut-250406, Uttarpradesh. Boundaries-East-House of Jai Karan, West-12ft wide rasta, North-Plot of Kiran Pal & South-Plot of Gaurav.
As you are aware, the previously mentioned property possession was lawfully taken on 24th of September 2026 as per the DM order passed on 13-08-2025 on pursuant to SARFAESI Proceeding initiated in the loan code **MTCMT23011177**. At the time of possession, several items of personal belonging to you remain on the premises. The inventory Panchnama has been attached herewith.
You are hereby required to remove all your personal goods and belongings from the premises within the next 15 days from the date of this notice. Please contact Authorised officer **Mr. Amit K (7409310969)** to arrange access to property for removing your belongings. You will be required to provide identification and sign a release form during removal of items from the property in possession. Please be ensure that all the items are removed by **15th October 2026**. If you fail to remove your belongings by the specified deadline, after this date, any remaining goods will be considered abandoned and may be disposed of or transferred to the new owner at their discretion, without further notice to you. Please note that you will bear all costs associated with the removal of your goods. CHFL disclaims any liability for damage that may occur during the removal process and/or disposed of and/or transferred to the new owner in event of failure to removal from premises by above mention deadline.
Thank you for your prompt attention to this matter.

Yours sincerely,

For Centrum Housing Finance Limited

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

1984

55.42s

PT Usha had set the 400m hurdles national record at the Los Angeles Olympics. Vithya Ramraj equalled the mark at the Hangzhou Asian Games before breaking it in Nagoya

54.75s

2026

“

When my coach said you have it in you to go (under) 55 seconds, I never believed it. But today I believed it. My coach is with me, my God is with me.

VITHYA RAMRAJ AFTER BAGGING A BRONZE MEDAL AT THE 2026 ASIAD

”

Vithya breaks Usha's 42-year-old record for 400m hurdles bronze

After months of preparation and years of chasing a mark that had once seemed out of reach, the 28-year-old from Coimbatore shaved 0.67 seconds off it in Nagoya



Vithya Ramraj secured her second consecutive Asiad bronze medal in the women's 400m hurdles. PTI

Gulveer wins second silver

GULVEER SINGH won another silver medal at the Asian Games 2026 after clocking a personal best of 3:36.72 in the men's 1500m final. He finished behind Kazuto Iizawa of Japan, who made a new Games record with a timing of 3:36.35. Earlier, Gulveer had bagged silver in men's 10000m. Meanwhile, long jumper Sreeshankar Murali also won the silver with a best jump of 8.07m despite getting injured in the fourth attempt and skipping his last two attempts. Parul Chaudhary also won her second bronze medal of the edition in women's 5000m, behind Winfred Yavi and Nozomi Tanaka. ENS

Months of prep

For Vithya, the breakthrough came after months of preparation and years of chasing a mark that had once seemed out of reach. After being asked repeatedly when she would break 55 seconds, the

questions had shifted to when she would run under 54. The scrutiny had begun to frustrate her. "The last Asian Games surprise was, okay, but for today, we started preparations last November, we fight for it," she said. "Everyone's first question,

when you will go 55? Then, when will you go 54? I was so upset about that."

Her journey had been anything but straightforward. The daughter of a truck driver, Vithya grew up in Coimbatore. She and her twin sister, Nithya, took up

athletics, their mother enrolling them in a sports hostel in Erode. When Vithya's career stalled, she left the national camp and began training independently under coach Nehpal Singh Rathore. Without the camp's support, she had to find a way to pay for her training, food and accommodation. Nithya, a national-level hurdler who works with the Income Tax Department, helped support her financially before Vithya secured a job with the Indian Railways.

The sisters went on to represent India at the 2023 Asian Games. Matching Usha's record there showed Vithya it could be done. Hangzhou was also nerve-racking. "When I saw the whole crowd (in Hangzhou), I got nervous. And my coach wasn't with me either. But this time, AFI supported me, TOPS supported me, everyone supported me to get my coach inside the track," she said. "So when I saw him, I got confidence and told myself, 'Come on Vithya, you can do it!'"

Rathore's instructions were to attack the first two hurdles, hold her rhythm until the sixth, then go all out to the finish. As she stood on the start line, he reminded her of the plan through gestures, standing in the stands within her eye line.

For a moment, even the weather threatened to unsettle her. Heavy rain during the warm-up had left her soaked, and she was wary of hurdling in the wet because of the risk of an ankle injury. "I never even train for hurdles when it rains. So today, thank God the rain stopped! But on warm up, full rain. I was completely wet, but after coming to stay on the track, it's alright," she said.

Once the race began, she executed the plan, holding her rhythm through the opening hurdles before digging deep in the final stretch. Rathore said she had run the first eight hurdles well. "That was the strongest part of her race today. The rhythm broke at ninth, just a tiny error, but other than that it was a butter smooth race," he said. For Vithya, the medal was a reward for years of work. The record was something else. Asked whether she valued the medal or the national record more, she chose the record. "This race will not come again. Today was my day, so I went for timing. Not for a medal."

In Hangzhou, she matched the record. In Nagoya, she took 0.67 seconds off it.

“The greatest legacy of a record is not how long it stands, but how it inspires the next athlete to dream of going beyond it.”

PT USHA, IN HER MESSAGE TO VITHYA RAMRAJ

Yashvir-Rohit duo reaches podium in Chopra's absence



Yashvir Singh (L) and Rohit Yadav finished with silver and bronze while Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage took the gold. PTI

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, September 28

WHEN NEERAJ Chopra pulled out of the Asian Games weeks before, doubt settled over India's men's javelin. At the 2023 edition, India had finished first and second. Rohit Yadav was the only other thrower in the squad, and Commonwealth Games bronze medallist Yashvir Singh was added at the last minute. Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage was the clear favourite. The question was whether Rohit and Yashvir could deliver on the big stage without Neeraj.

On Sunday night, with rain pouring on the track at Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium in Nagoya, they could not repeat the gold and silver of Neeraj and Kishore Kumar Jena. But both finished on the podium behind Pathirage, Yashvir with silver and Rohit with bronze.

"Recently I've won a bronze medal in the Commonwealth Games also, and this is my second lifetime achievement, this silver medal. The competition was very difficult because Rumesh threw 88.55 metres and my throw was 85m. The weather is not so good so the javelin grip was very slippery when we were throwing," Yashvir said after his win.

The slippery conditions did not stop him from producing a personal best of 85.72m, better than the 85.41m he threw in Glasgow to win Commonwealth Games bronze.

It had not been easy getting there. After breaking the 80m mark in 2022, Yashvir got stuck throwing under 80m because of complications with his body. For two full seasons, 2023 and 2024, he could not cross it.

"I was genuinely struggling. I don't know what was wrong. Probably it was the mental gap and I needed to play big competitions," Yashvir had told *The*

Indian Express before going to the Asian Games. "I had shoulder surgery also. It took me some time to regain my self belief. I would always look at Neeraj Chopra and think if he can do it, even I can."

He kept grinding at the domestic level, competing more than 10 times in the 2025 season. "The regular grind and the competition level at the national meets really helped me in gaining that confidence," he had said. With 85.72m, Yashvir also cleared the 85.50m qualifying mark for the 2027 World Athletics Championships in Beijing.

Different struggle

Rohit's struggle was different. He was touted as the next big thrower after Neeraj, finished 10th at the 2022 World Championships and represented India at the 2022 Commonwealth Games. Then an injury took away his shot at the 2023 Asian Games and 2023 World Championships. Kishore Kumar Jena won the Asian Games silver, and Sachin Yadav finished fourth at the 2025 Worlds, ahead of Neeraj.

"I always thought about what happened to me. Injuries are part of an athlete's life but seeing major tournaments go by while I was struggling was not a nice feeling," Rohit had told this paper.

He came back slowly and steadily, and was having a fantastic 2026, with two throws beyond 87m, before hitting a roadblock at the Commonwealth Games.

"When I couldn't finish on the podium at CWG, I thought, are we back to square one? But then I told myself that the Asian Games is a chance for me to redeem myself," he said.

His 84.35m on Sunday was well short of his personal best. It was still his first medal at a multi-sport Games.

• MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	132	53	45	230
2	Japan	41	68	63	172
3	S Korea	21	26	43	90
4	Uzb'stan	12	17	13	42
5	Kaz'stan	9	13	23	45
12	India	4	20	21	45

DAY 10 CAPSULE

Haul: **4 Silver, 4 Bronze**

4 SILVER

• Men's 1500m

Gulveer Singh nabbed the silver medal, setting a personal best time.

• Men's long jump

Though he injured himself on his fourth jump, Sreeshankar Murali managed to win silver.

• Women's 25m pistol

Esha Singh missed out on gold by the narrowest of margins but took home the silver.

• Men's Javelin

Yash Vir Singh set a personal best of 85.72m. Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage pipped him to the top spot.

4 BRONZE

• Women's 5000m

Parul Chaudhary added another bronze to her 2026 Asiad campaign. This is her fourth bronze in Asiad.

• Women's 400m hurdles

Vithya Ramraj won bronze in the women's 400m hurdles, setting a national record time of 54.75, improving on PT Usha's time set 42 years ago.

• Men's javelin

Rohit Yadav bagged the bronze with a best throw of 84.35m, securing a double podium for India in this event.

• Women's 78kg kurash

Pinky Balhara won her second medal at the Asian Games overall.

• TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 11

Athletics: Women's high jump final (3:35 PM), Women's 800m final (4:20 PM), Men's 5000m final (4:45 PM), Mixed 4x100m relay (5:18 PM), Women's 4x400m relay (5:35 PM), Men's 4x400m relay (5:47 PM)

• Asian Games medallist Gulveer Singh and men's 100m national record holder Gurindervir Singh will be among athletes in action.

Shooting: Men's & Women's trap Team Final (6:30 AM), Women's trap individual final (10:30 AM if qualified), Men's trap individual final (12 PM if qualified)

• Ahvar Rizvi, Kynan Chenai and Shapath Bhardwaj in the men's field and Manisha Keer, Aashima Ahlawat and Neeru from the women's team will seek another shooting medal.

Boxing: Women's 65kg semi-final, Men's 80kg semi-final, Men's over-90kg semi-final (9:30 AM onwards)

• Medal assured for Parveen Hooda, Narendar Berwal, and CWG gold medallist Ankush Panghal, they will all be hoping the semis will not be their last bout.

• UNENDING SUFFERING

For Palestinian athletes, making it to the Asian Games is a win in itself

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 28

WHEN MAHMOUD Daifallah first walked into a karate club near his home in Ramallah, he was eight years old. His mother had taken him and his brother there during a holiday, looking for a way to keep them occupied. It was an unplanned visit that turned into a lifelong pursuit. "The holiday has not ended to this day," he says.

Sixteen years later, Daifallah is in Nagoya for the Asian Games, finishing fifth in karate, narrowly missing out on a bronze medal.

But between that first visit to a club and the competition mats in Japan lies a journey marked by checkpoints, travel restrictions, training amid ruins of a years-long conflict and the steady erosion of the sporting world he grew up in.

The Israel-Palestine war erupted on October 7, 2023, as the previous Asian Games in Hangzhou were drawing to a close. By the time athletes gath-

The damage to Palestinian sport extends far beyond the difficulties of international travel

ered in Japan for the 2026 edition, much of the infrastructure that sustained Palestine's sporting ambitions had been destroyed, while the conflict had claimed the lives of athletes, coaches and other members of the sporting community.

The scale of the devastation is laid out in a brochure being distributed by the Palestine Olympic Committee (POC) at the Games. According to the committee, 1,014 people involved in sport — athletes, technical staff and administrators — have been killed, most of them in the Gaza Strip.

Of the 265 sporting facilities destroyed, 181 have been completely razed and 84 partially damaged. Among them is Gaza's only athletics track. The

Yarmouk Stadium, Palestine Stadium and Al-Durra Stadium have been converted into shelters for displaced people.

"These figures have left deep scars on Palestinian sports movement, affecting both its human resources and sporting infrastructure," the POC said in the brochure.

For Daifallah, those figures are not distant statistics. They describe a sporting ecosystem in which clubs have closed, young athletes have been forced to abandon training and the simple act of travelling to a competition has become a challenge in itself. "As you know, as a Palestinian athlete, nothing is easy," Daifallah, one of 67 athletes here, tells *The Indian Express*. "We are suffering from war, from rockets, from everything."

Training is tough enough in those conditions. Travelling for competitions is a bigger challenge. Palestine has no airport. To compete abroad, Daifallah must travel by road from Ramallah to Jericho, cross check-



Mahmoud Daifallah finished fifth in karate at the Asiad. EXPRESS

points, transfer his baggage and take a bus to the Jordanian border, in Amman, before catching a flight.

It is a journey that requires

careful planning, but even that cannot guarantee he will make it to a competition. "Sometimes, the occupation authorities do not allow you to leave Palestine,

and all your preparation goes to waste," Daifallah, who competes in the -67kg kumite, says.

Difficult existence

Since the Hangzhou Games, movement restrictions in the West Bank have made an already difficult existence more uncertain. "You have to deal with uncertainty before you can even think about the competition itself," Daifallah says.

But the damage to Palestinian sport extends far beyond the difficulties of international travel. In Gaza, sporting facilities have been destroyed. In the West Bank, Daifallah says, clubs have shut down because families can no longer afford to send their children for training. "Sometimes, the parents of a child tell me that they will not take their child to the club," he says. "I ask them why, and they say that their financial situation does not allow them to take their child to the training club."

The result is a generation of young athletes whose ambitions are being squeezed by circum-

stances beyond their control.

For Mohammad Edweedar, a Palestinian 800m runner who competed in Hangzhou, keeping his athletic career alive has meant making do with whatever space and equipment are available. He has often had to train on the streets, far from the facilities and support systems that athletes elsewhere rely on.

Even getting the right pair of spikes, essential for a middle-distance runner, can be difficult. "Ideally, I would have them a week before a competition, or at least two or three days in advance, to get accustomed to racing in them. But that is not easy," he says, adding that the difficulties of training and travelling have contributed to injuries, one of the reasons he couldn't be in Nagoya.

The uncertainty follows athletes beyond the track. After the Hangzhou Games, Edweedar and his teammates were stranded in Jordan for around two weeks while trying to return to Palestine. The border had closed, leaving them unable to

get home as their families waited on the other side. "It was very stressful because my family and our loved ones were back in Palestine," he says.

The war has also taken away people who were central to his sporting life. Edweedar speaks of losing coach Bilal Abu Saman, whom he describes as someone very special and close to him, and fellow athlete Waseem Abudib.

For Daifallah, the Palestinian uniform is a reminder of why he continues to compete, even when the circumstances make a normal sporting career seem out of reach.

"When I put on the Palestinian uniform, I feel that I am carrying something bigger than myself," he says.

Edweedar, too, returns to the reason he first took up running, even as the losses mount and the future remains uncertain. "I remind myself every day why I started competing and why I started running," he says. "It was for my family and my people."

Priya fights back; India assured of six boxing medals



Priya Ghanghas and team. BFI

Nitin Sharma

Chandigarh, September 28

PRIYA GHANGHAS knows the feeling of trailing after the first round as the 20-year-old Haryana boxer has had her share of bouts that began that way.

In the women's 60kg quarter-final against Tajikistan's Mijgona Samadova, it happened again, and a medal depended on how she responded. It came in the form of an unanimous 5-0 win and a semi-final berth. Samadova is a southpaw, and in the opening minute she showed a strong right lead punch and a right hook. Priya was left catching up with her speed. Priya's jab failed to land early, so she changed her approach, throwing it in combination with a right straight and pushing Samadova towards the ropes. The round still went 2-3 to the Tajik.

The second round turned. Priya's pressure had Samadova trying to come in close and hold, and she lost a point for it. The Indian took the round. In the third, Samadova looked tired, and Priya kept working with combinations and speed.

Santiago Nieva, India's women's foreign head coach, told *The Indian Express* from Japan: "We knew that the Tajik boxer would be a bit tricky being a southpaw and having a good lead punch as well as a lead hook. She neutralised Priya's jab initially but then Priya gained some momentum in the later half of the first round with the combinations."

Ghanghas, the Commonwealth Games champion, next meets China's Chengyu Yang in the semi-finals. She has beaten Yang before, in the quarter-finals of the Asian Championships on her way to the title earlier this year. Yang arrives with a fresh reputation after beating Nesthy Petecio of the Philippines, the Tokyo Olympics silver medalist and Paris Olympics bronze medalist, 5-0. Nieva believes the Indian has the edge. "The Chinese showed a lot of improvement as compared to the way she boxed in Asian Championships," he said.

"Priya has a very good left hook as well jumping left hook and the variations can come handy in applying pressure on the Chinese. Her strength has been her belief in close bouts."

Earlier, Tokyo Olympics bronze medalist Lovlina Borgohain beat South Korea's Seong Suyeon 5-0 in the 75kg quarter-finals, and in the evening session Kapil Pokhriya beat Korea's Kim Gi-chae by the same margin in the men's 90kg.

India are guaranteed of six boxing medals.

ASIAN GAMES

It was amazing, and I've never had an experience like this before. Definitely going into my bucket of amazing experiences.

ESHA SINGH, ON SURVIVING MULTIPLE SHOOT-OFFS IN THE FINAL

Chaos, delays, five shoot-offs: Esha's wild road to silver medal

Esha Singh turned a chaotic Asian Games 25m pistol final into a test of resilience, using unexpected stoppages to regain her composure

Mihir Vasavda

Nagoya, September 28

ESHA SINGH had a curious reason to be grateful for the chaos that nearly wore her down. As the women's 25m pistol final at the Asian Games descended into a series of shoot-offs, officials' errors halted the contest and left China's Xiao Jiaruixuan waiting nearly 15 minutes; Esha got what she desperately needed: time.

Her shooting hand was tightening. The pressure was building. And the long interruptions, frustrating as they were, gave her a chance to relax, reset and stay in a contest that seemed determined to stretch on. "I was kind of grateful for the errors and mistakes the judges were making because I got some rest," Esha said later. "Maybe you can call it God's grace, giving me some time off and just to think about it."

For a while, it seemed to work. The 21-year-old from Hyderabad clawed her way back from the brink of elimination, survived three shoot-offs against North Korea's Kim Hyon Suk and forced Xiao into a second tie-breaker for gold. But after the two shooters finished level at 38 hits in the regulation final and tied again at 4-4 in the first shoot-off, Xiao finally pulled away, winning the decisive series 3-2. Esha had to settle for silver. "It was amazing, and I've never had an experience like this before. Definitely going into my bucket of amazing experiences, and I'm grateful for every moment. Though it was nerve-racking, it was amazing," she said.

Breaking point

The final had begun very differently. Esha hit all five targets in her opening series and followed it up with four more to take an early lead. But the rhythm soon deserted her. A three-hit series allowed Xiao to move ahead, and the Indian found herself repeatedly fighting to stay in contention.

At one point, she slipped outside the medal positions. With another disappointing finish threatening to follow her struggles in the 10m air pistol, Esha needed a response. She delivered a perfect five-hit series to stay alive. The fight for the medals then became a contest of endurance. Esha and Kim finished level at 34 hits, forcing a shoot-off. The first two tie-



Esha Singh survived five shoot-offs in the final of the women's 25m pistol event to win the silver medal. PTI

The 25m pistol, however, is a discipline in which Esha has consistently delivered.

breakers failed to separate them, with both recording three hits apiece. After another lengthy interruption, Esha finally prevailed 3-2 in the third, securing at least silver and setting up a showdown with Xiao. The Chinese shooter had been waiting for nearly 15 minutes as the battle for the other medal positions dragged on. But when Esha returned to the firing line, the Indian showed little sign of being overwhelmed by the delay. She had, however, begun to feel the strain. "Because of the pressure, I think this time, in my mind, I don't know if it was a thought or if it was really happening, but my hand was genuinely getting very, very tight and very tired without me realising, even in the first series," Esha said. "So I just tried releasing or relaxing it a bit."

The stoppages, she explained, had given her an opportunity to do precisely that. "It looks like a situation where the zone is breaking for an athlete, but in my case, it really helped me." Esha had another hurdle to clear. Xiao, who had led for much of the final, was now the only obstacle between her and gold. The two shooters finished the regulation final level at 38 hits, forcing a shoot-off.

They were tied again at 4-4 in the first tie-breaker, leaving

the title to be decided in one final five-shot series. Xiao hit three targets to Esha's two to claim gold.

Silver lining

The silver was a measure of redemption for Esha after a disappointing outing in the women's 10m air pistol earlier in the Games. She finished 15th with a score of 572, while India narrowly missed a team bronze, finishing fourth on the count of inner tens.

The 25m pistol, however, is a discipline in which Esha has consistently delivered. The world No. 1 has won two World Cup titles and a bronze at the World Championships over the past 18 months. At the Munich World Cup in May, she produced a record-breaking performance in the final, registering 43 hits to set senior and junior world records. The silver also increased India's shooting tally, with Esha adding another podium finish in one of the country's strongest disciplines. She had also won individual silver medals in both the 10m and 25m pistol events at the previous Asian Games in Hangzhou, along with a team gold and silver.

India, meanwhile, finished fifth in the women's 25m pistol team event. The team had been one point behind China, but Rahi Sarnobat's opening-series miss in the rapid-fire round cost them valuable points.

For Esha, though, the day ended with a medal — her second successive individual silver in the 25m pistol at the Asian Games, and a reminder of why the event remains her strongest.

Rahi's costly miss derails 25m pistol team medal hopes

Express News Service

New Delhi, September 28

INDIA'S POOR luck at the Asian Games continued on Monday; this time, the shooting contingent faced the brunt of a missed team event in the Women's 25m pistol event in Nagoya on Monday. After a disappointing pistol campaign that has seen only one medal - a mixed team gold in the 10m air pistol event - the morning looked primed for an upturn in fortunes.

Instead, what followed was a heavily contested moment that was a prelude to drama in a final that delivered its own twists and turns. In her first series of the rapid event, Indian shooter **Rahi Sarnobat (in picture)**, a former Asian Games gold medalist in the women's 25m pistol, missed her shot. Judges at the range concluded she hit the frame of her target and had gained no points.

Rahi appealed the ruling as it seemed highly unlikely she would miss the mark altogether at this stage of her career, and in an event of this calibre. But the ruling stayed unchanged, and she finished her rapid series with a score of 86.

That one missed shot eliminated India from winning a medal in the women's 25m pistol team event. Despite stor-



ming back with a series of 99 and 96, Rahi's overall score was only 568, with 16 inner tens. It meant she and her teammate Manu Bhaker would return home without a medal from these Asian Games. Esha Singh, on the other hand, qualified for the finals and was almost eliminated in fourth position before clawing back. She then mounted a charge for the gold medal but narrowly lost in the shootout to win a silver medal.

India's pistol shooters have endured their share of setbacks at major events. At the Tokyo 2020 Olympics, Bhaker suffered a gun malfunction that, despite efforts to fix it, contributed to a disappointing exit from her first Olympic Games. At the Asian Games in Hangzhou, Bhaker was affected by empty shells from the left of her range entering her line of sight, hurting her performance.

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Fine margins, poor form prove costly in title defence for India



D Gukesh and captain Srinath Narayanan. MICHAL WALUSZA / FIDE

Amit Kamath & Mayank Chaudhary

Mumbai/New Delhi, September 28

"WE'RE PROUD of the silver, but are not celebrating like last time."

Vidit Gujrathi explains the Indian contingent's mixed feelings after the Chess Olympiad where the two teams could not defend their gold medals from Budapest 2024. The contingent returned from Samarkand with a glut of medals and accolades: silver in the open section, bronze in the women's event, the Nona Gaprindashvili Cup given for the best side overall, individual medals for six out of the 10 players, including a gold for Savitha Shri.

But what the Indians really craved were the ones that Uzbekistan (open section) and China (women's section) pocketed.

Both the Indian teams lost once over 11 rounds, the men to the hosts and the women to old nemesis Poland. The women did well to hold title rivals like China, Kazakhstan, and Georgia to draws. The men, on the other hand, will be sore about being held to a tied score by Azerbaijan and Hungary.

"The last Olympiad was so special that we created an unrealistic benchmark. Results like those from Budapest — where you don't lose a single match and claim the title with a round to spare — will probably not be achieved in many Olympiads. It's never happened before. That's why this silver was not a big cause of celebration. But we are proud of the silver because it was not an easy Olympiad," reasons Vidit.

The three members of the coaching staff and one player that The Indian Express spoke to indicated the feeling in the Indian camp that winning both sections was well within their reach. "There were misses from us. That's undeniable. But we want to be slightly careful micro-analysing these mistakes because that's just how games at an Olympiad go," says Vaibhav Suri, who was part of the coaching set-up of the open section team. "In 2024, it was super clean. Every person was in really good shape. We were taking every chance we were getting. This time, it was a little dicey. There were situations where evidence showed that not everyone was in their best shape. Pragg was missing some wins. Arjun missed a few too. Nihal lost against the Uzbeks. Gukesh also missed once (in the final round)."

Playing on the top board, the Indian open team's in-form player coming into the Olympiad, R Praggnanandhaa racked up three wins while losing none. On board 2, Arjun Erigaisi had two wins in 10 rounds and a defeat. On the third board, Nihal Sarin had four wins and two defeats. The surprise element for India was on board 4, with world champion D Gukesh, who until his final round defeat, had seven wins in 10 rounds without losing. Vidit played just three games, winning one and drawing two.

Team captain Srinath Narayanan explained that the team's strategy was to squeeze opponents in the last two boards. "With most teams having a pretty strong 1 and 2, boards 3 and 4 were generally craved where we wanted to put maximum pressure. In a lot of cases, it felt nice to have Nihal and Gukesh exerting that pressure," says Srinath.

Similar story

In the women's section too, the team relied on wins from their third and fourth boards via Vantika Agrawal (five wins, one loss in eight games) and the previously unheralded Savitha Shri, who turned out to be a sledgehammer of a player winning eight games and drawing two. On the top boards, Koneru Humpy proved to be a reliable campaigner with four wins and no defeats in 10 games. But R Vaishali's form was a concern, with her winning just her first round clash before enduring three draws and two defeats. She did not play in the final three rounds.

Divya Deshmukh (four wins and a loss in 10 rounds) deputised for her on board 2 in five of the 11 rounds. Swayams Mishra, the captain for the women's team, points out the fine margins that decided the colour of the medals. "We had a good chance of beating China (in the penultimate round) and things would have been very different. Kazakhstan was losing in that round but won with a miracle. That changed everything, in terms of the pairing in the final round as well," he says, adding that the players were "drained out physically, psychologically and emotionally."

There was an unprecedented amount of criticism too on social media. "India has developed as a chess-playing nation in the last few years. The amount of criticism the players and coaches received was unbelievable. But I see this as fans having big expectations from us."

INDIA V WEST INDIES, ODI SERIES

Kuldeep, the enforcer, brings value with wickets and thrifty economy rate

Sandip G

Thiruvananthapuram, September 28

THE SUN was punishing and Kuldeep Yadav just wanted to grab the ball and bowl. From his shifting outposts, where he and the rest just watched West Indies openers shred India's bowlers and plans apart, he would shadow bowl, stretch his sinews and warm-up, hoping for a summons from the centre. He had to wait for his turn till the 16th over, and when he found the ball, he ensured that the ball floated and danced to his chords; he guaranteed, as he often does, that the understated visitors wouldn't build a platform for an unprecedented shock.

Beyond it, he underlined that he is too valuable a component to be compromised in the World Cup balance-churn.

Every wicket was a cathartic release for him; the wait that was gnawing at him; his eagerness to bowl, pick wickets, and define games; his alacrity to ensure his tickets to South Africa. He is arguably the finest contemporary spinner in the world, yet in a cruel irony, he has to prove himself every time he turns up for his country.

It's a reflection of the times. The stocks of a high-class spinner plummeted as his batting prowess is modest. A batting collapse, his head rolls off the chopping blocks to accommodate that spinner who chimes in with the bat the next game; to add an extra seamer or batsman, he is again the sacrificial goat. He is his country's ninth highest wicket-taker, but two horrible games against New Zealand were all it took for him to be thrust to periphery.

But in Greenfield he reass-

serted the worth of a high-class wrist spinner. He is a rare one, not just because he bowls left-arm wrist spin, but because he has wizardry of the wrists and the control of the finger spinners. The control he brings is different from a finger spinner, but one he acquires through his pure deception. He doesn't keep the batsmen quiet by landing the ball on same zone repeatedly, as is the golden virtue in this format; he revels in the opposite, of mixing his lengths, speeds, trajectories, angles, drift, drop and turn, a master of disguises.

The wicket of John Campbell was instructive. Campbell is a competent and compulsive sweeper. Anything that could be swept, he sweeps disdainfully, both aerially and along the ground. Conveying an impression that he would offer him the length or line to sweep,



Kuldeep Yadav took four wickets against WI in the first ODI. BCCI

he tossed one up invitingly. Campbell failed to decipher the ruse; he swept fatally. He was too committed into the stroke that, he could not adjust to the sudden drop, the extra bounce

from his over-spun ball. A horrible miscue was the only outcome.

A partnership that seemed to march on endlessly ended with a piece of entrapment that

was more about his subtlety than the spectacular. When he first burst through, Kuldeep was all about magic balls and mystique. Theatrical turn, dazzling bounce, snaky drift, jaw-dropping drop, he was made for reels. But as his career unfolded, more gifts unfolded. The heart for fight, the grit for retooling, and the wits to evolve. He is more self-contained, and hence more dangerous. Spinners, historically, ripen with age, and 30-35 period is often when they hit their peak, discover the balance between offensive and defensive bowling, when they resist the experimental urges of youth but are not yet ravaged by aching shoulders.

The team management wouldn't budge on Bumrah, despite his non-utility with the bat; they shouldn't on Kuldeep either. Like the fast-bowling

totem, he can define the game with a spell. If he pulled the game away from the visitors with his thrift in the first burst with a spell of 6-0-26-1, when West Indies were strolling at six runs an over, in the second, he went for the jugular. His figures read 3-1-10-3. The single reason West Indies did not cross 300 after scoring 174 in 30 overs.

Sucker punch

He sucker-punched West Indies with centurion Justin Greaves' wicket, after he had ejected Shai Hope. He lured him into a wild slog by pushing his length, bowling his wrong'un slightly fuller. The pace of the ball deceived him; the ball didn't bounce as much as he had judged and crashed onto the pad. Though the umpire refused his imploring, the decision was overturned on review. A noticeable pattern in recent

times in his inclination to keep the ball within the stumps, thus enhancing the deceptiveness of his googly.

A wicket off the next ball — Keacy Carty caught at slip off a fullish googly — shoved West Indies into a familiar implosion. A fifth scalp eluded him, but his numbers shone as brightly as the skin-peeling sun over the arena. Kuldeep is not a bowler who could be appreciated through numbers. But some numbers, in the context of the game, are revealing. More than half of his deliveries were dots (34). He conceded only four runs an over, two boundaries and a six; the next thriftiest was Ravindra Jadeja's 5.4. He wore many guises, the strangler, enforcer and aggressor. And furnished a memo of his immense value that shouldn't lose its shine in the search for batting utility.